



HT SELECT

From the edge of extinction, bustards take fledgling steps

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BARMER/AHMEDABAD: Not very long ago, the Great Indian Bustard (GIB) ranged across a vast swathe of India, from Punjab in the north to Tamil Nadu in the south. Today, fewer than 150 remain in the wild, confined largely to pockets of Rajasthan's Jaisalmer and Kutch in Gujarat.

The decline has been driven by two major threats.

The first was the loss of its grassland habitat. Dry grasslands, the natural home of the bustard, were often classified as wasteland, leaving them vulnerable to takeover by government agencies and encroachment. The resulting neglect degraded the habitat, reducing the prey base and depleting water sources.

The second, and more recent, threat came with the rapid expansion of high-voltage transmission lines and windmills across the bustard's remaining habitat. Unlike many other birds, bustards have excellent peripheral vision to detect predators but relatively poor front vision. When flying, they can fail to detect overhead power lines and collide with them, often fatally.

"Degradation of grasslands along with hunting contributed in a major way in decline of the GIB population. Their habitats have shrunk to less than 10% as compared to 1960s. In the last two decades, the high voltage lines connecting wind mills and solar farms to the grid in western Rajasthan and Gujarat overlap with Bustard traditional homes, and is a reason for death



(Above) Environment minister Bhupender Yadav and forest officials release two Great Indian Bustards at the Desert National Park, in Jaisalmer district, Rajasthan. PTI



of large number of bustards," said MK Ranjitsinh, former Union environment secretary.

In 2021, the Supreme Court banned laying of overhead new power transmission lines in 99,000 square km area of GIB habitat in Rajasthan and Gujarat to save them. Years later, the SC relaxed the guidelines by reducing the area to about 14,000 square kilometers and providing more time to lay the underground lines.

In 2016, the Government of

India started a project to revive Rajasthan's state bird, the Great Indian Bustard, through captive breeding in Jaisalmer. By June 2026, the captive population had reached 98, of which 38 were born through artificial insemination.

On Sunday, that effort entered a new phase when two captive-bred GIBs were released into the wild at the Desert National Park, at Sam in Jaisalmer.

"With this, we have entered a new era of GIB conservation," said Ashok Singh, assistant conservator of forest at Jaisalmer.

But releasing a bird is one thing. Making it survive in the wild is another. The birds underwent extensive rewilding training at a specially designed facility costing ₹9.25 crore at the GIB Conservation Breeding Centre at Ramdevra.

Inside the tunnel, captive-

bred birds are exposed to natural sunlight, temperature variations and airflow and were made to hunt the prey — insects and other natural foods — and find water, Singh said.

If they survive, the experts from Wildlife Institute would monitor their reproduction in wild to revive the GIB population. "If that happens, we could say that the project was successful," said an expert from the Wildlife Institute.

The information gathered from the first release will be important in determining how future captive-bred GIBs should be trained and released. It will also help scientists assess whether birds raised in captivity are capable of establishing themselves in the wild without prolonged human assistance, said WII official Mahesh Gurjar.

He added that use of artificial

continued on →9

Whataboutery can't justify mass voter exclusions: Justice Bhuyan

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NEW DELHI: Any exercise that leads to the disenfranchisement of millions of Indian citizens, making them "second class citizens in their own country" by denying them the right to vote, is "intrinsically arbitrary", Supreme Court judge Ujjal Bhuyan said on Sunday, delivering a scathing constitutional critique of mass voter exclusion amid the controversy over the Election Commission's special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

"No amount of whataboutery can justify it," said Justice Bhuyan, warning that such a process would strike at the very heart of the Constitution and amount to "a negation of the constitutional order which we have adopted under the Constitution of India".

The judge's remarks at the valdictory address of the 19th NAL-SAR-Justice BR Sawhney Memorial Moot Court Competition in Hyderabad come as the SIR exercise faces mounting legal and political scrutiny.

Justice Bhuyan warned against any administrative exercise that undermines the constitutional guarantee of adult suffrage. He argued that the right to vote is not a mere statutory entitlement but a constitutional right integral to citizenship and the democratic order. →P5



Security personnel detain people during a protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in Delhi on Sunday. ARVIND YADAV/HT

Anti-CEC stir continues in Delhi amid detentions

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NEW DELHI: Security officials and protesters clashed for at least three hours in central Delhi on Sunday, the third consecutive day of protests against chief election commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls. Over 120 people were briefly detained as police

reiterated that no permissions had been given for the demonstrations. While protesters alleged that they had been man-handled, police said they used minimum force.

Delhi Police deployed around 5,000 personnel, including those from the Rapid Action Force (RAF) and other paramilitary forces. Prohibitory orders under Section 163 of Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) have been in force since July.

THACKERAYS LEAD MARCH IN MUMBAI; ORGANISERS BOOKED

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) president Raj Thackeray on Sunday led a protest march in Mumbai against CEC Gyanesh Kumar. The Mumbai police registered an FIR against the organisers of the march, saying it was held without the requisite permission. →P5

SUMMARY REVISION OF U.P. ROLLS AHEAD OF NEXT YEAR'S POLLS

The Election Commission will launch a special summary revision (SSR) of electoral rolls in Uttar Pradesh ahead of next year's assembly elections. SSR is a routine exercise likely to be launched in October–November. The final voter roll will likely be out in January, said officials. →P5

KERALAM MIN ORDERS INQUIRY AGAINST CEC OVER '06 ROAD PROJECT

Keralam home minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday ordered a Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) inquiry against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in a 2006 case of alleged irregularities over a road project when the IAS officer was the secretary of the state public works department. →P5

THERE WILL BE NO MILITARY SOLUTION TO WEST ASIA WAR, SAYS ARAGHCHI

TEHRAN: Iran's top diplomat insisted on Sunday that there would be no military solution to the United States' war against the Islamic republic, with talks on ending the conflict apparently at an impasse.

"If our enemies again choose the path of military confrontation, our response will be stronger than before, and we will defend ourselves with even more force," Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi said.

"There is no military solution, nor any solution based on new sanctions," he continued, adding "only negotiations based on justice and fairness" could end the conflict. →P11

Capital punishment only if reformation is ruled out: SC

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NEW DELHI: The death penalty can be imposed only in cases where the possibility of a convict's reformation is completely ruled out, the Supreme Court has held, underlining that the possibility of reform cannot be presumed absent merely because a crime is exceptionally brutal or grotesque.

According to a bench of justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi, the prosecution must establish that life imprisonment is unquestionably inadequate as an alternative to capital punishment,

COURT COMMUTED DEATH SENTENCE OF MAN CONVICTED OF SEXUALLY ASSAULTING HIS STEPDAUGHTER REPEATEDLY AND MURDERING HER

and that the death sentence must be reserved for cases where the alternative of imprisonment for life is demonstrably foreclosed.

The ruling highlighted the distinction between the gravity of a crime and the separate

question of whether the person who committed it is beyond reform — a distinction the law requires courts to examine before taking away a life.

Applying this principle, the bench commuted the death sentence of a man convicted of repeatedly sexually assaulting his six-year-old stepdaughter and murdering her in 2018. The court, however, directed that he remain in prison for the remainder of his natural life, without the possibility of remission, holding that this was an appropriate punishment given the gravity of the crime.

In the present case, it said, continued on →9

NUMBER THEORY

Beyond the medals: India's growing chess footprint

By [howindialives.com](#)

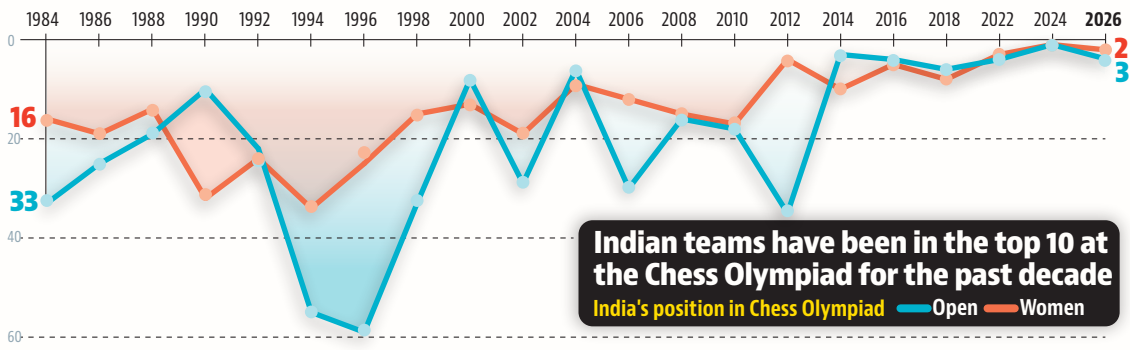
The Indian teams in the Open and women's sections of the Chess Olympiad missed out on retaining their titles by narrow margins in Samarkand, finishing the tournament with silver and bronze medals respectively. The final results, however, tell only part of the story, with India's showing at the tournament over the years reflecting a larger transformation in its chess fortunes. From once being on the fringes of the elite group, India has become a leading contender on the global stage.



Middlers to elite

Over the last four decades, Indian chess has undergone a significant structural shift, one expression of which is its showing at the Chess Olympiad, which is held every two years. Following Viswanathan Anand's Olympiad debut in 1984, India operated largely as a mid-tier competitor, frequently ranking outside the top 20 through the 1980s and 1990s. For context, both sections had 100 teams each at

this year's event. Over the past decade, however, India has established itself as an elite chess power, with its teams both in the Open and women's sections consistently finishing in the top 10 across the last five Olympiads, including a historic double-gold in Budapest 2024, reflecting a pipeline of top-class players built on Anand's pioneering legacy.



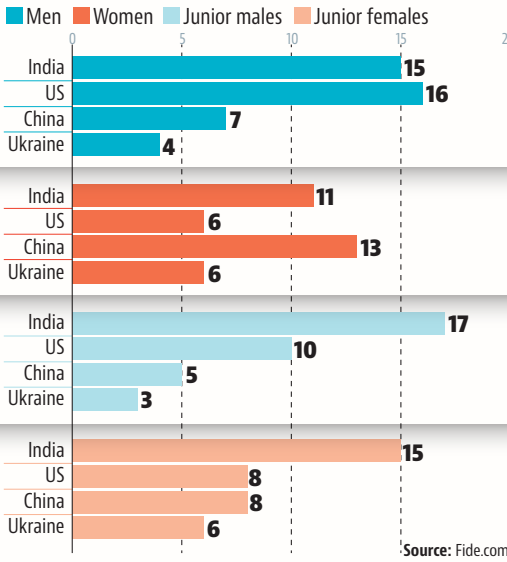
Note: 1. Data since 1984, when Viswanathan Anand made his debut at the Chess Olympiad. 2. Graph on inverted scale. Source: olimpbase.org

Strength in numbers

India is not only competing at the top level in adult divisions, but also possesses an unmatched reserve of men and women junior players. As of September 2026, among the top 100 players in each of the four categories (a total of 400 players), India has 58 — the most among all nations. The next best is the US (40 players), followed by China (33 players).

India has a healthy presence in the top 100 in all four categories

NUMBER OF PLAYERS IN THE TOP 100, AS OF SEPTEMBER 2026



India's count is well distributed across age and gender brackets. It's next only to the US among men and second to China among women, and leads among junior (aged under 20 at the start of a calendar year) categories. This massive youth concentration highlights a robust ecosystem for talent generation and youngsters taking to chess in large numbers. Across the four categories, India also has the highest presence among the top 10 — 11 players — including R Praggnanandhaa and Arjun Erigaisi among men, Koneru Humpy among women, and World Champion D Gukesh among juniors. It is followed by the US (six players) and China (five players).

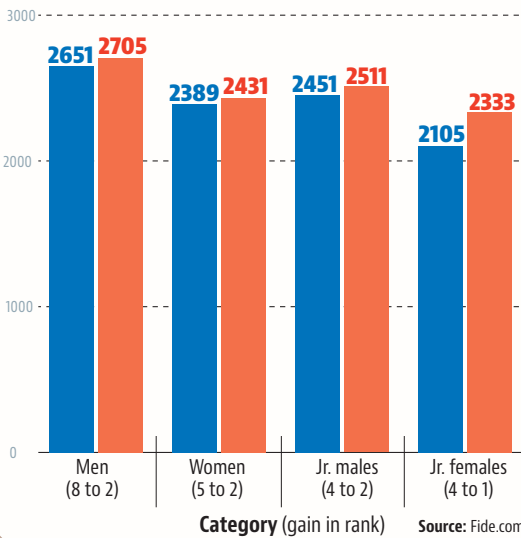
Relative gains

India's ascent in the past decade is not just about the numbers. It's also how Indian chess players are faring relative to the competition. A numerical capture of that is the ELO rating, a dynamic measure that incorporates both a player's performance and the calibre of the competition. Between January 2015 and September 2026, the average ELO rating of India's top 10 players saw remarkable gains across all four categories. Among men and women, it's a largely stable list. Seven countries in men and eight in women featured among the top 10 in both January 2015 and September 2026. What's striking is that only the US and India made gains in the average ELO rating figure for their top 10 players during this period, among men and only India among women. This is also a period that has seen greater adoption of structured academy training, integration of AI chess engines and digital training tools, and greater sponsorship supporting international tournament exposure.

India is among the top 2 on average ELO of its top 10 players in all categories

AVERAGE ELO RATING OF TOP 10 INDIAN PLAYERS

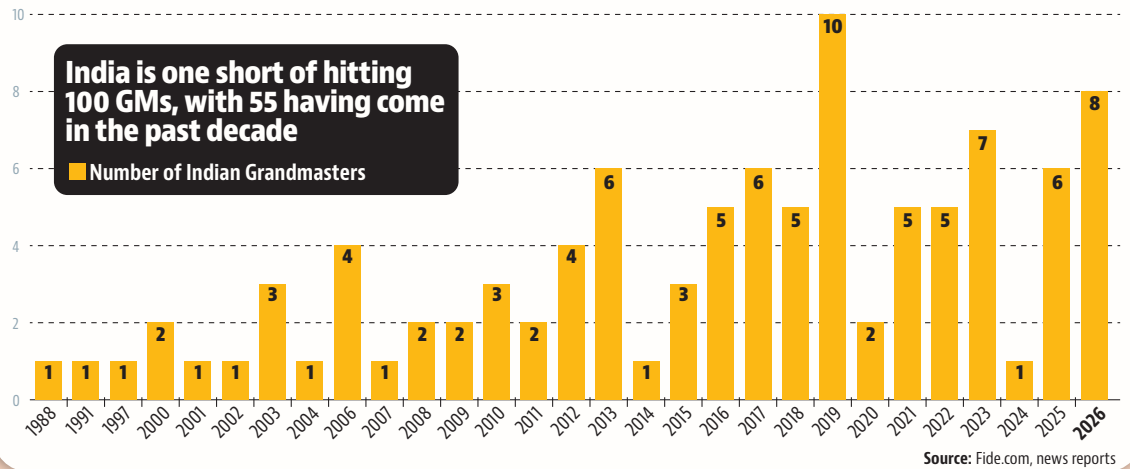
■ January 2015 ■ September 2026



Grand designs

The surge in numbers and quality is also translating into more grandmasters (GMs). Anand was India's first GM in 1988. Since then, India has added 98 more, including 55 in the past decade alone. That's an average of 5.5 per year in the last 10 years, against 2-3 for Russia and 1-2 for China. The year 2019 saw a single-year record for India of 10 new GMs, complemented by strong additions in 2023 and 2026. While Russia holds the record for cumulative GMs (255), followed by the US (110), India is currently the

fastest-growing nation in GM production. Russia's historic lead stems from decades of massive state funding, chess academies, and widespread popularity during the Soviet era, producing world champions such as Mikhail Tal, Anatoly Karpov, Garry Kasparov and Vladimir Kramnik. India is currently turning a massive junior participation base into top players at a rate unseen since the Soviet era and boasts the highest concentration of teenage and sub-20 GMs in world chess today.





Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Land of the rising stars: Indian team bids Japan farewell



Athletes from India march in the closing ceremony for the Asian Games in Nagoya, Japan on Sunday. India ended the event on a high, finishing with 85 medals overall — 21 gold, 27 silver and 37 bronze.

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AP

MOST POLLUTED START TO OCT IN 6 YEARS AS DELHI AQI CREEPS UP

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NEW DELHI: Air quality in the national capital continued to deteriorate for the fifth consecutive day on Sunday with the city logging its most polluted start to October since 2020, according to official data. This comes ahead of the city's annual pollution scourge, when a toxic blanket of smog chokes the Capital.

According to Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) 4pm data, the city recorded an average air quality index (AQI) of 187, firmly in the "moderate category". It was the worst AQI in the past 82 days. The city recorded an AQI of 171 on Saturday, 174 on Friday, 166 on Thursday, and 129 on Wednesday when air quality started worsening.

Final airline audits this week ahead of US checks

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NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) will begin a final round of inspections of all Indian airlines this week, ahead of the US Federal Aviation Administration's (FAA) audit of India's safety oversight, officials told HT.

"Two rounds of inspections, majorly focusing on operations of Air India and Indigo, were conducted in August and September. The final round of inspections however will cover all airlines," one of the officials aware of the development said.

The inspections will largely focus on the operational and safety standards maintained by the airlines, officials said. A third official said the "special" or

TWO ROUNDS OF INSPECTIONS WERE CONDUCTED IN AUGUST AND SEPTEMBER. THE FINAL ROUND WILL COVER ALL AIRLINES

"final" inspection would be completed by the end of the month.

"Airlines have been informed about the pre-FAA inspections," another official said. "Some serious observations were noted in the previous two inspections which were raised with the concerned airlines for them to immediately take the needed action and inform about the same."

The observations were not disclosed, but airlines had responded, said people aware of the matter.

The DGCA is also preparing replies to an FAA questionnaire. "The DGCA will also submit a set of questionnaires asked by the FAA. These replies are attached with evidence and will be submitted to the US regulator before their arrival," an official said.

These roughly 200 questions will be answered before FAA arrives in India.

"The DGCA visits different departments within the airlines to ensure that there are no lapses. The process is time-consuming, as inspections at each airline can take several days to complete," a former airline official said.

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US choosing to be 'lonelier power'; China rising: EAM

HT Correspondent and agencies

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NEW DELHI: External affairs minister S Jaishankar on Sunday highlighted the changing dynamics of global geopolitics, which he said were marked by the US "deliberately becoming a lonelier power" and China rising on the world stage, as he stressed the need for middle powers to deepen cooperation and push for self-reliance.

He added that competition between nations, not limited to the US and China, has led to a



S Jaishankar

"weaponisation of any leverage" that a country has.

"...The landscape today is primarily marked by a radical repositioning of the United States. A repositioning which is a posture

of choice, and, in a way, it has deliberately become a lonelier power. The second feature of the landscape is, of course, the rise of China," he said at the Munich Leaders Meeting in New Delhi.

He added: "That competition today, not limited to these two countries, has led to a weaponisation of any leverage that any country has. And that competition coexists with the complexity of interdependence."

His comments come against the backdrop of escalating conflicts — from the Russia-Ukraine war to the West Asia crisis — as

continued on →9

'INDIA HAS NOW GONE BEYOND ADVOCACY TO END UKRAINE CONFLICT'

India has gone beyond its advocacy of the past few years and engaged in conversations with Russia and Ukraine in recent months to end the war between the two countries, external affairs minister S Jaishankar said on Sunday in the first public acknowledgement of New Delhi's initiative to address the conflict.

"...We have [had] conversations with both Russia and Ukraine in this regard. We are trying to be helpful, starting with the Black Sea, [the] safety of shipping issue," he said.

→P2

IIT-D STUDENT DIES 46 DAYS AFTER SUICIDE ATTEMPT; POLICE FILE CASE

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NEW DELHI: An Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi student died on Saturday at AIIMS Delhi, 46 days after he was found unconscious and injured after allegedly trying to die by suicide at his accommodation, police said. This is the third such death of an IIT Delhi student this year.

The student was a PhD scholar and lived at a rented accommodation in Munirka Village, where he was found unconscious on August 18. A case was registered on Sunday under BNS section 108 (abetment of suicide).

GST 2.0 reforms set for rollout this week

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NEW DELHI: The Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council which meets this week will seek to complete the GST reform process that started with a rate rationalisation last year by considering sweeping process reforms that include scrapping the provision that empowers tax officials to arrest alleged defaulters, people familiar with the matter said.

The move towards GST 2.0, as the government terms it, may also allow taxpayers to make changes or corrections directly in their sales statements to avoid disputes, introduce a single



Nirmala Sitharaman

annual tax return for small consumer businesses, simplify the registration process with a three-day deadline, and use data analytics to automatically approve 90% of low-risk refund claims without requiring physical paperwork, the people added asking not to be named.

→P6

AMBULANCE TAKING U.P. JAWAN'S BODY HOME CRASHES, 3 OF FAMILY KILLED

LUCKNOW: Four people, including three from the family of an Indian Army Subedar, were killed when the ambulance carrying the soldier's body rammed into a truck on an expressway in Sultanpur district of Uttar Pradesh on Sunday, officials aware of the matter said.

Sultanpur district magistrate Indrajeet Singh said Subedar Satyawar Singh, who had undergone a kidney transplant, was receiving treatment at the Command Hospital in Chandigarh, where he died three days ago. The deceased included the soldier's son, brother, nephew and the ambulance driver, the officials added.

→P8

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{ WORLD } AHEAD OF FLYDUBAI ATTACK
UAE shared details of flight with Israel



Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the flydubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection. With the investigation underway, preliminary details about the incident have highlighted several major security lapses. Officials already have said the Omani co-pilot had been barred from flying by his own country because of concerns about his extremist views. It also remains unclear how a citizen of Oman, an Arab nation that has no diplomatic relations with Israel, was allowed to fly a plane loaded of Israelis to Tel Aviv. The regional officials said Emirati authorities had shared information about passengers and crew, including their nationalities. Israel hadn't raised red flags on any passenger or member of the crew, they said. —PTI

{ MY INDIA } IN WEST BENGAL
CM: Law against 'love, land jihad' in 6 mnths'



West Bengal chief minister Suvenudh Adhikari on Sunday said his government will bring stringent laws against "love jihad" and "land jihad" in six months, and implement a Uniform Civil Code in the state like Uttarakhand and Gujarat. Addressing an event here to mark the birth centenary of Vishva Hindu Parishad's (VHP) former president Ashok Singhal, he said the BJP government in the state would function in accordance with the Constitution, but would not tolerate attacks on Indian culture, tradition and places of worship. "This government will not allow any anti-national activity here," he said and urged people to remain united and vigilant against "divisive forces". "Give us six months, will also bring stringent laws against love and land jihad," the chief minister told the gathering. —PS

{ MY INDIA } VOTING ON OCTOBER 16
RS polls: BJP names Mallick from WB, Arya from U'khand



The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday announced names of its candidates for Rajya Sabha polls, fielding Rukmini Mallick from West Bengal and Dinesh Arya from Uttarakhand. Elections to 12 Rajya Sabha seats across Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and West Bengal will be held on October 16. The last date for filing nominations is October 6. The election from Uttarakhand was necessitated due to MP Nareish Bansal's term coming to an end on November 16. Meanwhile, Mallick will be contesting for the seat from the eastern state, which was left vacant after she resigned as a Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP on July 16. With Mallick's exit, the Mamata-led TMC's strength in the Rajya Sabha came down to nine. In Uttarakhand, Arya serves as the vice-chairperson of the state drinking water monitoring committee. "I thank CM Pushkar Singh Dhami, for choosing an ordinary party worker like me for such a significant responsibility," Arya said. —PS

{ WORLD } TO HEAD TASK FORCE
Intelligence chief Jay Clayton is US AI czar



President Donald Trump on Sunday tapped Jay Clayton, his director of national intelligence, to lead a new government task force on artificial intelligence. Trump is calling it the "Super Intelligence Force" because he has tried to rebrand AI as "super intelligence." The announcement comes after Trump hosted top executives of AI companies at the White House last week and said they had signed a voluntary accord that would effectively self-police the development of the technology. The task force will coordinate the federal effort "to ensure that America continues to lead the World in Super Intelligence, which many say is bigger than the Industrial Revolution and the Internet, and will protect the interests, and improve the lives, of all Americans," Trump said in a post on social media. AP

{ WORLD } SCHOOLS RANSACKED
French schools to be shut amid protests



Up to 500 schools across France will be totally or partly closed on Monday because of a wave of student protests that has shaken the country, the education minister said. Lessons will be "totally or partly suspended" in some "400-500" high schools as the security conditions "have not been fulfilled," said Education Minister Edouard Geffray on Sunday, adding that 24 schools had been "burned or ransacked" since the start of the movement. The students say their school hours are excessively long, conditions inadequate including overheated classrooms, and that there are too many staff absences. The government says the grievances are legitimate but has condemned what it has described as "urban violence". Students have accused police of using excessive force and causing injuries by regularly firing tear gas canisters to disperse the protests. AFP

EAM: India going beyond advocacy to end Ukraine war

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NEW DELHI: India has gone beyond its advocacy of the past few years and engaged in conversations with Russia and Ukraine in recent months to end the war between the two countries, external affairs minister S Jaishankar said on Sunday in the first public acknowledgement of New Delhi's initiative to address the conflict.

Jaishankar's comments came two days after Ukrainian foreign minister Andrii Sybiha said Kyiv has received ceasefire proposals from four countries, including one from India that is "most comprehensive", and three days after Russian President Vladimir Putin said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has "excellent ideas" aimed at mutually acceptable solutions. Sharing limited details of the Indian initiative at the Munich Leaders Meeting in New Delhi, Jaishankar said it is focused on the safety of shipping in the Black Sea as ensuring grain and energy exports. He noted that India had taken a clear position on ending the conflict through dialogue and diplomacy.

"We have been advocating it for many years, and in recent months we have got a little bit more involved beyond advocacy," he said. "We have conversations with both Russia and Ukraine in this regard. We are trying to be helpful, starting with the Black Sea, [the] safety of shipping issue."

India, he said, is also "going beyond that to cover some immediate concerns which [Russia and Ukraine] have on grain exports, energy exports, non-attack possibilities". He added: "Those are ongoing conversations right now."

Modi met Putin on the margins of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Kyrgyzstan in August and called for a shift from endless war to the end of war. The Ukraine conflict figured again in a meeting between Modi and Putin ahead of the Brics Summit in New Delhi last month. Modi also met Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky on the margins of the G7 Summit

in France in June.

In early September, Jaishankar travelled to Ukraine, days after the meeting between Modi and Putin in Kyrgyzstan, and emphasised that the conflict cannot be resolved on the battlefield and that India stands ready to help in all efforts to end the war.

Jaishankar also spoke at Sunday's event on India's long-standing positive ties with Russia and its burgeoning relationship with the European Union (EU).

"India and Russia have historically had very good relations, particularly since the 1950s. That history is not forgotten," he said. "For us, Russia, and the Soviet Union before that, was a country that stood by us in many ways when our security, when our territorial integrity was under threat."

Without directly naming Pakistan, Jaishankar said that at a time when many countries "preferred backing a military regime next to us", Russia had very good relations with India and this legacy shapes the current relationship.

The India-Russia engagement has also significantly widened. "It is very much more today an economic relationship as well. There is a military component, there are space issues, but there is a significant amount of trade and investment between the two countries, and energy and resources as well," he said.

At the same time, there is a compelling case for a wider relationship between India and Europe, with the possibility of enhanced cooperation in advanced manufacturing, semiconductors, space and defence, Jaishankar said. There is also a convergence of the positions of India and Europe on artificial intelligence (AI), while European countries have become more open to Indian talents, he said.

At the multilateral level, India and the EU are part of initiatives to shape the world, such as the Partners for Multilateralism (P4M), which wants to ensure a better United Nations, Jaishankar said.

Yemen moves to retake Houthi-held territories

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TAIZ/SAANAA: Yemen's leader announced on Sunday the start of a new military operation to retake all territory held by the Houthis, even as the group made fresh gains on the ground, effectively encircling a government-held city.

The announcement sets an ambitious goal for the embattled government, which recently lost swathes of the country's Red Sea coastline and areas around the Bab al-Mandab Strait — a choke-point for international shipping — after a lightning offensive by the Iran-backed Houthis.

Yemen's government has struggled to roll back the surge, even with the military support of Saudi Arabia, where the Houthis said they had attacked oil infrastructure in the capital yet again on

Sunday.

"I announce today the start of military operations to retake the remaining territories of the republic and extend the authority of the state and its institutions across the entire national territory," Rashad al-Alimi, the head of Yemen's presidential council, said.

Alimi called on all the armed forces "to begin carrying out their assigned missions, in accordance with the approved plans, until the country is liberated from the grip of the Houthi terrorist militia".

Yemen's Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree on Sunday said the group launched a ballistic missile and drone attack on Saudi energy giant Aramco's sites in capital Riyadh and the oil-rich Khurais area.

"Both operations successfully achieved their objectives," the spokesman said on X.

Gold class: India's trailblazing podium toppers

A late gold medal surge — 11 in the final two days — helped India achieve their second-best medal tally in the Asian Games. The 85 medals at Aichi-Nagoya was only next to the record 106 in 2023 Hangzhou. India also won medals in 22 events for the first time in Games history. Here's a look at some of the path-breaking gold medal performances:

GOLF

Pranavi Urs
(Women's individual stroke play)

Pranavi Urs became the first Indian woman to win an Asian Games gold in golf. Lakshman Singh (1982) and Shiv Kapoor (2002) were the only two Indians to win gold since golf became part of the Games in 1982. Pranavi (23) finished at 15-under 265, one stroke ahead of Singapore's Shannon Tan and China's Yin Ruoning. Ruoning, a six-time LPGA winner and the 2023 Women's PGA Championship Major champion, took the silver medal after she beat Shannon in a playoff.

TRAP SHOOTING

Neeru Dhanda
(Women's individual and mixed team)

Neeru Dhanda (26) scripted history by becoming the first Indian woman to win the individual trap gold. She shot 28 points, an Asian record score surpassing the previous mark of 24, set by China's Liu Wan-yu in January. Five Indian male shooters had won medals in trap at the Asiad, but only Randhir Singh had won gold, way back in 1978. Neeru then paired with Kynan Chenai to win India's first-ever mixed team trap gold with an Asian record score.

PISTOL SHOOTING

Kamaljeet Singh and Suruchi Singh
(10m air pistol mixed team)

India put up an overall ordinary show at the ranges, but began and finished the events with historic performances. Kamaljeet Singh and Suruchi Singh won gold in the 10m mixed team pistol with an Asian record score. It was India's first Asiad gold in the event, improving on the silver won by Sarabjot Singh and Divya TS at 2023 Hangzhou.

ARCHERY

Kumkum Mohod
(Women's individual and team)

Kumkum Mohod (17) ended South Korea's long-standing dominance in Asian Games archery, becoming the first Indian to win an individual recurve medal in the sport's 48-year history at the Games. Earlier, she had teamed up with Ankita Bhakat and Kirti Sharma to end another South Korean monopoly on the gold medal.

DOUBLE HOCKEY WIN

Harmanpreet Singh and Salima Tete
(Men's and women's)

For the first time, India have completed a hockey gold double, winning both the men's and women's titles. It has earned them direct berth in the 2028 LA Olympics. The women beat holders and Paris Olympics silver medalists China in the final. The men survived a scare from Pakistan in the semi-final, but dominated Malaysia 5-1 in the final.

{ 11 WOMEN'S GOLDS, 3 IN MIXED EVENTS }

Women who raised the bar, set the standards

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NEW DELHI: Kumkum Mohod, 17, stood next to Korean recurve archer Oh Yejin, beaming after having vanquished the Olympic champion. Pranavi Urs walked back from a historic golf gold almost matter-of-factly, after downing China's Yin Ruoning, World No 6, a Major champion, and winner on the tour the previous week.

They looked assured, confident and certain that they belonged — the kind of conviction that comes after pulling off a major upset.

India's women have increasingly fought for and earned their space, both on and off the field. And, now, they are doing so on the podium too.

At the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Indian women arrived at very different points in their careers — from teenagers such as Anahat Singh and Kumkum, established stars such as Mirabai Chanu and Lovlina Borgohain, and a 36-year-old Suchika Taryial who refused to give up on her desire to win an Asiad medal.

Together, 234 women were in the 495-strong squad that was at the Games.

India returned with 85 medals (21 gold, 27 silver, 37 bronze). Women's events

accounted for 38 of them, the same number as men's events, with nine medals coming from mixed competitions. But what was most remarkable was the view from atop the podium.

Out of the 21 gold medals India won, 11 came from women's events and three from mixed ones.

In 2023, India earned nine golds from women's events, 15 from men and four from mixed events.

Behind the medals were women who endured long waits and ended them, grew up hearing of records and then broke them, bemoaned their setbacks and returned, overcame illness and injury, and in some cases simply refused to let personal traumas and systemic hurdles halt their journeys.

The women's cricket team set the ball rolling by winning India's first gold.

Soon after, Mirabai Chanu's silver ended a 28-year wait for an Indian weightlifting medal at the Asian Games, the country's first since Karnam Malleswari's silver at 1998 Bangkok. Vithya Ramraj won bronze in the 75kg category made her only the second Indian woman boxer, after Mary Kom in 2014, to win an Asian Games gold.

Three years after her 57kg bronze from Hangzhou was struck off following a whereabouts failure — a suspension that also cost her a chance to go



(From left) Squash player Anahat Singh, boxer Lovlina Borgohain, MMA athlete Suchika Taryial. PTI & AP



to the Paris Olympics — boxer Parveen Hooda returned in a new division (65kg) and won gold.

Trap shooter Neeru Dhanda completed a medal treble, carrying a body that had given her every reason to worry. She had been hospitalised shortly before the Games after a bout of Influenza B. She became the first Indian woman to win an Asian Games individual trap gold.

Ancy Sojan had a different battle in the months before the Games. The long-jumper has spoken about dealing with Polycystic Ovary Syndrome (PCOS) — the health condition makes training and maintenance of

weight for an athlete whose sport demands explosiveness and a carefully managed body very challenging. She still cleared 6.53m for silver, missing gold by two centimetres.

Suchika Taryial's route to the podium was different. Sport had, in part, become a response to abuse and trauma as a child. At 36, she stood on the Games podium with bronze in mixed martial arts (MMA), a sport that was making its debut in Japan.

There are also lessons to learn from sporting powerhouses like China and the USA, who dominate Olympic sports. In the 1990s, China began a

state-sponsored project to produce athletes who will win gold medals.

As a result, parity was ensured in women's sport. It was both unlearning a lot of systematic and gender-based prejudices but also extremely strategic.

A deliberate focus on women's sports because they tend to be underfunded in other countries became the way forward. The outcome is there to see. China emerging as a sporting powerhouse in the 2000s ensuring their programme was successful.

In 2026 too, China, unsurprisingly, have the most medals at the Asian Games, with 341 overall. At the Paris Olympics, 56% of the medals came from Chinese women. Similarly, the US women contributed 53.97% of their medal share in Paris.

For India, Aichi-Nagoya offered a view of what sport can look like when women get the opportunity to compete — teen-aged and middle-aged, established and emerging, individual stars and team players, women who have had smooth journeys and those who have had to claw their way back.

And they could, like other sporting powerhouses, tap into a trend that is waiting to be unlocked.

It is becoming amply clear that sustained investment in women's sport can boost a country's medal tally.

MY BENGALURU

BJP threatens agitation over Form 7 cases across K'taka

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BENGALURU: The BJP on Sunday threatened a statewide agitation if police take legal action against its workers over bulk filing of Form 7 applications during Karnataka's Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, escalating the political fight over alleged attempts to delete voters.

Former chief minister and senior BJP leader BS Yediyurappa issued the warning after a party delegation led by him met director general and inspector general of police MA Saleem and sought protection for workers facing police cases. The delegation included state BJP president B Y Vijayendra, Leader of Opposition R Ashoka, Council Opposition leader Chavadi Narayanaswamy, MPs, MLAs and MLCS.

"No legal action should be taken against our workers under any circumstances. They should not be arrested, harassed or assaulted. If this continues, we will launch a statewide agitation," Yediyurappa said.

He alleged that police were acting at the behest of chief minister DK Shivakumar and said officers should act according to law rather than work to please the government.

The BJP's intervention came as police registered another case linked to the Form 7 controversy in Bengaluru.

Vyalikaval police have registered an FIR following a complaint by Congress leader Anoop Iyengar over 778 applications seeking deletion of voters in the Malleswaram Assembly constituency.

GS Vasanthalakshmi, identified in the FIR as a BJP member, has been named accused No. 1. Another person, described as being associated with an RSS wing, has been listed as an unidentified accused. The complaint alleges that the applications sought deletion of voters who had in fact cast their votes, by describing them as having shifted residence or as otherwise ineligible. The 778 applications were spread across eight polling parts.

Ashoka defended the submission of Form 7 applications



BS Yediyurappa

and said the validity of individual applications should be decided by election authorities. "Submitting Form 7 is not a crime. It is the Election Commission, not the police station, that has to determine the truth and validity of a voter," he said.

The BJP's warning follows a direction from Karnataka chief electoral officer V Anbukumar to electoral registration officers in all 224 Assembly constituencies to act against applicants who knowingly make false statements or declarations in Forms 6, 6A, 7 and 8.

In a circular issued on October 1, Anbukumar directed

EROs to take action under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, after an inquiry under Rule 20 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

The directive came hours after Shivakumar led a sit-in at the state election commission office in Bengaluru and sought an FIR and a time-bound investigation into alleged bulk filing of Form 7 applications.

He alleged that pre-printed applications were being used to target eligible voters, particularly from minority, Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe and Other Backward Class communities.

Shivakumar said the state government had not ordered a separate investigation because the Election Commission was already examining the allegations.

"Details about where the application forms were printed and how they reached the BJP are coming to light. The truth has become clear to the Central Election Commission. Let us see what action it takes. We will take a decision thereafter," he said.

Shivakumar also rejected the BJP's criticism of his interaction with the election commissioner, saying he had raised the issue through legal channels rather than staged an unlawful protest.

"I did not stage a protest before the election commissioner and violate any law. I only brought the issue to the commissioner's notice through legal means. What is wrong with that? They had sought time to discuss the matter, and we questioned why more time was required. Eventually, a solution was found. Where is the question of a protest?" he said.

He also said he was prepared to face a case if he had violated the law.

"If I have committed any wrongdoing, let a case be registered against me. The BJP is making such statements under pressure from its leadership. The law is the same for everyone. If I have disturbed public peace or violated the law, a case can be registered against me. These statements are being made for political reasons," he said.

'Vijayi Bhava' rally



Participants take part in the 'Vijayi Bhava' tricolour flag rally organised by the Yuva Brigade to pay tribute to India's armed forces, scientists and engineers in Bengaluru on Sunday.

K'taka seeks ₹7.5k-crore for drought losses: Dy CM

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BENGALURU: Karnataka has estimated losses of about ₹46,000 crore from the first two phases of its drought and is seeking around ₹7,500 crore from the Centre under its prescribed relief norms, deputy chief minister and revenue minister G Parameshwara said on Sunday.

The figures were presented to a Central drought assessment team led by Ajit Kumar Sahu, joint secretary in the Union agriculture ministry, which has begun a four day inspection of drought affected areas. The team has been split into three groups to visit North Karnataka, Central Karnataka and other parts of the state, with field assessments continuing until October 6.

The first memorandum put the losses at about ₹18,000 crore, for which Karnataka sought nearly ₹3,700 crore in relief. A second assessment covering 77 additional drought affected taluks estimated another ₹27,000 crore in losses, with the state seeking about ₹3,500 crore.

Parameshwara said Karnataka had confined its demand to what is allowed under the Centre's drought relief guidelines and had not sought additional assistance outside those norms. "If we had sought additional funds outside the prescribed norms, there could have been grounds for rejection. But the State has assessed its losses and sought relief strictly in accordance with the guidelines laid down by the Union Government," he said.

He urged the Central team to assess the damage based on conditions during the four months of deficient rainfall rather than allowing recent



G Parameshwara

showers to alter the assessment.

"The State has already suffered around 82% crop loss. Rainfall over the past two or three days will not benefit crops that have already been damaged. Nor has there been enough rain to resolve drinking water concerns. Apart from helping some grass grow in a few places, the recent rainfall offers little benefit," Parameshwara said.

He added that the rainfall deficit recorded during June, July, August and September and the resulting crop damage would remain central to the assessment.

According to the revenue department, 217 of Karnataka's 240 taluks have now been declared drought affected. An October 1 order added 40 taluks, including 24 classified as severely affected and 16 as moderately affected. Ground truthing will be carried out in the remaining 23 taluks, and those meeting the prescribed criteria will also be declared drought affected.

The state told the Central team that about 49 lakh farmers had enrolled for crop insurance. Officials also provided details of crop damage, drinking water availability, reservoir and lake storage, fodder supplies, input subsidy and steps to prevent

distress migration.

Parameshwara said water was being conserved in reservoirs for drinking purposes rather than released for irrigation. The government has also undertaken works generating about 1.27 lakh person days of employment in drought affected areas. He said the state expected the Centre to provide relief based on its assessment rather than assuming that the request would be rejected.

"We must fulfil our responsibility. We declared drought and submitted memoranda by following the Union Government's own guidelines. We will neither assume beforehand that relief will be denied nor prejudice the Centre's decision. We are asking only for the relief that Karnataka is legally entitled to under the prescribed norms," he said.

The appeal comes as Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge has separately asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi to intervene in the drought situation. In a letter to Modi, Kharge said Karnataka had recorded a 58% rainfall deficiency as of September and that all 31 districts had been affected.

Kharge said more than 31 lakh farming families faced livelihood losses, with crop damage assessed across 19.52 lakh hectares at ₹18,748.23 crore. He put the overall economic loss at about ₹40,000 crore and warned that the drought could become the worst in 150 years.

Parameshwara said Karnataka hoped to avoid another legal battle over drought assistance. The state had previously approached the Supreme Court after failing to receive the relief it said was due.

"We hope such a situation will not arise and that the Union Government will provide Karnataka the relief it is entitled to," he said.

Positive IOD may ease rain deficit in K'taka

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BENGALURU: Karnataka's interior districts recorded temperatures up to 4.3°C above normal on Saturday, even as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecast rain across parts of the state from Sunday.

Bagalkot recorded the highest departure from normal, with the maximum temperature reaching 34.6°C, or 4.3°C above normal. Dhawad recorded 33.2°C, 4.1°C above normal, while Chitradurga's a maximum of 33.2°C was 3.5°C above normal.

Kalaburagi was the hottest among the state's reporting stations, recording 35.7°C, which was 3°C above normal. Raichur recorded 35°C, while Vijayapura and Bidar recorded 34.5°C and 34.4°C respectively.

The heat was also pronounced along the coast. Karwar recorded a maximum of 34.6°C, 3.3°C above normal, while its minimum temperature was 27.6°C, also 3.2°C above normal. Honnavar recorded a minimum of 25°C, 1.5°C above normal.

In Bengaluru, the maximum temperature was 30.1°C, around 1°C above normal. The minimum temperature at the Bengaluru airport station was 20.5°C, also around 1°C above normal.

The rise in temperatures comes as the southwest monsoon enters its withdrawal phase and weather conditions begin shifting towards the northeast monsoon. The IMD has forecast heavy rain in coastal Karnataka from Sunday to Tuesday and in

south interior Karnataka on Monday and Tuesday.

The weather department has also forecast thunderstorms and lightning over parts of north interior Karnataka on Sunday and Monday. South interior Karnataka is expected to receive thunderstorms on Sunday, followed by rain and thunderstorms on Monday and Tuesday.

CS Patil, a scientist at IMD Bengaluru, said large scale weather conditions could support rainfall later in the season despite the current heat.

"If you look at the climatological history, a strong positive Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD), a climate pattern in the Indian Ocean that can influence rainfall over India, can offset the hot and dry conditions associated with El Niño and bring rain later in the season," Patil said.

The Indian Ocean Dipole refers to differences in sea surface temperatures between the western and eastern parts of the tropical Indian Ocean. During a positive IOD phase, waters near the Arabian Sea tend to be warmer while waters near Southeast Asia are cooler. This can alter atmospheric circulation and push more moisture towards peninsular India. "During a positive IOD phase, sea surface temperatures on Southeast Asian side become cooler, while temperatures in Arabian Sea region become warmer. These conditions influence atmospheric circulation patterns and bring more moisture towards peninsular region, resulting in enhanced rain," he said.

Bhalki man among 7 booked for radicalising state youths

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BIDAR: Karnataka police have booked seven people in Bidar, including a 24-year-old man from Bhalki taluk and three Pakistan-based nationals, for allegedly using WhatsApp and Instagram to communicate with members of banned terrorist organisations and illegal arms traffickers, officers said.

Bidar police had registered an FIR at Khatak Chincholi police station on October 1, naming Vishalkumar Vijaykumar Metre, 24, of Yenkor village; Pakistan-based nationals Shahzad Bhatti, Rana Hunain and Nomi Khan; Ashu Sharma of Mainpuri in Uttar Pradesh; and Raj Bhai alias Lucky Singh of Madhya Pradesh. One other person has also been named in the case.

Bidar superintendent of police Pradeep Gunti told HT that Metre was arrested on Saturday and produced before a court. "The accused was found to be in contact with people involved in illegal arms trafficking and members of banned organisations," Gunti said.

The case was registered on a complaint by Hanamareddyappa, circle police inspector, Bhalki Rural Circle. Police said they received information around 3 am on October 1 that Metre was allegedly using Instagram and WhatsApp to commu-

THE ACCUSED WAS FOUND TO BE IN CONTACT WITH PEOPLE INVOLVED IN ILLEGAL ARMS TRAFFICKING AND MEMBERS OF BANNED ORGANISATIONS

nicate with people involved in the purchase and trafficking of illegal weapons.

A police team reached Yenkor village around 3.30 am and found Metre sleeping outside his house, according to the complaint. A preliminary examination of his mobile phone allegedly showed WhatsApp conversations with Shahzad Bhatti, whom police identified as a Pakistan-based designated terrorist, as well as Rana Hunain and Nomi Khan.

Police alleged that the conversations involved the sale and trafficking of illegal weapons. Rana Hunain is also accused of sending Metre links to private WhatsApp channels named "Rahe Haq" and "RANA BHAI 333". Investigators alleged that Metre joined the channels and viewed posts and videos they described as prejudicial to the unity, integrity and sovereignty of India.

The FIR also alleges that

Metre was in contact with Sharma and Raj Bhai over illegal arms trafficking. Police have alleged that his activities continued since December 2025 and involved associations with organisations threatening India's unity and integrity.

Gunti said the investigation was focused on establishing the extent of Metre's involvement. "We are examining the digital evidence and his communications with the other accused. We are also trying to establish whether any weapons were actually procured or trafficked".

The case has been registered under Section 18 (terrorist acts), Section 20 (terrorist membership) and Section 39 (terrorist support) of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967, along with Section 61(2) (criminal conspiracy) read with Section 3(5) (common intention) of the BNS.

Police said they were examining the accused's mobile devices and digital communications to determine the extent of his contacts and activities. The allegations in the FIR have not been established in court.

Gunti said police surveillance of social media platforms had been intensified following cases in which extremist elements allegedly used WhatsApp and Instagram to establish contact with young people and facilitate illegal activities, including arms smuggling.

{ POLLUTED WATER ENTERS LAKE }

Thousands of fish die in Doddagubbi lake

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BENGALURU: Thousands of fish have died in Doddagubbi Lake, a 125 acre water body in Bengaluru's Mahadevapura Assembly constituency, after polluted water entered the lake during recent rains, with officials suspecting a sharp fall in dissolved oxygen.

Dead fish were found floating across several parts of the lake and along its edges, leading fisheries officials and the Karnataka State Pollution Control Board (KSPCB) to collect water samples. The samples have been sent for laboratory testing, which will determine the nature and extent of the contamination.

B Chikkanna, deputy director of the fisheries department in Mahadevapura ward, said the initial assessment pointed to asphyxiation caused by oxygen depletion. "Prima facie, the fishes died due to asphyxiation. Due to the rains, a large quantity of rainwater mixed with polluted water from Mittaganahalli GBA dumping yard entered Doddagubbi Lake, causing a shortage of oxygen," he told HT.

"We have launched an investigation and taken samples," Chikkanna said.

KSPCB regional officer K S

Sudhakar said the lake appeared to be heavily contaminated during the initial inspection. The board has sent the samples to its laboratories for testing.

"We have taken water samples from the lake. We have already sent them for testing to our labs. Prima facie, it seems highly polluted and unfit for any kind of usage," Sudhakar said.

Bengaluru deputy minister Krishna Byre Gowda has directed officials to inspect the lake and take corrective measures. The fish deaths have also brought attention to the drainage network around the lake and the possibility of sewage entering the water body during rainfall. Environmental activists have alleged that untreated sewage may have entered the lake and worsened its water quality.

Former KSPCB chairman Dr Sharath Chandra said untreated sewage can rapidly reduce oxygen levels in a water body. Organic matter in sewage is broken down by microorganisms, which consume dissolved oxygen in the process. If oxygen levels fall sufficiently, fish can no longer survive. Officials are expected to examine the drainage network around the lake alongside the laboratory testing to establish how polluted water entered the lake.

Agencies

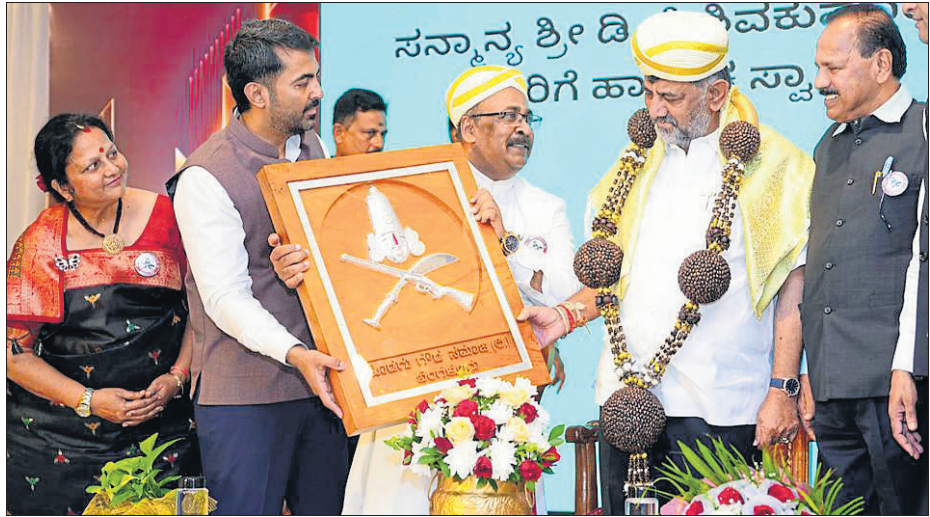
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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday urged people from the Coastal and Malnad regions to build businesses in their hometowns instead of migrating elsewhere for employment, highlighting the state government's special tourism policy for the regions. Addressing the Kail Muhurat Jambara 2026 event at the Kodagu Gowda Samaja Hall in Ullal, Bengaluru, Shivakumar said the policy was aimed at creating opportunities for local people to become entrepreneurs by leveraging the region's natural resources, tourism potential and cultural heritage.

"Instead of migrating elsewhere for jobs, people of the Coastal and Malnad regions should start businesses in their own hometowns utilising local natural resources. To empower you, the Congress government has formulated a special Tourism Policy for the Coastal and Malnad regions," he said.

Shivakumar, who spoke about the importance of preserving roots, culture and heritage, said people from Kodagu residing in Bengaluru should remain connected to their hometown and contribute to its development.

"All of you have come from Kodagu and are residing in Bengaluru. If you forget your roots, you will not achieve success. Just as roots are essential for a tree,



CM DK Shivakumar being felicitated during the inauguration of the Kyle Muhurta Jambara 2026 program at the auditorium of Bengaluru Kodagu Gowda Samaj in Bengaluru on Sunday.

faith is essential for a human. It gives me immense joy to see you all come together, building such a magnificent structure by bringing together your culture, hometown, heritage, and community. My congratulations to everyone who worked hard and encouraged this effort," he said.

Highlighting Kodagu's history and its contribution to the state, Shivakumar said the district has a rich legacy of valour, culture and spirituality.

He also spoke about the Cauvery river and the rainfall situation in the Malnad region. "Kodagu has a history in the fields of valour, culture, and spir-

ituality. We can never forget its history of raising heroes in every household. Mother Cauvery, who originates here, feeds us all the way to Puducherry. This time, there has been a severe drought. Even Malnad region has lacked rainfall this year. I am anxiously waiting for lakes and KRS dam to fill up," he stated.

Shivakumar said the state has decided to conduct Cauvery Aarti annually and emphasised need to preserve Kodagu's heritage while creating better educational and employment opportunities locally. "I have decided to conduct the Cauvery Aarti every year, and instructions have been

issued to celebrate it during the Dasara festival this year as well.

Kodagu district is the Kashmir of Karnataka. The entire world is attracted to this region. Preserve your heritage; it is a great human quality. In my own experience, people migrate from villages to cities for education and livelihood. If education and employment were available in the villages, you would not have come here. You are organising yourselves and trying to do good for the village people, and you have presented several demands to me," he said.

On the government's tourism initiatives, the chief minister

said a separate tourism policy had been formulated for the Coastal and Malnad regions following a special Cabinet meeting in Mangaluru. He said the government intended to utilise Karnataka's coastline for tourism while creating opportunities for local entrepreneurs.

"We recently held a special cabinet meeting in Mangaluru, where a separate tourism policy was formulated for the Malnad and Coastal regions. The talent of the people from this region must be recognised. People from this district have left their mark in sports and the defence sector. Educational institutions and banks were established in the Coastal region, but they have now declined. Protecting them is our duty. It has been decided to utilise the 327 km-long coastline for tourism, similar to Goa and Kerala," he noted.

The CM said the government wanted to attract investment and develop tourism infrastructure in Mangaluru, Udupi and Karwar, while creating opportunities for people from the region. "Looking at Mangaluru, Udupi, and Karwar, there isn't even a single five-star hotel. I do not wish to talk politics about why this happened. It is our desire to want to talk politics about why this happened. It is our desire to contribute during our tenure. We are not permanent in politics. God gives neither blessings nor curses. He only gives opportunities. What we do with the opportunities is what matters," he said.

DKS, DEPUTY CM CONDOLE DEATH OF FILMMAKER SRINIVASA RAO

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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar and his deputy G Parameshwara on Sunday expressed their grief over the death of veteran filmmaker Singeetham Srinivasa Rao, saying his demise was an irreparable loss to the film industry.

Rao, who won accolades for his remarkable movies in Kannada, Telugu, Tamil and Hindi films including 'Halu Jenu', 'Panthulamma', 'Mayuri' and 'Pushpakam Vimana', died at Kavery hospital in Chennai on Saturday night due to age-related ailments. He was 95.

In his message, Shivakumar recalled that Rao gave Kannada cinema a new dimension through his outstanding films and directed popular, critically acclaimed movies.

"Singeetham's silent film Pushpakam Vimana is a milestone in Indian cinema and a testament to his unique talent. Singeetham, who maintained a close association with the Kannada film industry, remained devoted to cinema until his last breath," he said in his statement.

Deputy CM in a post on 'X', expressed his sorrow. "Singeetham Srinivasa Rao, who was recognised in Indian cinema for decades for his creativity, innovative experiments and distinctive style of storytelling, has left the world of cinema poorer with his demise," Parameshwara said.

SOUTH REGION

Keralam orders probe into case linked with Gyanesh

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Keralam home minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday ordered a Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) inquiry into alleged irregularities in a 2006 road construction project and the suicide of a Malaysian engineer when current Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was the then secretary of the public works department.

Chennithala said the probe was ordered after he received a complaint on Saturday from Malayankkeezhu Venugopal, a Congress leader and member of the party's state executive.

The investigation will be a continuation of a preliminary VACB inquiry conducted in 2006, which got stalled after Kumar left the state on a central deputation that year, the minister said.

The inquiry will probe corruption and bribery allegations linked to the upgradation of MC Road, a 240-km-long arterial road connecting Thiruvananthapuram and Ernakulam districts, under the Kerala State Transport Project (KSTP), implemented by the Indo-Malaysian consortium PATI-BEL and supported by the World Bank. Kumar then served as the public works department (PWD) secretary, overseeing the project.

The allegations arose following the death by suicide of Malaysian national Lee See Been, the chief project officer of



Ramesh Chennithala and Gyanesh Kumar



PATI-BEL, in Kuala Lumpur on November 11, 2006, said the minister.

"Two suicide notes were written by Been, one to PATI director and another to his wife. Gyanesh Kumar was named in one of the suicide notes," said Chennithala.

Responding to questions about the allegations, Chennithala said they included demands for money to clear bills and delays in payments allegedly linked to corruption.

"I haven't seen the suicide note myself; this is information reported through the media," he clarified.

The home minister said a preliminary probe was ordered under then Left Democratic Front (LDF) government of VS Achuthanandan in 2006 and saw Kumar being summoned from the PWD department.

"Shortly after, he earned a deputation to Delhi and left Keralam. He never came back to the state, and the probe fizzled out," said Chennithala, who added that legal advice was sought by

the State government before ordering the present inquiry.

"The investigation pertains to an incident from the time he served as the PWD Secretary of Kerala in 2006. Therefore, he will not get the protection attached to the post of Chief Election Commissioner," he said.

Venugopal alleged that there were repeated delays to the road modernisation project which had propelled PATI-BEL to write complaints to then State government.

"Been had come to the State several times to meet top PWD officials urging them to clear his bills on time. He was under tremendous pressure from the sub-contractors. The treatment meted out to him by then PWD officials was extremely bad, and he died by suicide in Kuala Lumpur. Kumar was among the PWD officials who were named in the suicide note," said Venugopal.

CPI(M) leader TM Thomas Isaac and finance minister in the 2006-11 LDF government, wel-

comed the vigilance probe and said the country needed to know what happened in 2006.

"The case files of the 2006 vigilance probe should be with the department. They must be examined. As far as I know, PATI-BEL did not want to continue with the project at the time and was uncomfortable with the company's name being maligned by a corruption probe. But today, the circumstances are different and people can come forward with any evidence they have," the former minister told local media.

India Union Muslim League (IUMML) leader M K Muneer, who was the PWD minister in 2006 when Kumar served as the secretary of the department, said he welcomes the decision to investigate the circumstances leading to the engineer's death and called for a comprehensive probe into the matter.

"The incident that led the PATI-BEL engineer associated with KSTP to commit suicide must be subjected to a comprehensive investigation. When that is investigated, all other related matters should also be looked into," he said.

The inquiry against Kumar comes as he faces growing allegations of taking unilateral decisions within the Election Commission. Opposition parties and outfits, including political pressure group Cockroach Janta Party staged protests demanding his resignation from the post.

(With PTI inputs)

Bypolls: Vijay appeals voters to support govt

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and TVK founder C Joseph Vijay on Sunday appealed to voters in Madurantakam and Dharapuram to continue supporting his administration's "honest and corruption-free" governance as the campaign for the bypolls came to an end.

The high-octane campaign turned into a fierce battle of words with the DMK and AIADMK attacking the four-month-old government.

DMK president MK Stalin slammed the ruling party over alleged cash-for-votes schemes and administrative failures, while AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami accused TVK of relying on fraudulent tactics and unethical means out of fear of defeat.

The bypolls will be on October 6 and the counting of votes will take place on October 9.

Stating that it was now time for him to express his gratitude to the people who showered with unprecedented love in the recent Assembly election, and appointed him as their primary servant (Chief Minister), TVK chief Vijay said, "No amount of thanks can truly measure up to the people of Tamil Nadu who established a genuine and conscientious democracy."

He further said, "The present administration is one led by you, the people of Tamil Nadu. To ensure this government continues and grows even stronger, we will always need your continued support."

Stating that the reception



Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay during a roadshow on Sunday for the upcoming Dharapuram Assembly constituency by-election. PTI

extended to TVK by the people of Chengalpattu district, as well as Coimbatore and Tiruppur districts during the byelection campaigns were truly beyond measure, Vijay said, "They will remain etched in his heart forever." Further stating that TVK will never compromise on anything when it comes to safeguarding public welfare, he said, "We will forever maintain an honest, corruption-free administration backed by a conscientious democracy, just as we do today." Meanwhile, DMK chief Stalin claimed that cash distribution was taking place through tiffin carriers and pointed out that even parties extending support to the government from outside were now accusing the ruling party of trying to buy votes in whole streets.

He further alleged that TVK's self-proclaimed status as a "pure force" had lost credibility within a mere four months.

In his statement, Palaniswami alleged that during the recently concluded Assembly elections, TVK resorted to various fraudulent tactics and, despite lacking

the necessary majority to form a government, has been running a "minority administration" with the support of other parties.

"Out of fear of defeat, TVK members are indulging in unethical means and alluring promises to secure votes, a ploy well understood by the public," he said, and alleged, "It is an undeniable truth that the electorate will teach a fitting lesson to these two candidates contesting on TVK tickets after betraying the party's victory."

"When I campaigned across various places seeking votes for our party candidates in Madurantakam and Dharapuram, the spontaneous gathering and enthusiastic reception from the voters clearly demonstrated that the victory of AIADMK candidates was already sealed," he claimed.

The elections were necessitated following the resignation of then-sitting AIADMK MLAs K Maragatham Kumaravel and P Satyabama from Madurantakam and Dharapuram, respectively, before joining the Vijay-led party.



Udhayanidhi Stalin

FIR FILED AGAINST UDHAYANIDHI FOR INVOLVING MINOR IN POLL CAMPAIGN

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

DHARAPURAM: Tiruppur police have filed a case against DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin for allegedly involving a minor in an election campaign, officials said on Sunday.

The case was filed under the Representation of the People Act and the Juvenile Justice Act, officials added.

According to police officials, the incident occurred during a campaign rally near the Periyar statue in Dharapuram town on Saturday.

Udhayanidhi allegedly brought a minor boy onto a campaign van and handed him a microphone. The boy reportedly made disparaging remarks against Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay.

The Dharapuram Town Police have registered a First Information Report (FIR) against the DMK leader under Section 123(1) of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, and Section 83 of the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015.

Authorities stated that the involvement of a child in campaign activities is also a direct violation of Election Commission guidelines. Further investigation into the matter is underway, police added. The DMK has not yet released an official statement regarding the charges.

Fishermen protest in Chennai



Fishermen raise black flags and raise slogans during a protest against the state government's proposal to establish a new Secretariat at Pattinapakkam in Chennai, Tamil Nadu on Sunday. PTI

CM Naidu, Chouhan lay foundation for 300k welfare houses

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BURRIPALEM: Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Sunday laid the foundation for the construction of 300,000 welfare houses across the state under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) 2.0 scheme.

The leaders joined a beneficiary family in laying the foundation for their house construction in Burripalem village in Guntur district, which will be built using three-dimensional (3D) printing technology, a first-of-its-kind in the country.

"Chief Minister Chandrababu joined Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan in laying the foundation for the construction of three lakh houses across the state," said an official release.

Chouhan assured the beneficiary family in Burripalem that a durable house will be constructed for them at the lowest possible cost at the earliest time.

Naidu underscored that the new house would incorporate the latest technology to ensure a cooler indoor environment.

Addressing a public meeting later, the CM said the state aimed to achieve 100 percent housing by 2029.

Houses built using this technology were expected to maintain indoor temperatures at least eight degrees Celsius lower than the outside temperature,



Union agriculture and farmers' welfare minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu during in Guntur district, Andhra Pradesh.

providing greater comfort to residents, he said.

"The Centre had initially sanctioned only 75,000 houses to Andhra Pradesh under the regular quota. However, following a special request, the Union Government had increased the allocation to three lakh houses," said Naidu.

He said Chouhan had agreed to sanction another three lakh houses as soon as the current batch was completed and further 300,000 houses next year, taking the total allocation to nine lakh houses.

Naidu said the coalition government was committed to ensuring that welfare and development reached all sections of the society.

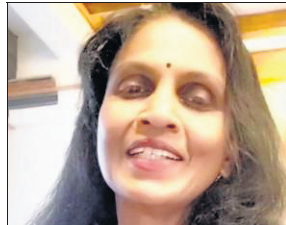
R Sreelekha to continue in BJP as Thiruvananthapuram councillor

Vishnu Varma

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which holds a razor-thin majority in Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation, said on Sunday that R Sreelekha, former DGP turned councillor, would continue in her post a day after she announced her resignation in a ward-level WhatsApp group.

Sreelekha's surprise resignation announcement on Saturday had sent state BJP leaders into a tizzy as it could potentially rock the party's power in the only municipal corporation it rules in the state. The BJP has 50 councillors in the 100-member corporation council along with the support of an independent.



R Sreelekha

On Sunday afternoon, Sreelekha deleted the message, relaying her resignation, in the official WhatsApp group, minutes after BJP leaders S Suresh and K Soman visited her in a hospital where she was undergoing treatment due to some health issues. However, the Sasthamangalam councillor has not formally issued a statement.

In a Facebook post, Suresh, the state general secretary, said

the news of Sreelekha's resignation was not true.

"For the past few days, Sreelekha has been battling some health issues. She had concerns that she could not serve her ward and it's people to the best of her abilities. She relayed the same to some people in her ward. Unfortunately, it led to a media discussion," he said.

The news of her resignation, he claimed, led to speculations that she was joining another party and deeply dissatisfied with the BJP.

Many even predicted the BJP's governance in the city administration to collapse, he said.

Suresh termed Sreelekha a fierce, anti-corruption crusader who funds development activities in her ward with her pension funds.

SRI LANKAN NAVY APPREHENDS NINE FISHERMEN FROM RAMESWARAM

Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

RAMESWARAM: The Sri Lankan Navy on Saturday apprehended nine fishermen from Rameswaram along with their fishing boat near Neduntheevu after claiming that their vessel had allegedly crossed the International Maritime Boundary Line, triggering unrest among fishermen in the coastal town.

According to officials, fewer than 400 boats had left the Rameswaram fishing port for fishing on Saturday.

Later in the evening, nine fishermen who were fishing near Neduntheevu were apprehended by the Sri Lankan Navy along with the vessel.

The latest apprehension has caused concern among the Rameswaram fishing community, with fishermen's representatives calling for immediate intervention by the Central and Tamil Nadu governments.

Karalmarks, President of the Fisherman Association, said the fishermen had ventured into the sea after obtaining the required pass permits from the Rameswaram town office and strongly condemned their arrest.

"Today, 9 fishermen and one boat, who had set out to sea after securing pass permits at the Rameswaram town office, were arrested by the Sri Lankan government. This is something that must be strongly condemned. It's unclear what the central and state governments are even doing," Karalmarks said. He urged both governments to intervene immediately to secure the release of the fishermen.

Won't tolerate misuse of Form-7 against Muslims, says Owaisi

Agencies

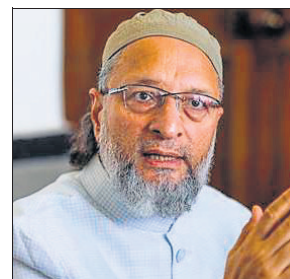
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: AIMIM president and Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi on Saturday warned of protests in Hyderabad over what he alleged was the filing of false Form-7 applications during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Addressing the 57th 'Jalsa-e-Milad-un-Nabi' at Milad Maidan on Saturday, Owaisi said the Election Commission should take action against those responsible if false Form-7 applications were being filed.

"If false Form 7 are being filed, we appeal to the Election Commission to take action against those responsible. If this drama does not stop, remember: protests bigger than those at Delhi's Jantar Mantar will take place on the roads and streets of Hyderabad, and it will create a lot of trouble for you. Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen will not remain silent," Owaisi said. Form-7 is used to raise objections to the inclusion of a name in the electoral roll or seek deletion of an entry on specified grounds.

Alleging that BJP and Sangh Parivar are misusing Form 7 to exclude Muslim voters from final electoral rolls, Owaisi said, "Printed Form 7 are being submitted where the name of the person whose name is to be deleted is mentioned, but the name and details of the person filing the form are not being provided. If this is happening, it is completely wrong."



Asaduddin Owaisi

He urged the Election Commission of India to take note of this.

"We are also informing the Chief Electoral Officer of Telangana and the District Electoral Officers that this cannot be allowed," he said.

Owaisi, earlier, alleged that the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is a "backdoor NRC" and claimed that the BJP would use the exercise to turn it into a test for citizenship.

Addressing a press conference on Thursday, Owaisi said his party had opposed the SIR from the beginning, alleging that the exercise would create problems and eventually be used as the basis for a National Register of Citizens (NRC).

He stated, "We are opposing it since the beginning. We have opposed SIR. We have opposed the selection of the election commissioner. If there is anyone in the country who has done this, then we did it in 2002. We did it in Maharashtra, Telangana, Uttarakhand and Delhi. No one else did it," Owaisi said.

Hyd: 380 drunk drivers booked in 2-day drive

Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Hyderabad Traffic Police booked 380 drivers for allegedly driving under the influence of alcohol during a two-day special drive conducted on October 2 and 3 to ensure road safety.

Of the 380 drivers booked, 343 were two-wheeler riders, 12 were three-wheeler drivers, and 25 were four-wheeler and other vehicle drivers.

According to the data released by Hyderabad Traffic Police, 80 cases were recorded with blood alcohol concentration (BAC) levels between 30 and 50, while 167 cases were in the 51-100 range.

A total of 77 cases were recorded in the 101-150 range, 39 in the 151-200 range, 12 in the 201-250 range, two in the 251-300 range and three cases involved BAC levels above 300.

Hyderabad Traffic Police said

there will be zero tolerance towards drunk driving violations and that the special drive will continue. Commuters have been requested to cooperate with Hyderabad Traffic Police.

Earlier, the Hyderabad City Police, through the Special Branch-Foreigners Monitoring Cell, in coordination with the Foreigners Regional Registration Office, local Law and Order Police and IT Cell Hyderabad, intensified identification and tracking of foreign nationals overstaying in India and violating visa and immigration regulations.

The operation was undertaken with the objective of strengthening verification of foreign nationals, ensuring compliance with visa conditions and preventing unlawful activities, while also creating awareness among the public and accommodation providers.

Muziris to be transformed into global heritage tourism: CM

Press Trust of India

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KOCHI: Kerala Chief Minister V D Satheesan on Sunday said that the Muziris project will be transformed into an international heritage tourism initiative. Speaking after launching Muziris boats at the North Paravur Thattukadavu boat jetty here, the CM said that the current boat service and kayaking will be extended to other places.

The Muziris Heritage Project is one of India's largest conservation initiatives undertaken by the Kerala government to revive the legacy of the legendary 3,000-year-old ancient port city of Muziris.

Satheesan said that the boat services and kayaking will be extended to Ezhikkara, Kottapuram, Azhikkode, as well as to three four constituencies and their beaches.



VD Satheesan

Kodungallur, Kaippamangalam and Vypeen areas will also be connected as part of this project, he added.

The Chavittunataka Kala Kendra and restaurants in Gothur that serve traditional food will be further developed, new museums and water sports facilities will be established, and star hotels and restaurants will be brought in Paravur, Kodungallur and nearby areas in collaboration with large hotel

groups, the CM said.

"Public participation will be ensured to create more employment opportunities for the locals and help local businesses grow. Under the leadership of the Tourism minister, major projects will be implemented in Muziris areas, including Alappuzha, on a priority basis," he said. Satheesan said that earlier the boat services that connected heritage centres through inland waterways were operating at great profit without any marketing, but they were discontinued.

"Now, the government has decided to bring more new boats to resume those services," he said.

He further said that the area between Paravur and Kodungallur has great historical heritage, which cannot be found anywhere else in the world, due to its relations with foreign countries 2,000 years ago..

Bypoll campaigns for 5 assembly, 1 LS seats end

Utpal Parashar and HT Correspondents

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KOLKATA/CHENNAI/GUWAHATI: Campaigning for six crucial by-elections — five assembly seats and one Lok Sabha constituency across three states and a Union Territory — ended on Sunday, with parties making a final push in what has become a key mid-term test for ruling parties.

Voting will be held on October 6 in Nandigram and Rejinagar in West Bengal; Madurantakam and Dharapuram in Tamil Nadu; Thattanchavady in Puducherry; and the Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency in Assam.

All six seats fell vacant after sitting legislators resigned following the April 2026 general and assembly elections, where several leaders won from two constituencies and later retained one.

The Nandigram seat fell vacant after chief minister Suwendu Adhikari retained Bhabanipur, where he defeated TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee, and vacated Nandigram.

Adhikari took out a foot march in Nandigram on Sunday for BJP candidate Hasirani Rath, mother of his slain close aide Chandra Nath Rath, as he attacked his predecessor over her leg injury.

He alleged the previous TMC government “misused” the CID to frame BJP leaders in an attempt-to-murder case following Banerjee’s “false claims” of a leg injury during the 2021 polls.

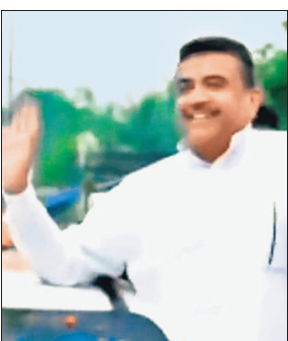
“Under the previous TMC government, the CID harassed BJP leaders entirely on falsehoods. Attempt to murder charges were framed against them even though official documents do not show any fracture,” he said.

Kunal Ghosh, TMC MLA, questioned the timing of Adhikari’s allegation. “Why is he making the claim on the eve of the bypoll?” He said.

Banerjee remained Adhikari’s foremost political rival even though her camp has no candidate in the bypoll.

Mamata’s TMC has extended support to Congress candidate Milan Pradhan after its nominee Sachinta Pradhan Dey withdrew following a meeting with Adhikari.

Rejinagar fell vacant after Humayun Kabir, founder of the Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP), retained Nawda after winning both seats. The bypoll will see AJUP’s Golam Nabi Azad, son of Humayun Kabir; TMC’s (Mamata faction) Rabiul Alam Chowdhury; TMC’s (Rita-



(Clockwise from top) Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay; Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma; and West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari during roadshows ahead of the bypolls.

BJP NOMINATES ARYA, MALLICK FROM U’KHAND, WB FOR RS POLLS



Rukmini Mallick, Dinesh Arya

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KOLKATA/DEHRADUN: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday announced the names of actor Rukmini Mallick, popularly known as Koel Mallick, for Rajya Sabha by-election in West Bengal and Dinesh Arya for biennial election to the Upper House from Uttarakhand.

Both the names have been approved by the BJP central election committee, the party said.

Elections to 12 Rajya Sabha seats across Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and West Bengal will be held on October 16. The last date for filing nominations is October 6.

The election from Uttarakhand was necessitated due to the completion of tenure of the incumbent MP Naresh Bansal, who will vacate the seat on November 25.

Meanwhile, Mullick will be contesting for the single Rajya Sabha seat from West Bengal which was left vacant after she resigned as a Trinamool Congress (TMC) lawmaker on July 16.

With Mallick’s nomination, the Mamata Banerjee-led party suffered another setback as the actor-politician will now be contesting the by-election as the BJP candidate.

With Mallick’s exit, the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC’s strength in the Rajya Sabha came down to nine.

With the BJP is in control of 208 of Bengal’s 294 assembly seats, Mallick’s victory appeared certain.

In Uttarakhand, Arya serves as the vice-chairperson of the state drinking water monitoring committee. By fielding Arya, the BJP has sought to reach out to the Dalit community ahead of the assembly polls in the state.

“I thank CM Pushkar Singh Dhami, for choosing an ordinary party worker like me for such a significant responsibility,” Arya said.

The actor did not make any comment to the media till late on Sunday.

BJP sharpens upper caste outreach ahead of UP assembly polls

Smriti Kak Ramachandran

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) will sharpen its overtures in the poll-bound Uttar Pradesh towards the upper castes, particularly the Brahmins, even as it will deploy its time-tested social engineering formula of relying on a broader coalition of non-dominant castes, people aware of the details said. This comes in the backdrop of intensifying tussle between political parties to consolidate the upper caste voters.

In the state, where caste is a key factor in determining preferences and electoral outcomes, the BJP has been building a constituency of non-dominant and marginalised castes, wooing them through social welfare measures as well as political representation.

“Over the years the BJP has benefited from the support of upper castes, particularly the Brahmins. And although their number is not as vast as the OBCs, they are critical from the electoral point of view,” said a functionary in the state unit.

The leader admitted that a bunch of issues such as the controversial University Grants Commission equity regulation that has been challenged in court; the complaint from UC of being overlooked for party and government positions has created a narrative that suggests they are cut up with the party.

“Earlier, the BJP was accused of being a Brahmin-Baniya (UC) party, when we started social engineering, a new coalition of supporters emerged which was



The BJP will organise meetings and events to bear the concerns of the upper castes.

seen as a counter to the consolidation of Muslim-Yadav voters for the Samajwadi Party or the Jatav voters for the Bahujan Samaj Party. While there is no discrimination or overlooking of the UCs, they will have a dominant role in this election,” the functionary quoted above said.

To begin with, the party will organise meetings and events with the “samaj” (castes) where their concerns will be heard, the functionary said.

He said the party is not worried by the Samajwadi Party (SP) redefining the “Pichda” to represent “Pandit” in its popular “PDA” or “Pichda, Dalit, Apl-sankhyak” outreach.

“Will the Brahmins want a CM who will overlook their concerns for Muslims and only the Yadavs? There is no threat to the Hindu vote bank, of which the Brahmins are a core group,” said the functionary.

Brahmins are estimated to be between 10% to 12% of the electorate, but wield clout in about 100 of the 403 assembly seats, particularly in central and eastern parts. They are traditionally counted as BJP supporters.

Minor at TN poll rally: Udhayanidhi booked

DHARAPURAM: Tiruppur police have filed a case against DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin for allegedly involving a minor in an election campaign, officials said on Sunday. Udhayanidhi allegedly brought a boy onto a campaign van and handed him a microphone. The boy reportedly made remarks against CM C Joseph Vijay. The police have registered an FIR under the Representation of the People Act, 1951, and the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015.

Raut, Dipke back protest, demand MPSC chair removal

PUNE: Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut and BJP founder Abhijeet Dipke on Sunday extended their support to aspirants agitating in Pune and demanded the removal of MPSC chairman. “This is the Jantar Mantar of Maharashtra,” Raut said. Dipke urged the protesters not to relent until MPSC chairman Rajesh Bhimanwar resigns.

Kharge approves three panels for TN Congress unit

CHENNAI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge has approved the immediate constitution of three committees for the TNCC — the Political Affairs Committee, the Advisory Committee and the Disciplinary Action Committee. In a press release, the party said that the panels will streamline operations and internal governance of TNCC.

{ JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN AMID S.I.R. ROW }

‘No amount of whataboutery can justify mass disenfranchisement’

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: Any exercise that leads to the disenfranchisement of millions of Indian citizens, making them “second class citizens in their own country” by denying them the right to vote, is “inherently arbitrary”, Supreme Court judge Ujjal Bhuyan said on Sunday, delivering a scathing constitutional critique of mass voter exclusion amid the controversy over the Election Commission’s special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

“No amount of whataboutery can justify it,” said Justice Bhuyan, warning that such a process would strike at the very heart of the Constitution and amount to “a negation of the constitutional order which we have adopted under the Constitution of India”.

The Constitution, he underlined, does not envisage two classes of citizens — those with voting rights and those without them.

The judge’s remarks at the valedictory address of the 19th NALSAR-Justice BR Sawhney Memorial Moot Court Competition in Hyderabad come as the SIR exercise faces mounting legal and political scrutiny, with the deletion of hundreds of thousands of names from electoral rolls, questions over the grounds for issuing verification notices and a huge backlog of appeals



Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

raising concerns over the risk of eligible voters being denied their franchise.

Justice Bhuyan warned against any administrative exercise that undermines the constitutional guarantee of adult suffrage. He argued that the right to vote is not a mere statutory entitlement but a constitutional right integral to citizenship and the democratic order.

“Theoretically, citizenship and franchise are intertwined; one cannot be divorced from the other,” he said.

In Delhi, petitioners have told the court that 4.75 million names were excluded from the draft electoral roll published on August 31, while another 3.31 million electors were identified for notices on grounds of “no mapping” or “logical discrepancies”. On September 22, a bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant sought the Election Commission’s response to pleas challenging the process and questioned the basis on which such notices were being issued. Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked the poll panel to examine

whether notices were being generated mechanically, while the CJI sought clarity on the meaning of “logical discrepancy”. The Commission assured the court that no voter would be deleted without following the prescribed process.

In West Bengal, the problem has extended beyond exclusion to the ability of affected voters to secure timely relief. The poll panel informed the Supreme Court in September that 2.22 million of the 2.71 million electors deleted through adjudication had appealed against their exclusion. Another 1.61 million appeals challenged the inclusion of voters, taking the total to 3.83 million. More than 3.7 million appeals remained pending, prompting the Commission to propose increasing the number of appellate tribunals from 19 to 42. The top court is scheduled to take up the matter on October 5.

Against this backdrop, Justice Bhuyan traced the constitutional promise of universal adult franchise to the freedom struggle and the Constituent Assembly’s decision to trust every adult Indian with an equal vote, irrespective of literacy, wealth, property or social standing.

The framers, he said, adopted universal suffrage despite the enormous administrative challenge and widespread illiteracy in the country. The decision was an act of faith in ordinary Indians and marked the first step towards achieving equality in a

society deeply divided by caste and economic status.

Invoking BR Ambedkar’s closing speech in the Constituent Assembly, Justice Bhuyan recalled the warning that India would enter a life of contradictions, with political equality coexisting with social and economic inequality. The principle of “one man, one vote and one value”, he said, was a facet of equality and the very essence of the Constitution.

A billionaire and a rickshaw puller have votes of equal value, he said. So do a socially privileged temple priest and a person compelled to work as a manual scavenger. Universal adult franchise was the Constitution’s transformative promise that every citizen would have an equal voice in choosing those who govern.

Justice Bhuyan located that promise in Articles 325 and 326 of the Constitution. While Article 325 mandates a single general electoral roll for every constituency and bars exclusion on grounds only of religion, race, caste or sex, Article 326 provides for elections to the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies on the basis of adult suffrage, subject to constitutionally recognised disqualifications.

The emphasis, he said, was on “every citizen of India”. Unless a citizen is disqualified on grounds recognised under Article 326, the person is entitled to be registered as a voter.

Scrap SIR, return to ballot paper: Thackerays at rally

Saurabha Kulshreshtha

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MUMBAI: Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray on Sunday demanded the scrapping of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls while his cousin and Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of using power to pursue political vendettas.

The two leaders were addressing the ‘Virat Garjana Morcha’ rally in south Mumbai, along with other opposition leaders, against the alleged irregularities in SIR and to press the demand for the removal of chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Apart from seeking the removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, Raj Thackeray, who addressed the rally first, also demanded the scrapping the SIR and a return to holding elections with ballot papers. “Our demand is that the entire SIR conducted in Maharashtra should be cancelled,” he said. “There should be only ballot paper voting.”

Uddhav Thackeray said that Sunday’s gathering was not part of any particular political party’s agenda, but a fight to protect the nation, democracy and the Constitution. “Gyanesh Kumar is a weapon of the BJP,” he said.

Congress’s Balasaheb Thorat said, “We have a historical responsibility to save democracy and the Constitution. Let us unite for it.”

Hitting out at the opposition leaders, Maharashtra cultural affairs minister and BJP leader Ashish Shelar mocked the joint protest, calling it a ‘kolhekai morcha’ (march of foxes).

Meanwhile, the Mumbai police registered an FIR against the organisers of the protest march, saying it was taken out without the requisite permission. “An offence has been registered at the Azad Maidan police station against the organisers for conducting today’s morcha without requisite permission,” DCP Manish Kalwaniya said.



Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and MNS chief Raj Thackeray during the ‘Virat Garjana Morcha’ rally in Mumbai on Sunday.

ANSHUMAN POYREKAR/HT

Keralam asks Vigilance to probe 2006 suicide case linked to Gyanesh

Vishnu Varma

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Keralam home minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday ordered a Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) inquiry into alleged irregularities in a 2006 road construction project and the suicide of a Malaysian engineer when current Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was the then secretary of the public works department.

Chennithala said the probe was ordered after he received a complaint on Saturday from Malayankkeezhu Venugopal, a Congress leader and member of the party’s state executive.

The investigation will be a continuation of a preliminary VACB inquiry conducted in 2006, which got stalled after Kumar left the state on a central deputation that year, the minister said.

The inquiry will probe corruption and bribery allegations linked to the upgradation of MC Road, a 240-km-long arterial

road connecting Thiruvananthapuram and Ernakulam districts, under the Kerala State Transport Project (KSTP), implemented by the Indo-Malaysian consortium PATI-BEL and supported by the World Bank. Kumar then served as the public works department (PWD) secretary, overseeing the project.

The allegations arose following the death by suicide of Malaysian national Lee See Been, the chief project officer of PATI-BEL, in Kuala Lumpur on November 11, 2006, said the minister.

“Two suicide notes were written by Been, one to PATI director and another to his wife. Gyanesh Kumar was named in one of the suicide notes,” said Chennithala.

Responding to questions about the allegations, Chennithala said they included demands for money to clear bills and delays in payments allegedly linked to corruption.

“I haven’t seen the suicide note myself; this is information reported through the media,” he clarified.



Yogi Adityanath

YOGI: BHADOHI RENAMED TO SANT RAVIDAS NAGAR BHADOHI

VARANASI: Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday announced that Bhadohi district has been renamed Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi.

Addressing a gathering in the district after inaugurating and laying foundation stone for various I12 projects, the chief minister said, “Now, our Bhadohi district will be called Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi.”

“On the occasion of Guru Purnima, the government had said that Bhadohi district, currently known for its carpet industry, would in the future be known by the name of Satguru Ravidas ji Maharaj, a medieval saint who united society through his spiritual devotion,” Adityanath said.

Bhadohi was a part of Varanasi district before it became the 65th district of the state on June 30, 1994.

The district has undergone several name changes, with the last such exercise carried out on December 6, 2014, when the Akhilesh Yadav-led Samajwadi Party government changed its name back to Bhadohi from Sant Ravidas Nagar-Bhadohi.

On July 29 this year, Adityanath announced that the Bhadohi district would once again be renamed Sant Ravidas Nagar, as the ruling BJP kicked off a Dalit outreach initiative from the Prime Minister’s parliamentary constituency, Varanasi.

At Sunday’s event, the chief minister also announced that the Kashi Naresh PG college has been given the status of a university. “When students get degrees from here, they will get degree from Kashi Naresh University, Sant Ravidas Nagar,” Yogi added.

HTC

EC to hold special revision of voter rolls ahead of UP polls

Rajesh Kumar Singh

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LUCKNOW: Amid a raging controversy over deletion of millions of voters during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in various states, the election commission is likely to hold a special summary revision (SSR) of voter rolls in Uttar Pradesh ahead of the assembly elections in the state, people aware of the matter said on Sunday.

The SSR exercise is likely to be launched in October-November, they added, but did not provide any specific dates.

The Election Commission is likely to release the voter list for

the 2027 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections in the first week of January. Ahead of the 2022 elections, an SSR was conducted in the state. The final voter list was published on January 5, 2022.

After the SIR concluded in April in Uttar Pradesh, the final electoral rolls had 133.9 million voters, shrinking by 13.24%, compared to 154.4 million voters listed in the electoral rolls published on October 27, 2025, after a special summary revision.

Both SIR and SSR are essentially revision of electoral rolls. However, while SSR is an annual exercise usually taken up ahead of elections, SIR is conducted in decades, the people said.

ALTHOUGH SPECIFIC DATES WERE NOT ANNOUNCED, OFFICIALS SAID THE SSR IS LIKELY TO BE LAUNCHED BETWEEN OCTOBER AND NOVEMBER

The Election Commission of India has announced a ‘no voter to be left behind’ campaign across 20 states where SIR has been completed to address alle-

gations of indiscriminate deletions of voters.

The drive is aimed at re-enrolling any genuine or eligible citizens whose names were accidentally omitted during the recent voter list clean-up exercises.

“SIR has already been completed in 20 States/UTs. Any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter, and any person including young/ first-time voter, may apply to the concerned ERO, for inclusion of their names in the electoral rolls under the process of continuous updation.

CEOs have been directed to facilitate the same. The CEOs,

DEOs, EROs will immediately launch a special drive for enrolment of these electors,” the poll body said in a press note issued on September 26.

Under this special drive, the ECI stated that the requirement of a declaration form along with Form 6 (for enrolment as a voter) mapping themselves or their parents to the 2002-base rolls (2003 in UP) has been scrapped.

Uttar Pradesh chief electoral officer Navdeep Rinwa said any eligible citizen can apply by filling out Form-6 online through the Election Commission of India’s Citizen Service Portal (voters.eci.gov.in) or the ECINET

Mobile App.

Rinwa did not specifically comment on SSR.

However, regarding revision of electoral rolls in the state, he said, “All district electoral officers have been directed to conduct extensive publicity in this regard at the district level through various means, so that as many citizens as possible can receive information.”

Last month, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav had claimed that the Election Commission of India could undertake another review of electoral rolls in Uttar Pradesh ahead of the assembly elections and urged his party workers to remain vigilant.

GST 2.0 may replace arrests with fines for tax defaulters

Next-Generation GST and India's next growth phase

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: The Goods and Services Tax Council which meets this week will seek to complete the GST reform process that started with a rate rationalisation last year by considering sweeping process reforms that include scrapping the provision that empowers tax officials to arrest alleged defaulters, people familiar with the matter said.

The move towards GST 2.0, as the government terms it, may also allow taxpayers to make changes or corrections directly in their sales statements to avoid disputes, introduce a single annual tax return for small consumer businesses, simplify the registration process with a three-day deadline, and use data analytics to automatically approve 90% of low-risk refund claims without requiring physical paperwork, the people added, asking not to be named.

The second phase of reforming GST comes following revenue stabilisation after last year's rate rationalisation.

Another major objective of the 57th Council is to ensure a stability in both GST rates and process reforms so that both businesses and consumers will have certainty, one person said. The 56th GST Council in September 2025 rationalised tax rates by reducing key slabs to two – 5% and 18% – and dismantling a complex multi-tiered rate structure of 5%, 12%, 18%, and 28%. Now process reforms will complete an overhaul of GST regime, which will help the economy grow faster, this person added. Even minor rate tweaks may be considered only once a year, and the idea is to have these, if any, come into effect from April 1 of the following fiscal year, the person explained.

But the big process reform, arrived at after multiple rounds of stakeholder consultations, has to do with compliance and arrest, the people cited in the first instance said.

With advancement of technology such as data analytics, invoice matching between the buyer and the seller is instant even before the supply takes place. Now smart enforcement has replaced the need for arrests to detect tax evasion or misappropriation of input tax credit (ITC), they said. As a result, the council will consider a proposal to remove arrest provisions from the new generation GST or GST 2.0.

Under the proposal, tax disputes could be resolved through civil mechanisms such as tax recovery, interest payment and penalty, instead of arresting businessmen. The character of enforcement should change



The meeting is expected to provide relief to automobiles and mobility sector as well.

HT ARCHIVE

under GST 2.0, which reflects maturity of the system rather than a lowering of guard, they said.

According to them, the law will take its own course for serious frauds of criminal nature through established agencies. Under the proposed revamp, prosecution may still remain available with a higher threshold of ₹5 crore, up from ₹1 crore, they said.

The proposed system would reserve the criminal process for cases whose scale warrants it, they said. It would, however, spare ordinary disputes related to classification, valuation and credit between GST authorities and businesses. According to them, fine will be the norm rather than sentence.

For small taxpayers, the council will consider a waiver of late fee and penalties for ordinary lapses are expected to be rationalised, they said. The idea is to effect enforcement through fines rather than through custody.

It should be through a system that detects fraud rather than a provision that deters it so that honest business can deal with GST 2.0 with confidence, and enforcement efforts are made where the revenue is actually at risk, the people added.

Besides decriminalisation of the indirect tax regime, including removing the power of tax officials to arrest, the 57th GST Council may consider reforms that have been drafted after several meetings of all stakeholders, including the national coordination meetings of central and state officers between December last year and August this year. "Now the GST Council will examine them. Once approved by the Council, process reforms will be implemented in a staggered manner, depending on practicality of implementation and ease for businesses," he said. The GST

regime was introduced in July 2017 and GST 2.0 is the first major overhaul of the taxation system.

Key reforms proposed also include, allowing taxpayers to make changes or corrections directly in their sales statements to avoid disputes, introducing a single annual tax return for small consumer businesses, simplifying the registration process with a three-day deadline, and using data analytics to automatically approve 90% of low-risk refund claims without requiring physical paperwork, according to another person.

Sectoral benefits

Although, the 57th GST Council may not tinker with tax rates, several proposed process reforms and clarifications would remove ambiguities and thereby reduce tax burdens for various business segments and decrease disputes, the people mentioned above said.

For example, it is proposed to allow credit on inputs used in manufacturing free samples that will help several sectors such as pharmaceutical and consumer goods that often distribute free samples. In order to provide relief to agriculture and allied activities clarifications are proposed on taxing seeds that are graded, treated and packed before they reach the farmer.

Similarly, clarifications are proposed on the tax free nature of curing of coffee supplied to cultivators, lower levy on bio-stimulants used as fertiliser, a nil tax rate on psyllium seeds (isabgol) in all forms to protect small farmers, and a lower 5% tax on retracted tractor tyres in lines with the 56th GST Council meeting's decision, the people said.

It is also proposed to exempt micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) from compliance burdens by introducing a single annual return with quarterly payments, they said. This will save

MSMEs up to ₹5 crore turnover the trouble of frequent filings for which they engage professionals; and it will also free them from exposure to notices for minor discrepancies. On average about 1.685 million taxpayers report supplies made only to unregistered persons, and about 1.666 million of them, or 90%, have turnover up to ₹5 crore. This simplified arrangement may particularly benefit that body of taxpayers, the people said.

In order to further facilitate exports through ease of GST processes, it is proposed to remove restrictions on availing export benefits to firms even if they route sales through their own overseas branches, perform job work on foreign-owned goods within the country, or try to recover tax locked up in capital investments such as plant, machinery, and services.

It is also proposed to encourage small businesses to take full advantage of expanding e-commerce. Currently, small online vendors are unable to reach national markets because of the need to register physical offices in every state they operate with multiple tax liabilities.

It is proposed to allow such online sellers to use the e-commerce platform's warehouse as their local place of business. A seller can therefore reach customers nationwide on the strength of a single verified address, they said. Similarly for ease of logistics and warehousing, random border checks on trucks are proposed to be stopped. It is suggested to restrict checks at the state of origin on prior approved intelligence to save time and costs of businesses. It is also proposed to bring ease of process in the infrastructure, highways and real estate segment on the principle that if the toll itself bears no tax, the right to collect that toll cannot bear tax either.

The 57th Council meeting is expected to provide relief to automobiles and mobility sector too. It is proposed that businesses must not absorb heavy unrecoverable tax costs on employee transport fleets and electric vehicle (EV) operators must not face unequal tax terms compared to conventional vehicles. Therefore, full tax credit is proposed for EVs and business vehicles under 13 seats for purchase, insurance, and running costs.

To facilitate banking, insurance and other financial services it is proposed to make employee insurance fully tax-recoverable and treat internal bank branch transfers as exempt activities. Similarly, for the hospitality, tourism and health sector it is proposed that bookings by aggregators must not trigger double taxation on hotel rooms,

and relaxations must be given on seven drugs related to rare diseases by allowing appropriate tax credits.

Experts view

Industry and experts said they expect the 57th GST Council meeting to make GST 2.0 full-proof by introducing a range of process reforms, particularly removing the power of tax officials to arrest businessmen even on suspicion, which not only kills entrepreneurship but also leads to decline of that particular business establishment. Recently, officials from a southern state visited Mumbai and arrested a CEO of a payment bank for a minor fault of one of its employees located in that state. The CEO had to face jail for months and the business was hampered due to overreach of officials. Later, the matter was resolved without any criminality involved, the experts said requesting anonymity and without naming the company.

MS Mani, partner at Deloitte India said: "While GST was considered an amalgam of the erstwhile Central Excise and State VAT legislations, the introduction of Section 69 (of the CGST Act) which gave a right to arrest for specified offences under Section 132, was in conformity with the Central Excise legislation but a departure from the VAT legislation across states, which did not have any powers of arrest for violations of the VAT provisions. Almost a decade after the introduction of GST, which has also been a period of significant business transformation, it does now appear that arrest provisions in a transaction tax legislation like GST are not only unnecessary but also impact the business climate, which now seeks more freedom from compliance and policing. Many businesses have faced the harsh reality of arrest under the GST legislation, where potentially other avenues to investigate and determine violation of GST provisions exist.

In certain circumstances, businesses have also been unduly penalised for offences committed by their business partners and vendors, despite their own compliance and tax payments being on track. GST, as a transaction tax has received wide acceptance from all businesses as is evident from the growing GST collections every month and the misdemeanour of very few taxpayers does not require blanket provisions such as Sec 69 which are applicable to all businesses. Since the data of the entire GST value chain is available with the GSTN, they should be able to track and catch tax evaders and levy significant penalties which will act as a deterrence for the future."

Nirmala Sitharaman



India's ambition to become a Viksit Bharat requires an economy in which enterprises of every size can grow, wherever they begin. Over the past twelve years, our government has worked to create those conditions. GST's introduction in 2017 established a common national framework for indirect taxation. Next-Gen GST carries that effort forward, drawing on nine years of implementation and the experience of taxpayers and States.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, Next-Gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes: to reduce and rationalise rates, and to make compliance easier. The rate changes took effect on 22 September 2025. The next phase of process reforms will come before the GST Council shortly. Together, these efforts seek to give households relief, businesses greater certainty and taxpayers a system in which they can fulfil their obligations without avoidable difficulty.

The States have been partners throughout. They brought their priorities and experience to the Council, helped shape the decisions and undertook their implementation. I thank them for that commitment. GST's progress rests on this willingness to pursue a shared national purpose while respecting each government's responsibilities.

The results provide grounds for confidence. Between October 2025 and July 2026, the value of reported taxable supplies grew by 25.8% over the corresponding period a year earlier. A lighter rate structure has been accompanied by a substantial expansion in reported economic activity. This is an encouraging foundation for a reform intended to support both enterprise and public finances.

That resilience is visible in the latest revenue figures. Gross GST collections reached ₹12.46 lakh crore during April–September 2026, up 11.6% over the corresponding period last year. Every month from June through September recorded double-digit annual growth; together, collections for these four months accelerated by nearly 15%. Net collections, after refunds, also grew by 10.4% over the half-year. Taxpayer relief has coexisted with growth in the resources available for development.

The breadth of the expansion matters as much as its scale. Reported taxable supplies grew across all 11 sector groups and all major States. In an economy as diverse as India's, this spread is significant. Growth across sectors and regions creates opportunities for more busi-



Gross GST collections reached ₹12.46 lakh crore during Apr–Sep 2026, up 11.6% over the corresponding period last year.

ANI

nesses to participate in expanding markets, and for more communities to benefit from the demand, investment and employment that follow.

Reported sales to consumers (B2C) also rose by 26.7% in the post-reform comparison. When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: the purchasing power of households sustains demand for the goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the producer.

For small and medium enterprises, a national market is valuable when it opens a practical route to customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Businesses in Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns should be able to build those relationships while continuing to invest and employ people locally. Enterprises expanding into these towns, in turn, can create opportunities for local suppliers and distributors. GST's common framework supports these connections; simpler administration must make them easier to sustain.

Participation in that framework is substantial. GST registrations across Central and State jurisdictions stood at approximately 17.1 million at the end of August, up nearly 15% from a year ago. For the April–July 2026 tax periods, GSTR-3B returns filed by their due dates were 12.6% higher than for the same periods last year. These improvements place a corresponding responsibility on the administration: regular compliance must be supported by reliable service, clear guidance and timely resolution of difficulties.

The functioning of input tax credit is another important part of this experience. The post-reform figures show that the share of tax liability discharged through credits rose, while accumulated credit declined relative to taxable supplies. This is encouraging for businesses that depend on the effective use of eligible credit. For a smaller firm, working capital determines how readily it can purchase inputs, fulfil an order and take on the next one.

Refunds are equally relevant. Approximately ₹1.80 lakh crore

was refunded during April–September. Returning amounts due to businesses is part of a well-functioning tax system. Greater predictability in this process would help enterprises plan purchases and production with more confidence. The taxpayer's experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance.

The States also have a stronger revenue position. Their aggregate SGST receipts, including their share of IGST settlements, grew by about 16% during April–September this year. These resources support investment in infrastructure and public services, which improve the conditions in which families and enterprises pursue their aspirations. The gains can therefore reinforce one another: household relief supports demand, enterprise strengthens economic activity, and public revenues help sustain development.

The experience also points to the work ahead. A growing system must remain attentive to the costs it imposes on smaller participants. Their time and resources are limited. Each improvement in filing, credit or refunds should allow more of those resources to be devoted to running and expanding a business. The proposals before the Council on 7 October have been developed through sustained work with the States. They address registration, returns, refunds, disputes and improved flow of input tax credit, with the aim of reducing the time and cost of compliance. Taxpayer experience must continue to guide implementation.

GST's growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform. The same commitment to clarity, certainty and respect for the taxpayer guides our work on direct taxes. A dependable tax system enables enterprises to plan beyond their immediate obligations and invest in opportunities that take time to mature. Giving them that confidence, wherever they operate, helps build the economic strength of a Viksit Bharat as envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

(The author is the Union minister of finance and corporate affairs)

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The high-rise hurdle in push for rooftop solar

Residential societies still face issues such as builder-held power connections, complex metering rules, and challenge of collective decision-making

Manoj Sharma

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NEW DELHI: On the terrace of MJR Pearl, a 14-storey apartment complex in Bengaluru's Whitefield, rows of photovoltaic panels have turned the roof into a 150-kW power plant. For the residents of the 416-apartment complex, installing them was a leap of faith.

In most high-rise housing societies, rooftop solar proposals run into questions about the initial investment, the time it will take to recover the cost and whether the savings will justify the expenditure. At MJR Pearl, the decision has paid off: the installation has cut the complex's common-area electricity bills by 80%, bringing down monthly maintenance costs.

Across Indian cities, more and more rooftops are housing solar plants. Central government subsidies, additional state support and growing awareness of the savings on electricity bills have encouraged individual homeowners and apartment societies to go for solar power. The trend gained momentum after the rollout of the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana in February 2024, which made residential solar more affordable.

Official data shows that before the scheme, India's residential rooftop solar capacity stood at barely 3.2 gigawatts (GW), accumulated over nearly a decade. Total rooftop installations have since crossed 5.05 million, with

more than 16 GW installed. Daily installations, which stood at roughly 5,000 a year ago, now exceed 16,000. Close to 1.9 million families report paying nothing for electricity.

Delhi recently opened its own PM Surya Ghar portal, offering combined subsidies of up to ₹1.56 lakh for systems up to 3 kW. Maharashtra has seen strong adoption in Pune and Nagpur, while Gujarat leads in housing-society participation. Along with Uttar Pradesh, the two states and the Union Territory have moved faster by combining central support with state subsidies or earlier policies.

In Pune and Pimpri-Chinchwad, housing societies are using solar power for lifts, common-area lighting and water pumps. Park Royale in Wakad expanded its installation to 172.5 kW, bringing annual electricity expenses down from ₹62 lakh to ₹13.5 lakh. At La Melosa, monthly electricity bills fell from more than ₹2 lakh to ₹3,500.

In Greater Noida, three months back, Arihant Arden installed a 500 kW plant under PM Surya Ghar and added another 100 kW using its own funds. The 600 kW installation serves more than 1,500 flats and is projected to save the society ₹40-45 lakh a year. The project cost about ₹3.25 crore, including a central subsidy of ₹90 lakh.

A recent Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) survey of 17,094 households across 22 states found that PM Surya Ghar nearly doubled the sector's growth rate from 45% to 85%. Lower bills motivated 81% of willing households, while those who installed systems reported an average 71% reduction in monthly bills.

The high-rise challenge

But experts say the rising numbers hide a tougher reality. Much of the housing in India's



Rooftop solar panels on top of Arihant Arden in Greater Noida (left) and MJR Pearl in Bengaluru (right).



HT PHOTO

megacities consists of multi-storey apartment blocks, which continue to face several hurdles that independent homeowners do not.

Despite rapidly rising solar adoption by independent houses, only about 19,000 housing societies have installed shared rooftop solar so far, a significant number in the past year alone. "Individual homeowners and apartment societies face different barriers," says Bhawna Tyagi, senior programme lead responsible for the solar rooftop initiatives at CEEW.

"For individual homeowners with roof ownership, awareness about rooftop solar and its benefits has improved, but awareness gaps related to process and finance persist. For households in apartments and multi-dwelling buildings, the constraints are structural rather than informational," she says.

Rooftop solar vendors say in a multi-storey society, every decision must pass a general body meeting, and agreement is hard to reach. Residents often disa-

gree on whether the investment is worthwhile, particularly when money has to come from society reserves or a bank loan.

Managing committees usually last only a year or two, and a new committee can reverse the previous decision.

Naveen DR, CEO, Beestone Solar, which installed MJR Pearl's plant, says his firm has completed around 600 individual systems under the central scheme in two years, but only about 10 for apartment communities. "If the government could prompt banks to create a simpler loan product for registered housing societies, and if the Karnataka government adds a small subsidy of its own, apartment complexes in Bengaluru and across the state will see much higher adoption."

The limits of shared solar

Then there are other administrative and technical issues. For example, in large housing complexes in Noida and Ghaziabad, the distribution company often supplies electricity through a

single high-tension connection of 11 kV or 33 kV, because the society's total demand runs into several megawatts.

The society then uses private sub-meters for individual flats. These meters are not part of the distribution company's official metering system.

"That matters because virtual net metering, which allows electricity generated by a shared solar installation to be credited to individual consumers, relies on official discom meters. Where individual flats do not have direct discom meters, the generation cannot be credited to their electricity bills," says Nandan Singh Bisht, managing director, MN Energy & Infra, which installed the plant at Arihant Arden in Greater Noida.

"That is why almost all society solar projects, including Arihant Arden, are installed only for the common-area meter. By solarising the common load, every resident benefits through lower maintenance bills. At Arihant, we estimate that each member's share of the common-area elec-

tricity cost will come down by roughly ₹700-800 a month," Bisht adds.

"Rooftop solar connections in Uttar Pradesh are governed by the UPERC Rooftop Solar Photovoltaic Regulations, 2019, which provide for net-metering, gross-metering and net-billing arrangements," says Manoj Jha, spokesperson for Noida Power Company Limited, the distribution company serving Greater Noida. "But virtual net metering is currently not available under the applicable framework, so the generation cannot be credited directly to individual flat owners' electricity bills."

Twenty-two states and seven UTs have notified some form of virtual net metering, though the rules differ on eligibility, charges and the share of transformer capacity available to shared installations. "These frameworks need to move from pilots to mainstream options," says Tyagi.

Lavesh Kumar Sisodia, project officer for Gautam Buddha Nagar at the Uttar Pradesh New & Renewable Energy Develop-

ment Agency (UPNEDA), which promotes renewable energy in the state, says monthly rooftop solar installations in the district rose from around 100-120 a year ago to 249 in the current month.

"The big problem is that in about 90% of cases the high-tension connection in apartments remains in the builder's name," he says. "Until the connection is transferred, a housing society cannot access its subsidy."

Planning for solar

The experience of Gujarat suggests that administrative support can help.

Sumedha Malviya, programme head for energy at WRI India, says, "Under the Energy Transition Preparedness Initiative, we studied rooftop solar adoption at the state level and the role of clear processes. In Gujarat, the state discoms have created rooftop solar cells and identified sub-division level nodal officers to streamline and fast-track applications. This may explain the relatively better performance of Gujarat cities."

"Historically too, Gujarat had a head start on rooftop solar through earlier policies and programmes. In Gujarat's cities, the discoms have been facilitating smoother coordination through dedicated manpower," she says.

Similarly, Pune has used property-tax rebates to encourage solar adoption, while municipal bodies in several cities are incorporating renewable energy targets into climate action plans and installing panels on public buildings. Chennai, for example, has achieved high levels of rooftop solarisation in existing public buildings.

"Indian cities and planning agencies are not taking rooftop solar as part of urban planning exercises," Malviya says.

"There continues to be a disconnect between urban planning and energy planning.

Energy agencies, especially the discoms, are expected to supply electricity to new areas, but they do not participate in conversations related to master planning or actively managing rising cooling demand," she adds.

Many states now have building bye-laws requiring provisions for solar generation or solar water heaters. But compliance is weak, enforcement inconsistent and verification difficult. Architect and urbanist Dikshu Kukreja argues that what is required is designing buildings to accommodate rooftop solar from the outset and using planning incentives to encourage installation.

"Structural provisions, dedicated solar zones, electrical infrastructure and maintenance access can be incorporated at the planning stage," he says.

"We need to understand that the roof of a high-rise is not an empty surface. It is already packed with fire-fighting tanks, water tanks, lift machine rooms and other critical services," he says. "After accounting for structural limits, shading and maintenance access, the space left for solar is often surprisingly small. Most existing buildings were never designed for it. Subsidies can pay for panels, but they cannot fix the spatial and structural constraints. For high-rises, the real question is not how to add more panels later, but how to design solar into the building from the start."

Developers who integrate renewable energy generation could receive planning incentives rather than face a blanket requirement to install panels regardless of a building's limitations, says Kukreja.

"The objective should not be to put solar panels on every roof at any cost, but to make every new building capable of adopting renewable energy intelligently," he adds.

2 held for passing defence info to Pakistan: Assam CM

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SILCHAR: Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday said the Special Task Force (STF) of the state police has arrested a two people, including an Indian Army veteran, in Guwahati for his alleged involvement with a Pakistan's intelligence operative.

According to the police, one of the arrested was identified as Abhishek Kumar Singh (31), a Bihar resident. He was allegedly passing confidential information concerning security forces to the Pakistani operative, they said.

Meanwhile, the veteran, whose identity is currently unknown, was working with the army on a contractual basis post his retirement, the chief minister said in a press conference after a cabinet meeting.

"Today, as per input of central agencies, the Assam Police arrested two persons. One is a retired army jawan but currently working on a contractual basis with the army," said Sarma at a press conference, when asked about an espionage-related arrest which was shared with the media through a police statement.

"He, along with the other person, was sharing all the updates



Himanta Biswa Sarma

regarding Indian Army's movements here," Sarma added. The chief minister said that both of the accused were honey-trapped by Pakistani operative through online sex rackets.

Senior police officers did not respond to HT's requests for further details of the veteran.

Singh, a resident of Bihar's Purba Champaran district, was apprehended from a rented house in Gandhinagar under Satagaon Police Station in Guwahati during an operation conducted by the Assam STF in the intervening night of October 3 and 4, police said.

Assam Police said in a press statement that the operation was carried out after intelligence regarding Singh's alleged anti-national activities. "The opera-

tion was launched on the basis of a preliminary input received from Gajraj military intelligence, Tezpur," police said.

According to the police, the STF worked on the intelligence input and further developed information regarding Singh's alleged activities and his suspected links with a Pakistani intelligence operative.

"During the preliminary investigation, our teams found Singh's involvement in espionage-related activities, including passing secret information concerning security forces to the Pakistan Intelligence Operative," police stated.

During the operation, the STF seized a mobile phone, SIM cards and documents described by the police as incriminating from Singh's possession.

The police, however, did not disclose the specific nature of the information that Singh allegedly shared and the exact manner in which the alleged communication or transfer of information happened.

"We are investigating the matter further and also examining the duration of his communications with the Pakistan-based operatives. However, we cannot share further information as of now since this is a sensitive case," a senior officer said.

3 PAK NATIONALS AMONG 7 BOOKED FOR TERROR LINKS

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BIDAR: Karnataka police have booked seven people in Bidar, including a 24-year-old man from Bhalki taluk and three Pakistan-based nationals, for allegedly using WhatsApp and Instagram to communicate with members of banned terrorist organisations and illegal arms traffickers, officers said.

Bidar police had registered an FIR at Khatak Chincholi police station on October 1, naming Vishalkumar Vijaykumar Metre, 24, of Yenkor village; Pakistan-based nationals Shahzad Bhatti, Rana Hunain and Nomri Khan; Ashu Sharma of Mainpuri in Uttar Pradesh; and Raj Bhai alias Lucky Singh of Madhya Pradesh. One other person has also been named in the case.

Bidar superintendent of police Pradeep Gunti told HT that Metre was arrested on Saturday and produced before a court. "The accused was found to be in contact with people involved in illegal arms trafficking and members of banned organisations," Gunti said.

Tension flare after cops prevent protesters from entering SRFTI

Press Trust Of India

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KOLKATA: Chaos unfolded outside the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) here on Sunday afternoon during a protest organised by members of the Bangiya Hindu Jagaran Mancha, as police prevented them from entering the campus, officials said.

The demonstration was staged in protest against the September 27 clash on the campus between a section of the students and members of the Akhil Bharatiya Grahak Panchayat (ABGP), an RSS-affiliated consumer awareness group.

"This afternoon, the protesters arrived in front of the SRFTI gate, but police personnel deployed at the spot prevented them from entering the campus," an officer said. Some of the agitators tried to break open the institute's gate when they were stopped by the police, leading to a scuffle, he said.

Several students and teachers inside the campus, many of whom were seen wearing helmets, alleged that stones and water bottles were thrown into the premises from outside.

Another senior police officer said the situation was being closely monitored, and adequate personnel were deployed to prevent further escalation.

A member of the Bangiya



Members of Bangiya Hindu Jagaran Mancha attempt to climb the main gate of SRFTI on Sunday.

PTI

Hindu Jagaran Mancha said the outfit had announced the protest in advance. "The situation is under control now. We will not allow anyone to violate law and order. Strict action will be taken against anyone trying to disrupt peace," the officer added.

On Saturday, students of SRFTI maintained their "academic boycott", resulting in suspension of classes for the sixth consecutive day, as they demanded that those responsible for the September 27 clash on the campus be arrested and the pupils be provided security.

SRFTI students' union, in a statement, had said it was not informed about the ABGP programme on the campus on Sep-

tember 27. It said a confrontation had ensued during the programme, and some students were first verbally abused and called terms such as "anti-national" and "cockroach", following which they were beaten up with sticks and attacked with stones, while female students were also subjected to physical intimidation.

ABGP members have given a conflicting account, alleging that protesting students attacked them and damaged programme-related materials, including a picture of Bharat Mata.

Classes have not been taking place on the campus since violence took place between the students and members of the ABGP.

FOUR STUDENTS FOUND DEAD IN CHENNAI LAKE

CHENNAI: Four school students who went missing on October 3 were found dead in the Thiruneermalai lake near Chromepet on Sunday, police said.

The deceased, all residents of Krishna Street in Lakshmiapuram, were identified as Pooja, 13, Khushi, 13, K Devadarshan, 12, and Yuvanesh, 10.

The two boys were studying in Class 8, while the boys were in Classes 7 and 6, respectively, police said.

The children had gone out to play in their locality on Saturday but did not return home. After their parents and relatives searched for them and circulated their photographs in local WhatsApp groups without success, separate missing-person complaints were lodged at the Chromepet police station late Saturday night.

Around 10 am on Sunday, residents noticed four bodies floating in Thiruneermalai Periya Eri and alerted the authorities. Personnel from the Tamil Nadu Fire and Rescue Services (TNFRS) reached the spot and retrieved the bodies, police said.

Preliminary investigation suggested that the children may have ventured into the lake to bathe and drowned after getting trapped in the slush, police said.

The bodies were identified by family members and sent to the Tambaram District Government Hospital mortuary for postmortem examination. **PTI**

Ministry, airlines to discuss Navi Mumbai shifting tussle

Press Trust Of India

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NEW DELHI/MUMBAI: The civil aviation ministry has convened a meeting of airlines and Adani Airports' representatives on Tuesday to discuss about the proposed partial shifting of international flights from Mumbai airport to Navi Mumbai airport, according to people familiar with the matter.

With Mumbai airport's Terminal 1 (T1) renovation set to start from January 2027, airlines have been asked to stop one-third of their international operations from October 25 or shift them to Navi Mumbai airport.

Both airports are part of Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL). However, airlines have expressed concerns about the move while AAHL has said that extensive consultations have been taking place with airlines on the future of T1 since 2020.

The people said that representatives of airlines, including IndiGo, Air India, SpiceJet, and Adani Airports are expected to attend the meeting that will be chaired by Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha.

The meeting is scheduled to be held on October 6, Tuesday, they



Ahead of Mumbai airport's T1 renovation in January 2027, authorities asked airlines to halt one-third of their international operations from October 25 or shift them to Navi Mumbai airport.

added.

On October 3, AAHL, said 91% of Mumbai airport's passenger traffic will remain unaffected due to the demolition of the north section of T1 for redevelopment of the six-decade old terminal and subsequent relocation of partial operations to T2 and Navi Mumbai International Airport.

T1 redevelopment will begin from January 2027 which will increase its capacity by 33% - up to 20 mppa from current 15 mppa, AAHL had said in a statement.

Mumbai International Airport, one of the busiest in the country, has two terminals — T1 and T2.

While T1 is used for domestic operations, international flights operate from T2.

Global airlines' grouping IATA has opposed the partial relocation of international flights and termed it as "forceful relocation". In a letter to the ministry on September 9, the International Air Transport Association (IATA) also sought the civil aviation ministry's intervention in the matter.

AAHL, on October 3, said "extensive consultations" with airlines on the future of T1 have been ongoing since 2020, and the proposed redevelopment was also presented before the airports tariff

regulator AERA and subsequently incorporated into the approved tariff framework. "Of Mumbai airport's approximately 55 million passengers per annum only around 5-mppa (about 9 per cent) will be temporarily deoperationalised," AAHL had said.

To ensure continuity of operations and minimise inconvenience to passengers, AAHL had said it has provided airlines with the option to temporarily relocate their operations to Navi Mumbai International Airport at their discretion.

AAHL will support airlines through this transition and will provide all necessary assistance to ensure a smooth and seamless migration of services, it had said.

Mumbai airport operator MIAL has communicated to the 46 airlines to effect a 33 per cent cut in international departure slots at the airport with effect from 11.59 pm on October 25.

At present, a total of 46 airlines operate 770 weekly international flights from T2 and from October 25, which is also the start of the winter schedule, MIAL has asked carriers to temporarily discontinue 265 weekly overseas services, the people had said on October 2.

CBI ARRESTS DGCA DY DIRECTOR IN ₹2.5L BRIBERY CASE

NEW DELHI: The CBI has arrested Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) Deputy Director Sushil Kumar Garg, posted in Chennai, for allegedly taking ₹2.5 lakh bribe for issuing airworthiness certificate to aircraft operated by a private company, officials said Sunday.

The agency also arrested the Director of Ekvi Air Training Organisation Pvt Ltd, Sachin Keshav Bhane, for giving bribe to the officer, they said.

The CBI action followed registration of a case against Deputy Director (Airworthiness) Garg, Ekvi Air Training Organisation Director Bhane, the company, and others in relation to alleged demand and acceptance of illegal gratification, sources said.

Garg had allegedly demanded the bribe for issuing airworthiness certification in favour of aircraft operated by the company, they said. The agency had received inputs about the alleged bribe demand following which an FIR was registered and a raid was conducted, they said. **PTI**

No meeting of AI-copyright panel since June; second paper delayed

Sejal Sharma

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NEW DELHI: A government committee set up to study how artificial intelligence (AI) fits into India's copyright law has not met since June, according to three members of the committee who told HT that the government's interest in the matter has since faded. A second working paper on the AI-copyright issue, which the government had told the media would be out by February 2026, is still not ready, said the members.

The committee was formed by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) on April 28, 2025. It was asked to look at the legal and policy questions around AI and copyright, and to check whether the Copyright Act, 1957, is enough to deal with them. When the first working paper came out in December 2025, the committee said the second would follow in two months. Nearly 10 months on, there is no paper and no new timeline from DPIIT.

"The fizz has gone out from the government's side. They are not

THE GOVT'S INTEREST IN THE STUDY OF HOW AI FITS INTO INDIA'S COPYRIGHT LAW HAS SINCE FADED, SAID ONE OF THE PANEL MEMBERS

prioritising this issue," said one member, who did not want to be named. This member said the panel's last consultation was held before the beginning of the monsoon session of parliament.

The first paper dealt with the use of copyrighted material to train AI models. The second was to look at what AI produces. Members said the discussions on the second paper covered who owns AI-generated work, who is liable for it, what counts as originality, and whether AI-generated work should get copyright at all.

"Deliberations took place on the second part after the release of the first report, however they were sporadic in nature," said

another committee member. Members said the committee met every two weeks when they were churning out the first paper, however the meetings on the second paper got sporadic.

The first paper proposed a mandatory blanket licence. Under it, AI developers could train their models on all lawfully accessed copyrighted content in India without taking permission from each creator. In return, copyright owners would get payment through a new central collecting body.

DPIIT invited public comments on the proposal and extended the deadline by a month to February 6. Since then, no revised or final version has been released.

The first member quoted above said the issue has lost its urgency. "That time it was a major issue as people were complaining about AI training and its liability. I guess it's become the status quo now. There is also not a lot of pushback from the public," the member said.

HT sent emails to Himani Pande and Simrat Kaur on October 1, but did not receive a response till going to print.

ELDERLY COUPLE
FOUND DEAD AT
KOLKATA HOUSE,
SUICIDE SUSPECTED

HT Correspondent
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KOLKATA: A 67-year-old man and his 60-year-old wife were found dead inside their apartment at Panchasayar on the southern outskirts of Kolkata on Sunday morning, police said, adding that it is a suspected case of suicide. Police said that they have also found ₹1 lakh with a note asking for using the money for their funeral.

"Both bodies of the man and his wife were found in the same room in the apartment. The bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination to ascertain the exact cause of death. Initial investigation indicates that the man died by suicide," a police officer said, requesting anonymity.

"A handwritten note and ₹1 lakh were found on a table. The note said the money should be used for the couple's funeral," the officer added.

Local people and some relatives of the couple, who also live in the same neighbourhood, told the police that they called the man several times from outside in the morning but nobody responded.

The relatives went to the rear of the building and saw the man's body through a window. They informed the police at around 9.15 am, who then broke into the ground-floor flat. Police said that the elderly couple had been living in the ground-floor flat of the building for several years.

The couple had an only son, who died around 20 years ago and they were dealing with several health issues, the officer said, citing relatives.

"The relatives said the couple went into depression after their only son died around two decades ago and their financial condition was also poor. Both had been suffering from multiple ailments," the police officer said. "The deaths are being probed," he added.

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{ ARMY MAN'S BODY WAS BEING TRANSPORTED }

4 killed as ambulance rams into truck in UP

HT Correspondent
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LUCKNOW: A total of four people, including the son, brother and nephew of a deceased Army man, were killed when an ambulance carrying the soldier's body rams into a stationary truck on the Purvanchal Expressway in Uttar Pradesh's Sultanpur district on Sunday morning, police said.

According to police, the accident occurred around 8.15 am near Haliyapur on the Ayodhya-Sultanpur border.

The ambulance was carrying the body of Subedar Major Satyawar Singh from Haryana's Panchkula district to his village in Uttar Pradesh's Deoria district when it crashed into the truck from behind.

Taking cognisance of the accident, chief minister Yogi Adityanath expressed his condolences to the bereaved families and announced ₹2 lakh ex gratia each for next of kin of the deceased. He directed officials to expedite relief and rescue operations and ensure proper treatment of the injured. The chief minister also asked officials to speak to the families of the deceased and provide them all possible assistance and wished the injured a speedy recovery.

The deceased were identified as Satyawar Singh's 18-year-old son Gaurav Singh, his 55-year-old brother Ram Samujh, a relative's son Rajan Singh, 35, and ambulance driver Jaspal, 30, police said.

The impact was so severe that the front portion of the ambulance was completely mangled. Gaurav and Jaspal, who were seated in the front, died on the spot, police said, adding that Ram Samujh and Rajan, who were



A police officer stands near the wreckage of the ambulance in UP's Sultanpur on Sunday.

seated at the rear, were taken to a government hospital in Ayodhya where they succumbed to injuries during treatment.

Sultanpur DM Indrajeet Singh said: "Satyawar Singh, from Deoria, had been undergoing treatment at the Command Hospital in Chandigarh and had undergone a kidney transplant. He died three days ago, following which his relatives travelled to Panchkula to bring his body home."

The DM said that three members of the family and the ambulance driver died in Sunday's accident.

Sultanpur SP Vineet Jaiswal said police received information about the accident through Dial 112. "Local police are at the spot and further action is underway," he said.

Police said the initial investigation suggested that the ambulance driver may have dozed off, causing the vehicle to go out of control and crash into the truck.

The body of Subedar Major Satyawar Singh has been kept with due respect at Haliyapur police station pending further arrangements.

The bodies of the four accident victims have been sent for post-mortem examination, police said.

10-YEAR-OLD BOY
AMONG 3 KILLED
AS COUNTRY BOAT
CAPSIZES IN ASSAM

Biswa Kalyan Purkayastha
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SILCHAR: Three people, including a 10-year-old boy, died after the country boat they were travelling in capsized in Assam's Lakhimpur district on Sunday, police said.

The incident occurred in the Merbil area at around 9.30 am. Locals told police that the three were crossing the Merbil River with a few goats on board the small country boat and heading towards a market when the boat capsized due to strong current.

According to police, the deceased have been identified as Arit Dutta (25), Podma Dutta (50) and Midhusmi Dutta (10), all residents of Deolia Gaon under Ghilamara police station.

"The current was strong and they went missing, but they were recovered within an hour by locals and a team of the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF)," police said, adding that the three people were taken to a nearby government hospital, where they were declared dead.

Midhusmi Dutta and Podma Dutta belonged to the same household, while all three deceased were relatives and residents of the same village.

Fiscal federalism: Why public finance matters to every citizen

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Few subjects are as central to the functioning of government—or as likely to make the average citizen's eyes glaze over—as how governments collect and spend money. But public finance shapes nearly every interaction Indian citizens have with the state.

How much tax revenue will my state receive from the Centre? Will my local government have the resources to invest in the amenities I value? And how can I distinguish between an expensive freebie and a purposeful, targeted cash transfer?

A new book, *Fiscal Fables: A Citizen's Guide to Public Finance*, demystifies India's public finances for a lay audience and explains public finance concepts using relatable stories and examples. The book is co-written by Sarthak Pradhan and Pranay Kotasthane, two public policy researchers at the Takshashila Institution, Bengaluru.

They spoke about their new book on last week's episode of *Grand Tamasha*, a weekly podcast on Indian politics and policy coproduced by HT and the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace.

Pradhan, a fellow at Takshashila, said citizens require a better understanding of public finance because when the government spends on different kinds of things, as citizens, one cannot "exit a government's fiscal choices." And while "every politician would like to spend more, it has consequences, both for you and future generations, and in some cases these

INCOME TAX RETURNS ARE SO COMPLICATED... BECAUSE THE GOVT IS TRYING TO ACHIEVE MANY THINGS WITH THIS ONE INSTRUMENT —TAX POLICY

consequences are irreversible. If we understand public finances better, we can deal with these things better."

Kotasthane, deputy director at Takshashila, argued that the Indian tax system resembles Michael Scott, the bumbling office manager from the popular American television series *The Office*. Scott "was trying to be so many things at the same time. He wanted his branch to be profitable, and he wanted to be everyone's best friend, the funniest guy in the room, inspirational, and often he ends up achieving none of those goals," Kotasthane recounted. "The Indian tax system is identical in that sense. Anyone who has filled their income tax return knows what we're talking about. Income tax returns are so complicated...because the government is trying to achieve many things with this one instrument called tax policy."

Tax policy is sometimes "used to promote exports, sometimes to incentivise savings, sometimes to drive infrastructure investment, sometimes to ensure balanced regional development, sometimes to boost employment," Kotasthane



GRAND
TAMASHA

said. By trying to achieve so many objectives with one instrument, the government risks losing sight of its ultimate goal, which is to raise the maximum revenue with minimum economic distortion, the scholar explained.

While the Goods and Services Tax (GST) has been criticised for its rollout, Pradhan argued the new system nonetheless represented an improvement over the status quo. By merging 11 Union and state indirect taxes, it reduced the cascading effect of taxation through the input tax credit mechanism, he explained. Pradhan also highlighted the GST Council as an institutional innovation because it brings the Union government and the state governments together under one roof, an arrangement he described as unique in India. "Can the system be better? Are there absurdities in the current GST system? Yes, there are absurdities. But is it worse than before? We don't agree with that," he said.

On fiscal federalism, Kotasthane argued that the media often characterises debates over the distribution of resources as a fight between Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh, or Maharashtra and Bihar. But, in reality, "the fight is not so much about horizontal devolution. The real challenge is vertical devolution, that is, how much money the Union government is keeping and how much the state governments are getting."



LISTEN: Scan the QR code to listen to the full episode.

UP custodial death: HC rejects bail to 4 cops

Press Trust of India
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PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has rejected bail applications of four Uttar Pradesh police personnel in connection with the 2021 custodial death case in Jaunpur district.

Rejecting their pleas, justice Samit Gopal cited the CBI charge sheet, which accused the cops of causing grievous injuries to Krishna Kumar Yadav, alias Pujari, to extract a confession and subsequently murdering him by inflicting injuries sufficient to cause his death.

The CBI had also mentioned that false records were created to portray his death as an accident or assault by unknown persons rather than physical torture in police custody.

KRISHNA KUMAR YADAV WAS TAKEN FROM HIS HOUSE ON FEB 11, 2021, THE FAMILY WAS LATER INFORMED HE DIED IN POLICE CUSTODY

The four accused cops are Jaysheel Tiwari, Ramkrit Yadav, Raj Kumar Verma and Angad Prasad Chaudhary.

The CBI had filed the charge sheet against 11 police personnel after an FIR was lodged on February 12, 2021, under Sections 302 (murder), 34 (common intention), 120-B (conspiracy), among others, of the Indian Penal Code at Baksha village of Jaunpur district.

The Special CBI Judge in Lucknow subsequently framed charges on September 18, 2024.

According to the FIR, Krishna Kumar Yadav was allegedly taken from his house around 3 am on February 11, 2021, by a Special Operation Group team led by then Baksa SHO, along with other police personnel.

A relative claimed in the FIR Krishna was allegedly unable to stand and shouted to his mother to save him, saying that the police would kill him. The family

was subsequently informed that he died in police custody.

A division bench of the high court on September 8, 2021, had directed the transfer of the investigation of the custodial death case to the CBI. The CBI subsequently registered its own FIR and filed a charge sheet against eleven police personnel.

Justice Samit Gopal, while rejecting the bail, also considered the Supreme Court's March 12, 2024, order cancelling the bail granted to co-accused Jitendra Singh. In view of this, the high court, in its order dated September 30, rejected all four bail applications while directing the trial court to expedite the proceedings.

Justice Samit Gopal, while rejecting the bail, also considered the Supreme Court's March 12, 2024, order cancelling the bail granted to co-accused Jitendra Singh. In view of this, the high court, in its order dated September 30, rejected all four bail applications while directing the trial court to expedite the proceedings.

Maha school principal booked for sexually harassing girl: Police

LATUR: The founder-principal of a private school in Maharashtra's Latur city has been booked under the Poocho Act for allegedly sexually harassing a minor girl, a senior police officer said on Sunday.

The accused is absconding, and further investigation is on, SP Amol Tambe told PTI.

UP court awards father, son life term for killing young couple

GONDA: A court in Gonda district of Uttar Pradesh has sentenced a father and his son to life imprisonment for killing a young couple in August 2023, a lawyer said on Sunday. The court sentenced Kripparam and his son Raghavram to life imprisonment and imposed a fine of ₹60,000 on each.

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{ FROM PAGE 1 }

GREAT INDIA BUSTARDS

insemination is considered an important development because it provides conservation scientists with an additional tool for breeding birds and managing genetic diversity in a species whose wild population has fallen to critically low levels.

If the experiment works, the officials said the next destination could be Kutch. Already, a first chick has hatched in March 2026 after a fertile egg was moved about 770 km from Rajasthan. The chick has survived beyond the critical first three months in the wild, a landmark for restarting breeding in Gujarat's isolated population.

In Gujarat, officials said that the habitat restoration work at Naliya has started and about 11 sq km of invasive *Prosopis juliflora*, with 30 km of predator proof fencing covering 15 sq km, has been done. As per the Gujarat Action Plan for GIB Conservation, a target of release of 30 birds and 200 to 500 sq km of secure grassland has been set. In future, the GIB can be introduced in new habitats in states such as Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh, officials said. "That will all depend on how the captive bred GIBs survive in the wild," a senior environment ministry official said.

Sumer Singh Bhati, who has followed bustards in western Rajasthan for over a decade, said, "The real test is not just producing birds in captivity. That is easier than making them survive in the wild. There is a need to create a landscape where bustards can survive after release and flourish. Improving the habitat and putting all transmission lines below the ground would be key to revive the bustard population in the longer run," he said.

AIRLINE INSPECTIONS

FAA's reassessment of India's civil aviation safety oversight under its International Aviation Safety Assessment (IASA) programme is scheduled for November 16 to 20. It examines whether a country's civil aviation authority complies with safety standards set by the International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO), a specialised agency of the United Nations. India currently holds Category 1 status.

"In case India were to be downgraded, we would not be able to expand into the US market. There could also be greater scrutiny of the existing flight operations as well. In the previous instance, when India was downgraded, an action plan based on the observations made by the US authorities

was made after which the Category 1 status was restored," former DGCA joint director general JS Rawat said.

A civil aviation ministry official aware of the matter said, "FAA majorly looks at air safety and operations apart from various other aspects. We are confident that India would be able to retain the Category 1 status this year too."

The FAA routinely assesses the civil aviation authorities of countries whose airlines fly to the US, have applied to fly to the US or have code-share arrangements with US airlines. The reassessment is conducted every five years.

India was last assessed in 2021, when its ICAO effective implementation (EI) score rose from 69.95% to 85.65%, indicating improved compliance with ICAO standards.

The FAA visit comes as a major overhaul of the regulator has been proposed, with a plan to transform the DGCA into an independent, financially autonomous authority. HT first reported that the DGCA had submitted the proposal to the civil aviation ministry.

The need for such a body "has been a repeated observation made by the FAA in every audit", an official said, adding that a short, mid and long-term restructuring plan was needed, considering the present and future development of aviation in the country.

CAPITAL PUNISHMENT

the prosecution had failed to establish that the convict was beyond reform, while the material on his background and conduct in custody weighed against such a conclusion.

"The State has not excluded the possibility of the appellant's reformation," held the bench, adding that the alternative of imprisonment for the remainder of his natural life was adequate for a crime of such gravity.

The judgment emphasised that the sentencing exercise must consider the circumstances of the offender alongside those of the crime, rather than allow the enormity of the offence to eclipse every mitigating factor. The court said the death penalty was justified only when life imprisonment was "unquestionably foreclosed".

The bench did not minimise the brutality of the crime. The convict had repeatedly sexually assaulted the child, his stepdaughter, and killed her in April 2018, apparently to prevent her from disclosing the abuse. Her mother was the prosecution's solitary eyewitness to the events inside the home.

Describing the killing as an

instance of "instrumental silencing", the court said the murder compounded the sexual violation of the child with an assault on the administration of justice. It called this an aggravating circumstance of the highest order, but stressed that even such gravity did not, by itself, establish that the offender was beyond redemption.

The court considered several mitigating circumstances, including the convict's account of childhood deprivation and adult misfortune, the absence of previous criminal convictions, satisfactory conduct in custody, continuing family ties, his age of about 56 years and the nearly eight years he had spent in prison, including around seven under the shadow of a death sentence.

The psychological evaluation did not disclose any condition from which incorrigibility could be inferred. The state, meanwhile, had produced no evidence establishing that the possibility of reform could be ruled out. The court said these circumstances deserved genuine and substantial weight in deciding whether the ultimate punishment was warranted. The judgment also criticised the trial court for convicting and sentencing the accused to death on the same day, without a separate, meaningful hearing on sentence as required by law. The Supreme Court subsequently obtained additional material concerning his social and psychological background and prison conduct to ensure that the sentencing decision rested on a complete record.

At the same time, the bench ruled out ordinary life imprisonment carrying the prospect of remission after 14 years as inadequate for the crime. It invoked the intermediate sentencing option recognised in Union of India Vs V Sriharan (2016), under which a court can direct imprisonment for the convict's entire natural life without remission.

The death sentences for murder and aggravated penetrative sexual assault were accordingly commuted to imprisonment for the remainder of the convict's natural life, without remission. The sentences for the other offences were upheld and ordered to run concurrently.

The court described the substituted punishment as one of the utmost severity, second only to death. It would ensure that the convict remained behind bars for the rest of his life, it said, while preserving the possibility of reformation that an irreversible death sentence would extinguish.

JAISHANKAR

countries navigate security concerns and economic ramifications linked to these standoffs.

In his address, the minister also laid out a road map for India's economic growth, touched upon AI's use and said the FTA with the EU will have "cascading impact" on overall relations.

Jaishankar emphasised that emerging and middle powers were reassessing their roles, and instead of seeking strict alignment or waiting for full ideological consensus, they were focusing on self-reliance, a concept central to India's own "Aatmanirbhar" vision. During the Brics summit, PM Narendra Modi had said that the grouping must chart the course of global reform to ensure that the Global South has a greater say in decision-making and the existing "pyramid of privilege" in global governance makes way for a "platform of partnership".

"What unites the emerging and middle powers, is a growing self-awareness of their interest. All of them, in a way, are becoming more self-reliant," Jaishankar said. "It's a term, 'Aatmanirbhar', very much in vogue in India as well. Many of them today are driven by this calculation," he added.

He emphasised that middle powers were increasingly focusing on strategic hedging and pragmatic partnerships. "In many ways, they are working out new arrangements. They are developing agenda-based cooperation."

Stating that India is poised for decades of high economic growth, Jaishankar outlined a forward-looking trajectory for the country's global standing, highlighting India's human-centric vision for artificial intelligence.

"People perceive AI also as something which must become accessible, affordable, and used for a certain socio-economic purpose..." he said. Highlighting the potential of a trade deal, Jaishankar argued that an FTA with the EU would catalyse alignment across the board. Commerce ministry officials last month told HT that India has secured favourable deals in advance for its steel, fisheries and shipping sectors from the EU as the two sides looked on course to sign the "mother of all FTAs" by December and operationalise it early next year.

Indo-Pacific in focus

Separately on Sunday, Jaishankar held talks with Commander of US Pacific Command, Admiral Samuel J Paparo, with focus on boosting bilateral maritime security cooperation in the Indo-Pacific.

A year on, many IIMs yet to submit reservation rosters

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: Nearly a year after the education ministry asked Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs) to prepare and submit reservation rosters for faculty and non-teaching positions, several premier management institutes were still in the process of completing the exercise, according to official documents accessed by HT.

At the first Coordination Forum of IIMs meeting in September 2025, officials flagged "inherent challenges" in implementing the reservation roster, saying it was "difficult to find suitable candidates." By the second meeting on May 14, 2026, the ministry said that category-wise sanctioned-position details were still awaited from eight IIMs — Ahmedabad, Bangalore, Calcutta, Indore, Ranchi, Rohtak, Udaipur and Mumbai — while draft rosters were pending from 10, including Ahmedabad, Bangalore, Calcutta, Indore, Raipur, Ranchi, Rohtak, Udaipur, Nagpur and Sambalpur. This was despite the ministry noting that such information is "frequently sought in Parliament, often five to six times in each session."

There are 22 IIMs in the country. Under the Indian Institute of Management Act, 2017, the forum is an "advisory body", unlike the IIT Council, whose decisions are binding on IITs. The education ministry circulated the minutes to IIMs on June 17, and HT obtained them through a Right to Information (RTI) application last month.



In September 2025, officials flagged 'inherent challenges' in implementing quota roster. HT

The ministry first discussed implementing reservation policies at the forum's September 23, 2025 meeting, when it asked all IIMs to prepare their rosters and share them with the ministry's nodal officer.

The May 2026 minutes record that ministry officials pointed out that several IIMs are yet to share category-wise sanctioned-position details while proposing "mandatory structured training" for IIM liaison officers responsible for reservation implementation.

The forum discussed using post-doctoral fellowships to expand the pool of eligible candidates. "Potential candidates may be identified and initially encouraged to join the Institute as Post Doctoral Fellow (PDF), so that they can be groomed during the period of fellowship as faculty," the minutes said.

Members also suggested supporting candidates from reserved categories at newer IIMs through training and scholarships during the period before they become qualified faculty.

{ SWATANTRATA SENANI EXPRESS } AC COACH REPLACED

Snake on train triggers panic

Bishnu K Jha

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DARBHANGA: A snake slithering through a concealed panel above an upper berth sent passengers into a panic aboard the Swatantrata Senani Superfast Express on Saturday evening, forcing railway authorities to replace the suspected coach at Muzaffarpur as a precaution.

The incident occurred in coach A2, an AC 2-Tier coach of train 12561, which was travelling from Jaynagar to New Delhi. The train departed Jaynagar at



A passenger spotted the snake entering a panel above a berth.

around 5.30pm on Saturday, and shortly afterwards, a passenger spotted the snake entering the panel above an upper berth. The passengers alerted the

The IIM forum also discussed faculty mobility between institutes. The minutes said newer IIMs faced a shortage of experienced and senior faculty while older institutes had a relatively larger pool. It suggested that IIMs collectively evolve a policy allowing newer institutes to temporarily engage senior faculty from older IIMs.

Data obtained through RTI applications by Kiran Kumar Gowd, president of the All India OBC Students Association, provides a separate indication of the extent of vacancies in reserved faculty positions. Responses from nine IIMs — Calcutta, Lucknow, Kozhikode, Amritsar, Jammu, Raipur, Sambalpur, Sirmaur and Visakhapatnam — showed that 58.6% of sanctioned OBC faculty positions, 55.9% of SC positions, 79.6% of ST positions and 77.6% of EWS positions were vacant.

IIM directors have pointed to the availability of qualified candidates as a key challenge. IIM Indore director Prof Himanshu Rai: "The long-term solution involved encouraging more students from under-represented categories to pursue doctoral studies and expanding post-doctoral training, mentoring and faculty-development programmes."

IIM Lucknow director Prof MP Gupta said reservation policies had to be implemented, but added that vacancies could persist when suitable candidates were not available. "There is no benefit to any institution in keeping faculty positions vacant," he said.

WIFE, LOVER HELD FOR KILLING MAN IN DEHRADUN

DEHRADUN: A 30-year-old woman and her 23-year-old lover were arrested on Sunday for allegedly murdering her 38-year-old labourer husband after he learnt of their affair in Dehradun district, police said.

The accused, Lallan Sharma, 23, from Saharsa in Bihar who lives in Premnagar area in the district, was arrested along with the wife of the deceased man, Meena Devi, 30, also from Saharsa, police said.

According to police, the body of Madan Mukhiya, 38, a labourer and resident of Saharsa, was recovered from a forested area in Manduwala, Premnagar, on Saturday. The body bore injuries to the neck caused by a sharp-edged weapon, police said, adding that a knife allegedly used in the crime was also recovered.

SSP Pramendra Dobhal said: "We arrested the accused near Bala Sundari Temple. During questioning, he confessed and disclosed the involvement of the deceased's wife. Meena Devi was subsequently arrested." HT

3 ARRESTED FOR RAPING 13-YR-OLD IN DARJEELING

SILIGURI: A 45-year-old grocery shop owner and his two brothers were arrested on Sunday in Bengal's Darjeeling district for allegedly repeatedly raping a 13-year-old girl, police said.

"The victim's family, which lives in the same village, lodged a complaint at the Phansidewa police station on Saturday after the girl fell ill and told her mother that the shopkeeper and his brothers committed the crime. Local people vandalised the shop when they came to know about the incident," one of the investigating officers said, requesting anonymity.

"The girl said she was allegedly raped multiple times. Doctors confirmed she is pregnant. The accused made videos of the crime and allegedly blackmailed the girl. The family alleged that the accused also threatened to kill her if she told anyone," the officer added. Police were deployed in the area due to the brewing tension.

SDPO Saumyajit Roy said, "The accused were remanded in police custody by a local court on Sunday." PRAMOD GIRI

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



WORLD

No military solution to war, Iran tells US

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

TEHRAN: Iran's top diplomat insisted on Sunday that there would be no military solution to the United States' war against the Islamic republic, with talks on ending the conflict apparently at an impasse.

A campaign of heavy bombardment failed to bring a decisive close to the war launched by the US and Israel in late February, and Washington in recent weeks has dialled back military operations in favour of economic pressure.

The main point of contention remains Iran's attempt to blockade the Strait of Hormuz, a vital conduit for Gulf oil and gas where a UK maritime agency reported on Sunday another tanker struck by an unknown projectile.

"If our enemies again choose the path of military confrontation, our response will be stronger than before, and we will defend ourselves with even more force," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said at a gathering of foreign ambassadors.

"There is no military solution, nor any solution based on new sanctions," he continued, adding "only negotiations based on justice and fairness" could end the conflict.

The two sides agreed a memorandum of understanding in June that spelled out a framework for a permanent resolution, but Iranian attacks on vessels in the Hormuz prompted a return to US military operations.

Iran has sought to impose its control over the vital shipping lane since the start of the war, striking vessels that attempt to transit without its authorisation.

The US has imposed its own



A ferry carries sailors from the USS George HW Bush aircraft carrier to a pier near Phuket Deep Sea Port during a stop following a long deployment in West Asia, in Phuket, Thailand on Sunday. REUTERS

IRAN TO INCREASE THE RANGE OF ITS MISSILES, ARMY TELLS FARS

DUBAI: Iran will upgrade the range of its missiles following the war with the US as American forces are now positioned as much as 1,000 km away from the Iranian coast, Army spokesperson Mohammad Akraminia told Fars news on Sunday. "During this war, we concluded that we absolutely must increase the range of our missiles, and we have now moved in that direction," he said. REUTERS

counterblockade of Iranian ports, and has also struck vessels it accuses of violating it.

On Sunday, the British maritime security agency UKMTO said a tanker in the Hormuz "reported being struck by an unknown projectile, causing damage to the engine room", though the crew were reported safe and no environmental impact was recorded. It did not say what kind of vessel it was.

Trump: US will decide on Iran, easy or hard way

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Saturday (local time) said that Washington will take a decision on Iran, stating that the outcome would come either the "easy way or the hard way", while asserting that Iran has been "decimated".

"We have a decision that I'll make about Iran. Iran's been decimated. So the only question is, it'll either be the easy way or the hard way. We'll have it the easy way or the hard way," Trump said to reporters outside the White House.

Trump's remarks came as he continued to withhold details of his forthcoming actions concerning Iran, while saying that the situation was progressing favourably and that Iran was not doing well.

Speaking to reporters on Friday, Trump, when asked about

his upcoming strategy regarding Iran, initially suggested that revealing his plans would generate significant headlines.

"If I told you, you'd have a major story, right? But you'll see. Working out very well. Iran is not doing well," Trump said.

The US President did not provide further details about potential administration measures or a timeline for his next steps.

Earlier, Trump said that the war with Iran would conclude "very quickly" and forecast a sharp decline in oil prices once the hostilities ended, while describing Tehran as heavily degraded economically and militarily.

Speaking to reporters in Texas, Trump said Iran faced a decisive choice over how the conflict would end. "Iran will very soon be ending one way or the other," Trump said. ANI

Australia probes flydubai co-pilot's links to country

Reuters

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SYDNEY/TEL AVIV: A multi-agency Australian counterterrorism unit is probing links to Australia of the co-pilot of flydubai flight FZ1073, who stabbed his captain and then attempted to hijack the plane, a police spokesperson said on Sunday.

The Victorian Joint Counter Terrorism Team - which comprises federal police, Victorian state police and the ASIO intelligence agency - were "investigating the man's links to Australia," the Australian Federal Police spokesperson said.

Two sources briefed on the investigation said the co-pilot studied at a university in Melbourne, capital of the Australian state of Victoria. A third source said he studied at RMIT University around a decade ago. RMIT declined to comment.

The co-pilot of the flydubai flight FZ1073, which was bound for Israel from Dubai on Wednesday, attacked the pilot with an emergency crash axe, the UAE prosecutor general said on Saturday, calling the incident a "terrorist attack".

Flight FZ1073 would have felt like a "vertical roller coaster", when it plunged 16,000 feet in about 30 seconds before being levelled out and landing safely, according to an aviation instructor who recreated the descent in a flight simulator.

Two sources have said the co-pilot is an Omani national

named Hamam Al-Hamami. Israeli officials have not named the co-pilot but said that he is from Oman. UAE authorities and flydubai have not publicly disclosed the co-pilot's identity.

Reuters could not independently reach Al-Hamami, who is in UAE custody, for comment. The UAE has not announced any formal charges against him and it is not known if he has appointed legal counsel. Oman has not commented on the incident. Disaster on board flight FZ1073 was averted after passengers and crew subdued the co-pilot, who had attacked the captain in what Israeli officials said was an attempt to crash the plane carrying more than 170 passengers and crew. The UAE public prosecutor has said the co-pilot had attempted to take control of the plane.

Most of the passengers on board were Israeli nationals.

A reserve flydubai pilot travelling on the flight took control of the aircraft and landed it at Tabuk airport in northwestern Saudi Arabia, where the co-pilot was detained by Saudi authorities and later transferred to the UAE on Thursday.

The Financial Times reported on Sunday that Al-Hamami had allegedly visited what it described as radical mosques and extremist websites while in Australia, citing two people familiar with the investigation. Australian intelligence services held a file on the individual, according to the FT.



(Top) Flydubai passengers react after realising there is a commotion in the cockpit on September 30; (left) this image taken from a video provided by a passenger shows the co-pilot after he was detained by passengers, in Saudi Arabia. REUTERS & AP

UAE shared pilots' details with Israel before flight, say officials

Associated Press

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TEL AVIV: Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the flydubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection.

With the investigation underway, preliminary details about the incident have highlighted several major security lapses. Officials already have said the Omani co-pilot had been barred from flying by his own country because of concerns about his extremist views. It also remains unclear how a citizen of Oman, an Arab country that has no diplomatic relations with Israel, was allowed to fly a planeload of Israelis to Tel Aviv.

UAE, which is leading the probe, said the co-pilot attacked the flight's captain with the cock-

REGIONAL OFFICIALS SAID ISRAEL HADN'T RAISED RED FLAGS ON ANY PASSENGER OR MEMBER OF THE CREW

pit's crash ax and tried to take control of the plummeting plane in a "terrorist attack". His actions nearly crashed the flight with 182 people on board before the Indian captain managed to open the cockpit door, allowing passengers and others to rush in and subdued the attacker.

The regional officials said Emirati authorities had shared information about the passengers and crew, including their nationalities. Israel hadn't raised red flags on any passenger or member of the crew, said the officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to

reporters about the probe.

The Shin Bet, Israel's domestic security agency, said the Transportation Ministry is responsible for vetting passenger lists from foreign flights. Transportation Minister Miri Regev told Israel's public broadcaster Kan that the security agencies are responsible for flight security, and that her ministry wasn't given a list of passengers or any warnings.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel has agreements with foreign carriers to keep pilots from flying into the country if they are citizens of nations that don't maintain diplomatic relations with Israel.

HT

Musk says he will rename SpaceX AI to SpaceXSI

BENGALURU: SpaceX CEO Elon Musk posted on Sunday that he would rename the company's AI unit to SpaceXSI, following Donald Trump's push to use the term "super intelligence" instead of "artificial intelligence." "Yes, we will make that change," he replied to a user on X asking him about the possibility of renaming SpaceXAI to SpaceXSI. REUTERS

Shooter fires on hunting party in Norway, kills two

OSLO: Two people were shot dead and a third seriously wounded in a hunting incident in Norway, police said on Sunday. A suspect has been arrested after the shooting on Sunday morning in Halden, 120 km south of Oslo, police said. Police said the shooting circumstances were unclear. AFP

2 shot dead in US, dozens injured in shooting at party

VIENNA: Two people were shot to death and nearly three dozen others were injured at a block party on Sunday in Vienna, Georgia, police said. Police did not specify how many of the 35 injured had been shot. Victims were taken to several hospitals to be treated, police said. AP

Search for missing Bermuda-Boston flight ongoing

NANTUCKET: A search continued Sunday off the Massachusetts coast for an air ambulance carrying six people that disappeared during a flight from Bermuda to Boston as authorities planned to comb the seabed floor, the US Coast Guard said. Authorities have since searched an area encompassing 7,356 sqkm. AP

Uproar from Japan after US Marine robs and murders woman in hotel

Associated Press

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TOKYO: Japanese police arrested a US Marine in the alleged robbery and murder of a woman on Okinawa, officials said Sunday, the latest criminal case on the southern island where the heavy American troop presence has remained a sensitive issue.

The Okinawa prefectural police said they arrested a 20-year-old Marine stationed at the Futenma Air Station on sus-

picion of killing a 39-year-old local woman at a hotel in Naha, Okinawa's capital city, and taking her wallet and backpack in the early hours of Saturday.

Kyodo News agency, citing the police, reported the woman's body was found in her hotel room and she appeared to have been strangled to death.

Police said security camera footage showed the man believed to be the suspect entering the hotel with the victim and coming out alone.

"The case deals a major shock and adds fear to the Okinawans who have already been forced to live next to US bases," Okinawa governor Genta Koja said.

Some 50,000 US troops are deployed in Japan under a bilateral security pact, about half of them on Okinawa. Okinawans have long complained about noise, pollution and crime related to US bases.

Foreign minister Toshimitsu Motegi summoned the US ambassador to his office.



Kim Jong Un and his daughter Kim Ju Ae watch the launch. REUTERS

Kim sees launch of missile that uses AI

Agence France-Presse

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SEOUL: North Korean leader Kim Jong Un oversaw the launch of a missile with his daughter, state media reported on Sunday, which allegedly used artificial intelligence to adjust its trajectory. The AI technology means the missile is "capable of changing its flight orbit at a low altitude", Kim's powerful sister had said, adding this meant there was "no way to avoid" the attack.

It launched from an area around the eastern coastal city of Wonsan early Saturday morning and flew more than 700 kilometres (435 miles), South Korea's military said, without giving further details.

"Through today's launching drill, the strategic missile soldiers have fully demonstrated their professional qualifications and counterattack posture," Kim said after overseeing the launch,

according to an English-language dispatch by the official Korean Central News Agency.

"We must continue our responsible efforts nonstop to constantly and repeatedly make the enemy recognize the reliability and fatality of our strategic offensive means," he added.

Photos released by KCNA showed a missile soaring into the sky in a burst of orange flame. Another photo showed Kim smiling, flanked by his daughter Ju Ae and wife Ri Sol Ju, who is seen clapping her hands in celebration.

Ju Ae, who was first introduced to the public in 2022, is the most likely successor to her father according to South Korea's spy agency, citing her increasingly prominent role at major state and military events. The launch was conducted to help train soldiers operating the "hypersonic strategic weapon system", KCNA reported.

Russia hits Kyiv as Merz visits city

Associated Press

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KYIV: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced a new aid package for Ukraine worth more than 1.3 billion euros (\$1.5 billion) during a visit to Kyiv on Sunday, as Russia escalated its attacks on Ukrainian cities.

The aerial war has intensified, with Moscow menacing cities across Ukraine with hard-to-intercept ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones, while Kyiv has been striking Russia's oil industry and businesses.

About 1 billion euros (\$1.1 billion) of the package is military aid, including long-range strike weapons, combat drones and satellite technology, "so that Ukraine can also target Russian launch pads," Merz said at a news conference. Germany is



A bridge hit by a Russian drone strike in Kyiv on Sunday. REUTERS

also providing some 350 million euros (\$395 million) in energy aid ahead of winter for repairs, substations and gas work, he said.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the two countries also signed 15 agreements worth more than 8.5 billion euros (\$9.6 billion), mostly covering security cooperation, weapons production and pro-

dymyr Zelenskyy said the two countries also signed 15 agreements worth more than 8.5 billion euros (\$9.6 billion), mostly covering security cooperation, weapons production and pro-

Woman at centre of Cornell University rape allegations targeted with threats, lawyer says

Reuters

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WASHINGTON: The woman who has alleged that she was sexually abused and raped by Cornell University students has been the target of threats, her lawyer said on Sunday.

Thomas Giuffra, who represents the woman identified as "Jane Doe," told CNN that people have threatened to silence or harm her if she does not withdraw her civil lawsuit alleging

that several members of a Cornell fraternity drugged and raped her in 2024.

"She's received multiple threats," Giuffra said on CNN's "State of the Union." Giuffra said he had also been threatened. "I'm not afraid of these people," he said. "But the threats, the abuse to protect what's going on, the status quo - these guys are disgusting. They should stay in their mother's basement and stay out of the world."

Cornell University President Michael Kotlikoff said in a video message on Saturday that the university will examine the role of fraternities and sororities on campus following the outcry over the school's handling of the rape allegations.

"At their best, these organizations can provide students with friendship, belonging, mentorship and a powerful sense of community," he said. "But being part of a group can never diminish individual responsibility."

Since the lawsuit was filed last month, prosecutors in New York have been criticised for their initial handling of the allegations in 2024. New York governor Kathy Hochul last week named state Attorney General Letitia James as special prosecutor to look into the case. Donald Trump, a critic of James for years, lambasted the decision to appoint her. "And I feel badly for whoever she's looking at because they won't get a fair shake," Trump said.

GLOBAL EXPERTS CALL FOR ACTION ON DIGITAL HEALTH RISKS TO CHILDREN

Rhythmia Kaul

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NEW DELHI: The way digital technologies are currently built and governed creates real risks to health worldwide, alongside genuine benefits, according to a new three paper series authored by 13 global experts, published in The Lancet. The authors call for coordinated governance of digital systems, with the health of children and youths be made an immediate global policy priority. The authors caution that the certainty of the findings for both harms and benefits is low.

"The evidence linking problematic digital media use to poorer mental health, sleep and physical activity, although not conclusive, justifies coordinated, global action. With the right governance, a healthier digital world for young people is possible," said series chair Professor Ilona Kickbusch, Digital Transformations for Health Lab (DTH-Lab) (Switzerland).

A new umbrella review (a review of published reviews) for the series, covering nine million people under 25 across 121 reviews, finds consistent associations between problematic digital media use (defined by the series as addiction-like patterns of digital media use, rather than by time spent online) and a range of adverse health outcomes for children, adolescents and young adults. Problematic digital media use is linked to a common mental health problems, sleep problems, and reduced physical activity.

Cash, derivatives volumes sink as oil, bond yields hit sentiment

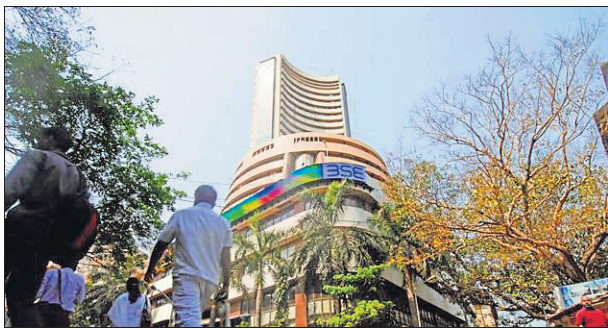
Ram Sahgal

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MUMBAI : Trading activity in Indian stock markets fell sharply in the September quarter, with volumes in both the cash and derivatives segments declining as rising global bond yields, foreign outflows and new regulatory curbs on traders weighed on sentiment.

The combined average daily equity cash volume of NSE and BSE fell 11.7% sequentially to ₹1.29 lakh crore in July-September, reversing a 13% rise in the preceding quarter, according to exchange data. The combined average daily index-options premium volume fell by a sharper 27% to ₹63,326 crore over the same period—extending an 11% decline in the April-June quarter, and marking a second straight quarterly drop.

The slowdown reflects a confluence of pressures. A surge in oil prices, driven by the US-Iran war and disruptions to global supplies, has pushed up bond yields and heightened volatility, while US Treasury yields—at



Foreign portfolio investors sold ₹1.38 lakh crore of Indian equities in the fiscal year through October 1.

MINT

their highest level in more than two decades—have driven foreign investors out of Indian assets. A revival in volumes may hinge on two swing factors: a de-escalation of the war in West Asia, and whether the market regulator delays rules pertaining to weekly options settlement on expiry days.

"Incremental flows have clearly reduced as investors have been losing by averaging on the downside, which is behind fewer transactions in both cash and derivatives segments," said inde-

pendent market analyst Ambareesh Baliga. Baliga also said that the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) funding curbs on proprietary traders, and teething troubles with the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (Sebi's) newly introduced closing auction, have dented domestic participation in both cash and derivatives markets.

The Nifty 500 declined 4% to 22,072 during the September quarter—a sharp reversal from the nearly 10% gain it posted in the first quarter of FY27. The

reversal mirrors oil's own swing — Brent crude rose 34% to \$98 a barrel during the September quarter, after sliding 38% to \$73 a barrel in the June quarter, according to Investing.com. The sharp rise in crude prices has been a primary reason for the market's underperformance.

Foreign portfolio investors sold ₹1.38 lakh crore of Indian equities in the fiscal year through October 1, after a record ₹1.8 lakh crore of selling in FY26, adding to market volatility and weighing on overall participation.

Following this, the yield on the benchmark 10-year Indian government bond rose 43 basis points (one basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point) to 7.18% during the September quarter, according to Investing.com. Hopes of a resolution to the West Asia conflict had driven the yield down by 21 basis points to 6.75% during the first quarter.

Other factors weighing on volumes include an RBI regulation requiring banks to fund proprietary traders only against full collateral from July, and the new closing auction session (CAS)

introduced by Sebi from 3 August.

"Q2 has been a bit challenging for the broking industry," said Ashish Nanda, chief digital business officer at Kotak Neo, underscoring the fall in volumes.

Analysts are split on the prospects for a recovery in volumes, especially in the cash market, but expect options volumes to pick up if Sebi defers the CAS requirement for derivatives settlements on weekly expiry days.

"Sebi is likely to defer the CAS for derivatives settlement on weekly expiry days for a year, while retaining it on non-expiry days, so many persons absent from derivatives trading will return to the fold and volumes will rise," said DK Aggarwal, chairman and managing director of SMC Capitals Ltd. "I expect cash market volumes to pick up too, especially if crude remains at or below \$100 a barrel." However, SK Joshi, consultant at Khambatta Securities, said that while he expects options volumes to pick up, cash-market volumes could remain subdued amid higher market volatility.

Rising inflation sets stage for a rate hike

Subhana Shaikh

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MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is expected to raise interest rates this week for the first time since February 2023, as a sharp shift in the global rate environment and rising inflation risks push the central bank towards monetary tightening. The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) may raise the key repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50% on 7 October, according to nine of 10 economists surveyed by Mint, with only one respondent expecting a pause. All expect the rate-setting panel to retain its neutral stance, signaling that the central bank wants to keep its options open rather than commit to a prolonged hiking cycle.

The expected hike comes as a surge in global commodity prices threatens to fan inflation, which rose to a 22-month high of 4.8% in August—above the central bank's 4% midpoint target. Consumer prices are also under pressure from a deficient monsoon and imported inflation amid a weakening rupee.

"Since the last policy, the global environment has completely changed with higher rates and growth holding up along with a build-up of inflation," said Sameer Narang, chief economist at ICICI Bank.

"Inflation in Q2 should be above RBI's trajectory with below-normal monsoon pushing food prices higher. However, the global environment may change once again, which doesn't call for committing to any path because of which stance change may not be required," Narang said.

Rising inflationary pressures and a wave of rate hikes by global central banks, including the US Federal Reserve, have led economists to move up their expectations for India's rate increases from December or February.

"There are two reasons why we are changing the timing of rate hikes to October and December (25 basis points each), from our earlier expectation of



The expected hike comes as a surge in global commodity prices threatens to fan inflation.

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December and February 2027 of 25 bps each, attuned to the current reality of elevated global oil prices, we expect upward revisions to both the growth and inflation forecasts, which offer a solid backdrop to commence a monetary tightening cycle," Barclays said in a report on 1 October. The inflation outlook is the clearest reason for the expected hike. Economists see price pressures broadening beyond a few food items, with higher crude oil prices, a weak monsoon and rising global commodity costs adding to the risks. The RBI's August forecast put consumer price index (CPI) inflation at 5% for fiscal year 2027 (FY27), but several economists now expect the central bank to raise that projection.

Barclays expects FY27 inflation to be revised higher from 5%, with its own forecast at 4.8%, but with upside risks if crude remains above \$100 a barrel. It also expects another round of retail fuel-price increases if elevated oil prices persist. Gaura Sengupta, chief economist at IDFC FIRST Bank, expects headline CPI inflation for FY27 at 5.2%.

"The September FOMC (Federal Open Market Committee) hike, elevated US Treasury yields and our expectation of further Fed tightening reinforce the case for earlier RBI rate action, particularly amid renewed Middle East conflict-driven upside risks to global crude oil prices,"

according to a Goldman Sachs report, adding that it expects the RBI to raise rates by 25 bps in October and December each.

Broadly, economists expect the RBI's hiking cycle to extend beyond October, but see it as shallow, with most forecasts clustered around 50-75 bps of cumulative tightening and the cycle likely to run through December or February 2027. The RBI's last rate-hiking cycle ran from May 2022 to February 2023, during which the MPC cumulatively raised the repo rate by 250 bps.

Meanwhile, growth is giving the RBI greater room to prioritise price stability over supporting demand. GDP growth of 7.8% in April-June was 80 basis points above the RBI's August forecast.

High-frequency indicators suggest that momentum has remained relatively firm in the second quarter, even though some indicators have moderated. That strength is prompting economists to expect the RBI to raise its FY27 growth forecast from 6.7%.

Barclays has lifted its own FY27 growth projection to 7.1%, citing stronger-than-expected Q1 performance, while Sengupta expects growth of around 7.5% in FY27, although she sees some moderation in the second half from the high base, led by weaker rural demand and pressure on corporate margins.

BofA Global Research is even more hawkish and expects the RBI to revise its growth estimate higher. It has raised its forecast for cumulative rate hikes to 100 bps from 50 bps earlier, with a 25 bps hike in October as the starting point.

Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at Bank of Baroda, is the only outlier, expecting the RBI to leave the repo rate unchanged in October.

His rationale is that a hike just before the festival season could weigh on consumption and that the RBI could wait for more clarity from September and October inflation data. Even so, Sabnavis expects 50-75 bps of hikes over the cycle.

DLF SELLS OUT ITS MAIDEN SENIOR LIVING PROJECT FOR ₹1,985 CRORE

Madhurima Nandy

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BENGALURU: Real estate major DLF Ltd on Sunday said it has fully sold out its project named The Aureva in Gurugram's Sector 63, marking its entry into the retirement living segment.

The project has achieved sales of ₹1985 crore, underscoring strong demand for luxury retirement living communities. Spread across 4.17 acres, the project comprises 172, four-bedroom residences with a total saleable area of over 750,000 sq. ft. It will be developed as a standalone tower rising ground-plus-45 floors.

The residences will have dedicated staff dormitories and private decks.

Each residence is complemented by three parking spaces and access to a suite of wellness, recreational, and lifestyle amenities.

Average ticket size of an apartment is ₹11.5 crore, at ₹28,000 per sq. ft. The project was sold out in a matter of days after DLF held a channel partner introduction meeting on 25 September.

"We were surprised by the response to the project. We got 406 confirmed EOIs (expressions of interest) within the first 48 hours. The Aureva represents DLF's vision of redefining luxury retirement housing in India. As expectations evolve beyond traditional markers of luxury, residents increasingly seek homes that enhance everyday life through thoughtful design, holistic wellbeing, seamless convenience, and a strong sense of community," Aakash Ohri, MD and chief business officer, DLF Home Developers Ltd told Mint.

New-age firms seek to reallocate IPO proceeds for better returns

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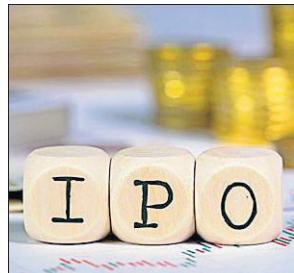
MUMBAI: Listed new-age companies are changing how they deploy initial public offering (IPO) proceeds, seeking higher-yielding growth opportunities as execution delays extend planned timelines. At least four new-age firms listed since mid-2025 are considering realigning ₹500-700 crore of proceeds from their primary issues, according to multiple industry executives Mint spoke to.

"Instead of leaving IPO proceeds idle in low-yielding deposits, we are opting to revise the deployment plans through a shareholder approval," an executive from one of the companies said on condition of anonymity. "Proxy advisory firms and minority (shareholder) groups may raise questions, so the delta of pivoting towards higher-return projects needs to be clearly established."

Another executive said that "plans like these need to be ratified at multiple levels, and will take at least six months before materializing."

Typically, Indian companies transfer net IPO proceeds from public issue escrow accounts to issue-monitoring accounts or current accounts with scheduled commercial banks before deploying them as outlined in their offer documents. Funds held in such accounts earn 4-6% annually.

Brainbees Solutions Ltd, the parent company of omnichannel retailer for baby and maternity products FirstCry, said on 31 August that it was seeking shareholder approval to change the use of ₹280 crore of its IPO proceeds, which would entail a reduction in funds earmarked



Firms are seeking shareholder approval to change fund deployment.

ISTOCKPHOTO

for expansion in Saudi Arabia and the opening of standalone Babyhug stores in India.

Fintech firm One Mobikwik Systems Ltd said on 2 June that it plans to divert ₹61 crore originally earmarked for the organic growth of its financial services business to its wholly owned subsidiary, Mobikwik Distribution Services Pvt. Ltd. Other than that, it also sought approval to reallocate ₹34 crore from the payment devices business to its payment services business.

Bhavish Aggarwal's electric two-wheeler maker Ola Electric Mobility Ltd on 18 March made a fresh revision in the utilization of its ₹5,500 crore IPO proceeds, reallocating ₹575 crore from its research and development (R&D) budget towards debt repayment and growth initiatives. This marked Ola Electric's second revision to its use of IPO proceeds, following an earlier reallocation approved by shareholders in August 2025 that reduced the R&D allocation while increasing the share earmarked for debt repayment and organic growth.

"New-age firms operate in rapidly changing environments and must continuously adapt their strategies to emerging

opportunities and challenges," said Raghuram K., partner, accounting and reporting consulting, Unicus Consultech Inc.

"Such strategic shifts may, in certain cases, necessitate a corresponding change in the utilization of IPO proceeds. However, this is unlikely to be a uniform trend across sectors; the impact will depend on the specific business environment and evolving priorities of individual companies," he said.

External headwinds have further widened the gap between initial fundraising targets and on-the-ground operational deployment, according to a top lawyer who deals with capital market transactions.

"This year, geopolitical conflicts, currency fluctuations and crude oil price volatility have disrupted pre-IPO projections across sectors," said Siddhartha Desai, a principal associate at law firm JSA, where he specializes in public and private capital market transactions. "Promoters and boards are realizing that sticking rigidly to original IPO end-use projections often does not make financial sense given the volatile market," he added, while explaining how, historically, companies rarely change their stated IPO object clauses, often forcing underperforming plans forward.

Desai said altering capital plans helps protect project internal rates of return and operational metrics, aiding management teams in securing shareholder approval.

"In most cases, reallocations are better understood as management responding to evolving market realities rather than necessarily reflecting shortcomings in pre-IPO financial forecasting," said Raghuram.

AUTOMAKERS RAMP UP STOCKS TO MEET STRONG FESTIVE DEMAND

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: Leading automakers are ramping up production and building dealer inventory to meet strong customer demand as India enters the peak festive buying season, with manufacturers seeking to ensure adequate vehicle availability and convert healthy bookings into retail sales. Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India has 2.2 lakh pending bookings ahead of the festive season, while Hyundai Motor India has built four-five weeks of inventory across its dealer network. Mahindra & Mahindra, meanwhile, has scaled up its utility vehicle and electric vehicle manufacturing capacity to 68,000 units a month to improve supply and bring down waiting periods. Maruti Suzuki India's senior executive Officer Partho Banerjee told PTI, "At the beginning of this financial year, we had 12 days of stock. The current bookings pendency is 2.2 lakhs, which translates to 16 days of stock before the festive season."

"We have already commissioned two new production lines, adding 5 lakhs capacity in total. The production is being ramped up gradually, and we expect these lines to fully stabilise by year-end." He shared that the company is calibrating production and supplies across models to prevent waiting periods from rising disproportionately for individual vehicles during the festive period. "For Maruti Suzuki, our supply chain and production teams are putting in efforts and trying to meet the festive demand. However, due to supply constraints, we may introduce special schemes for our pending booking customers," Banerjee said.

Tata Assam chip unit signs up non-China tech suppliers

Shouvik Das

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NEW DELHI: Tata Electronics Pvt. Ltd has rapidly built a network of technology suppliers outside China to reduce the risk of supply disruptions at India's largest semiconductor assembly facility it is building in Assam.

Mint has identified at least nine non-Chinese suppliers—including Singapore's ASMT, the Netherlands' Nexperia, Japan's Fujifilm and Malaysia's Kelington—that Tata Electronics has signed up for what will be India's third outsourced semiconductor assembly and test (Osat) facility, slated to start production in December. These vendors will supply a wide range of equipment and raw materials, and provide services to support Tata's chip packaging and assembly operations, two senior executives with direct knowledge of the matter said.

"Overall, the goal for Tata Electronics is to develop and maintain a widely diversified supply chain of vendor partners that are not concentrated in one geography. The idea is that in the current world, with unpredictable tariffs and geopolitical bargaining, India's semiconduc-

tor operations, which are finally on the verge of actually commencing, should not be prematurely halted because the commercial companies subsidized using public money are abruptly cut off from supplies of critical components," one of the two executives said on the condition of anonymity.

The strategy is driven by technology export curbs put in place by various countries including China, as well as recent disruptions arising from the West Asia war. By cultivating new vendor networks, Tata aims to ensure India's flagship semiconductor venture remains resilient against potential trade blockades, retaliatory mineral curbs, and broader geopolitical shocks.

The non-China partnerships include ASMT for training and servicing software, spares, wire-bond circuitry and integrated circuit assembly; Nexperia for bringing European semiconductor supply chain vendors to India and chip testing and manufacturing of automotive products; Fujifilm to localize production and sourcing of semiconductor raw material; and Kelington for machinery and infrastructure, according to the



The strategy is driven by technology export curbs put in place by various countries.

AFP

two executives cited earlier.

Typically, Osat supply chains have 55-60% of their suppliers based in China, the second executive said, without sharing an estimate on Tata's dependence on China. The first executive added that for the company, "the goal was not to leave China and China-based partners out—but to build a diversified set of alternatives."

Operated under Tata Semiconductor Assembly and Test (TSAT) Pvt. Ltd, the Osat plant in Assam's Jajiroad was announced on 29 February 2024. The project had an initial

net budget of ₹27,000 crore, alongside Tata's commercial chip fab in Gujarat's Dholera, announced at a net project cost of ₹91,000 crore. A semiconductor fabrication plant manufactures the actual silicon wafers containing numerous transistors, while an Osat facility cuts them into individual chips, packages them in protective housings, and tests them for final use. Both projects are backed by state and central subsidies totalling 70% of the net capital required, leaving the Tata Group to invest ₹35,400 crore into its two initiatives.

The second executive said the move to diversify the supply chain "is a part of Tata Electronics' long-term boardroom strategy." "While the general perception could be to see such a diversification as an anti-China policy, that is not quite the case. The main point of focus here should be that a geopolitically diversified supply chain is the need of the hour for various reasons. Quite simply put, outages of critical gases due to the Middle East war is one reason why suppliers should also be located elsewhere, in order to see how far a critical commercial venture that oper-

ates in semiconductor assemblies can be protected from sudden global supply chain shocks," the executive added.

Tata Electronics did not respond to emailed questions.

Tata's early rivals in the nascent industry include US chipmaker Micron, alongside domestic players Keynes Technology, CG Power, and an HCL-Foxconn joint venture.

Tata Group holding company Tata Sons is the parent of Tata Electronics, which is leading the group's push into high-tech manufacturing, including assembling iPhones for Apple. Tata Electronics is also building its semiconductor business through TSAT, which has yet to start generating significant revenue. Over the past three fiscal years, it has incurred ₹575.54 crore in losses, though such initial losses are common for startups in capital-intensive sectors.

Industry stakeholders said the Assam unit will be a key part of the profitability drive for the larger Tata Electronics umbrella, which includes the entity's smartphone assembly division and a third entity that operates the pure-play semiconductor fabrication plant in Gujarat's Dholera.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

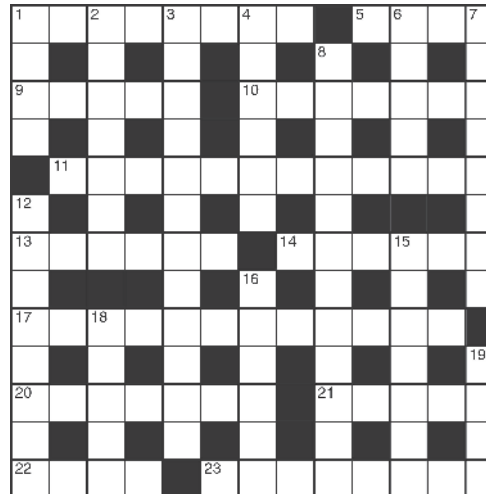
- 1 Girl straddles a horse belonging to James (8)
- 5 Look for a sign that a chick has hatched (4)
- 9 It's boring for a doctor being unwell (5)
- 10 Show sluggishness, i.e. train sloppily (7)
- 11 Honest player but not a grand one (7,5)
- 12 Was shifty and naturally guarded (6)
- 14 It's still produced in Ireland though illegally (6)
- 17 Characteristic chance in store for the theatre (8,4)
- 20 It gives pain to the listener (7)
- 21 Former French island Napoleon went into (5)
- 22 One four-letter word in place of another? (4)
- 23 Apprentices the boss sent out (8)

DOWN

- 1 One may get belted taking part in this sport (4)
- 2 A politician shouted about being inhibited (7)
- 3 It's shown by one looking for scraps (12)
- 4 Land set on fire? (6)
- 6 A minor player makes more (5)
- 7 Army units also included in schemes (8)
- 8 Remain calm and avoid being executed (4,4)
- 12 The lamb's tender (8)
- 15 Noise or disturbance can be wearing (7)
- 16 A road tester perhaps (6)
- 18 Horrors concealed in the gorse (5)
- 19 Elizabeth, a superior lady deserted by a sailor (4)

PUZZLE 17608

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QUICK CLUES

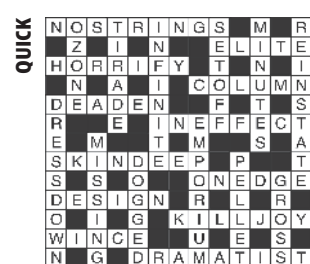
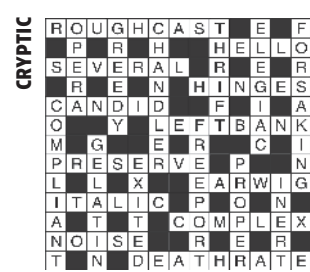
ACROSS

- 1 Inconvenient (8)
- 5 Norwegian capital (4)
- 9 Substantial (5)
- 10 North American open grassland (7)
- 11 Mature (5-7)
- 13 Venue of 2004 Olympics (6)
- 14 Middle East kingdom (6)
- 15 Noise or disturbance can be wearing (7)
- 16 A road tester perhaps (6)
- 18 Horrors concealed in the gorse (5)
- 19 Elizabeth, a superior lady deserted by a sailor (4)

DOWN

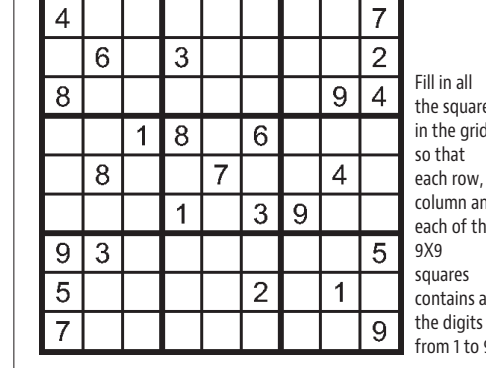
- 1 Threatening (4)
- 2 By means of (7)
- 3 Engage in business scheming (5,3,4)
- 4 To fleece (3,3)
- 6 Small shoot (5)
- 7 Exaggerated (8)
- 8 To dupe (4,3,1,4)
- 12 Opera by Wagner (8)
- 15 Lay down the law (7)
- 16 Vet for loyalty, reliability etc. (6)
- 18 Declare invalid (5)
- 19 Immediately adjacent (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17607)

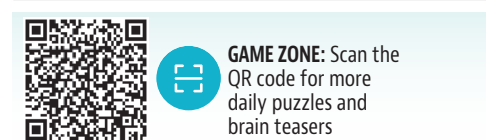


{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★



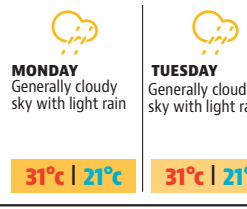
Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



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{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

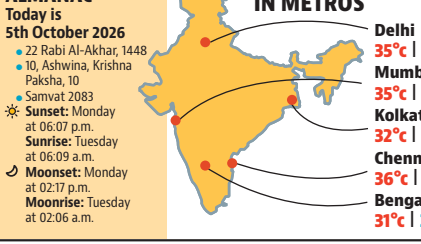


ALMANAC

Today is 5th October 2026
• 22 Rabi Al-Akhar, 1448
• 10, Ashwina, Krishna
• Paksha, 10
• Samvat 2083
• Sunset: Monday at 06:07 p.m.
• Sunrise: Tuesday at 02:17 p.m.
• Moonset: Monday at 02:06 a.m.



TEMPERATURE IN METROS



SPORT

‘People are mistaken in the way they talk about Uruguay’

There’s much more to two-time world champions than playing rough, says their head coach Diego Forlan

Dhiman Sarkar
dhiman@htlive.com

KOLKATA: As has been seen at Leeds United, Marseille and Chile, it is not easy to succeed Marcelo Bielsa. But that’s not why, even as he spoke of 2030, Diego Forlan was not looking too far ahead. His contract after replacing Bielsa as Uruguay head coach is till March 2027.

Asked why he agreed, Forlan, who has 112 caps and 36 goals for Uruguay and won the Golden Ball in the 2010 World Cup, simply said: “Well, the offer was not permanent.”

He still accepted because “it is a great opportunity.” That he took charge after Uruguay were the highest ranked team to exit from the group stage of a 48-team World Cup mattered little, he said. Ranked 19th at the last World Cup, Uruguay are 20th in the world now.

Forlan is also in charge of the under-20 team which he will take to the South American qualifiers for the under-20 World Cup next January.

“Let’s see if I have the chance to continue to the World Cup in 2030 where we are going to have the opportunity to play our first game in Uruguay after 100 years,” he said with a smile.

To mark 100 years of the World Cup, Uruguay, where the first edition was held, will host one match in 2030.

Forlan, 47, is not looking beyond his next game, which will be against India on Tuesday, but he spoke on a wide range of subjects with a small group of jour-

nalists. From the Oscar Tabarez years, Uruguay’s reputation for playing rough and his last visit to Kolkata which ended in a red card, nothing was off topic.

Uruguay are remembered as much for their physical brand of football as being twice Olympic champions (1924, 1928), World Cup winners in 1930 and 1950 and semi-finalists in 1954, 1970 and 2010.

Jose Batista’s 56-second red card against Scotland in the 1986 finals, Luis Suarez biting opponents at club and country, Cavani’s red card in the 2015 Copa America after being provoked by Chile’s Gonzalo Jara and 26 fouls in the 2024 Copa quarter-final against Brazil may have reinforced that opinion.

“I think sometimes people are mistaken a little bit in the way they talk about the way Uruguay play,” said Forlan. “It is not because of how tough we are. It is the way we play till the end of the game. It doesn’t matter who we play but we will make it difficult for the opponents.” Feisty, yes. Fighters, no. “We have great players, a great national team.”

One which is in Kolkata after beating South Korea 4-1. Federico Valverde didn’t travel because of injury but Rodrigo Bentancur, Lucas Torreira, Darwin Nunez, Rodrigo Zalazar and Ronald Araujo are in the city where Enzo Francescoli, one of Uruguay’s greatest players, made his international debut 44 years ago. “I didn’t know that. Unbelievable,” said Forlan.

Forlan has little experience as manager. He was in charge of Penarol and then Atenas in the Uruguayan second division but the last of his jobs was in 2021. But he has been one of the best footballers his country of 3 million people has produced. One whose father was an international and his first coach.

The experience of being an elite player, he said, can be an



Diego Forlan is in Kolkata with the Uruguay national team. AUF

advantage. “When you are a manager, of course, it is different but if you were an intelligent player, if you use common sense, in time you would know what to do.

“It’s not because I won the Golden Ball everything I say will be correct. So, I try to use a lot of common sense. (make sure the players) enjoy what they are doing. Of course, as a manager I will have a way of playing, a way of trying to do things.”

Forlan played under Tabarez who has in charge of the national team for 15 years (2006-21) in his second stint. In five years since, Uruguay have appointed four coaches. The situation is like how it has been at Manchester United where Forlan played two seasons from 2002. “With every manager it is a different story but it is about results. In the beginning with Tabarez everything was not that good. He was so near to being

Let’s see if I have the chance to continue to the World Cup in 2030 where we are going to have the opportunity to play our first game in Uruguay after 100 years

I think sometimes people are mistaken a little bit in the way they talk about the way Uruguay play,” said Forlan. “It is not because of how tough we are. It is the way we play till the end of the game. It doesn’t matter who we play but we will make it difficult for the opponents — Diego Forlan Uruguay head coach

sacked. But he stayed and he did what everybody knows in 2010 and 2011. We did a great World Cup. In 2011, we won the Copa America.”

Fourth-place in the 2013 Confederations Cup, quarter-finals in 2018 World Cup finals and a 13-game unbeaten run in 2019 were the other highlights of Tabarez’s time as head coach.

Forlan has pleasant memories of his time with Mumbai City FC in 2016. “We had a really nice group.” About Kolkata, not so much. “I was sent off in the (first leg) of the semi-final here. I was disappointed because I think if I wasn’t sent off, I think we should have won.”

After coming back to lead 2-1, Mumbai City FC lost 2-3 and drew 0-0 at home. “Sunil (Chhetri), great player but could not score (in the return leg).”

Forlan will hope to take better memories of the Salt Lake stadium from this visit.

New bowlers struggle to pass pressure test

Shalini Gupta
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CHANDIGARH: India won the ODI series against West Indies but Saturday’s defeat in New Chandigarh was symptomatic of the weaknesses the team has a year before the World Cup: poor catching and a lack of wicket-taking bowlers.

This series offered an opportunity to test fresh options in the absence of several established bowlers. Instead, it exposed the vulnerability of an inexperienced attack, particularly in the Powerplay and at the death, raising concerns over India’s ability to defend totals against quality opposition.

India were looking to sweep the series 3-0 at New Chandigarh. West Indies needed 44 runs from 24 balls with Mohammed Siraj yet to complete his quota of overs. However, India didn’t turn to the seasoned pacer and could not prevent the visitors from achieving the chase.

A penalty for slow over rate also left India with only four fielders outside the 30-yard circle. Shai Hope and Gudakesh Motie took the attack to Gurnoor Brar and Anshul Kamboj, completing the chase with 10 balls to spare. The 44 runs came off just 14 deliveries, dismantling India’s bowling plans as execution faltered.

With Jasprit Bumrah, Arshdeep Singh and Axar Patel at the Asian Games, it was an ideal opportunity for Brar, Naman Dhir, Aujib Nabi and Kamboj to strengthen their cases. However, the returns were largely underwhelming, leaving the team management with more questions.

Brar struggled to make a mark at his home ground, conceding 64 runs in 9.1 overs. In the second ODI in Guwahati, he went for 96 runs. Against England at Lord’s, he had conceded 97 runs in 10 wicketless overs. The recurring inability to contain runs or provide breakthroughs is a concern.

India head coach Gautam Gambhir had defended Brar after the Guwahati ODI win, stressing the importance of exposing young bowlers to challenging situations.



India players during a training session. PTI

“I know people will talk about his analysis. You can have him bowl in the middle overs, make him bowl defensively and get good stats. But the more he bowls in tough conditions, in tough situations, the better it is for Indian cricket,” he said.

Gambhir urged patience with the bowling unit, pointing to the batting-friendly surfaces. “When you bowl on this kind of a wicket, it’s not fair for the bowlers. We have got to give them something to work with. The first thing is that you need some sympathy and a bit of margin for the bowlers.”

Nabi, making his international debut in the second ODI, conceded 84 runs in 8.5 overs and struggled to find rhythm. Kamboj, who came in after Prasidh Krishna was injured, gave away 82 runs in nine overs on debut. It highlighted the challenge of translating domestic success into immediate international impact.

Selecting players such as Dhir and Kamboj shows India’s preference for batting depth. Kamboj’s ability to bat at No. 8 is an asset, but the value of an allrounder diminishes if the bowlers can’t deliver wickets under pressure.

Skipper Shubman Gill said injuries and scheduling had restricted India’s ability to field their preferred attack. “But at the same time, it’s something that is not in our hands. It’s a good chance for the other players.”

He was clear though about the areas that need improvement. “Bowling in the powerplay and at the death is something that has hurt us. If you don’t get off to a good start in the powerplay, we’ve seen that in the middle overs it’s not easy to take wickets or create chances with only four fielders outside,” Gill said. “I don’t think there is that much time to experiment. The combination that we want to play (in the World Cup), hopefully we get all the players available from the next series.”

The batting, with Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Gill and KL Rahul looking in good touch, appears to be in a reassuring position. But runs alone will not guarantee World Cup success.

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Don’t Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn’t just what’s trending.

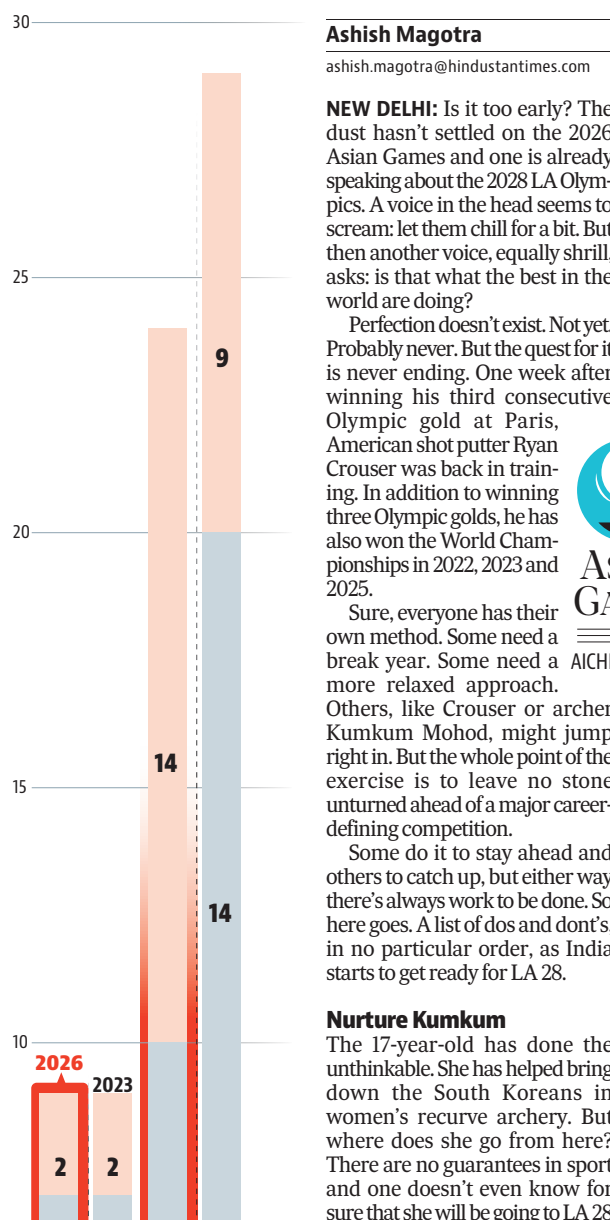
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Mission LA '28: A list of dos and don'ts

The 2026 Asian Games are over but the Olympics are less than two years away and preparing for them requires some urgency



(from the competitive domestic trials), but her talent is unquestionable. At this point, she is no longer the challenger. She is the one being chased and that can bring with it a different kind of anxiety. So much of archery is the process, and if anything that is what Kumkum will need to reinforce in the time to come. Let her do so.

Identify top talent

Kumkum isn't alone. And that is a good thing. Aman Sehrawat and Sujeet Kalkal have beaten the best in the world, as have some of the boxers. Squash player Anahat Singh, 18, is on the rise too. Suruchi Singh, 20, redeemed herself with a gold in the 10m air pistol mixed team, an Olympic event. Give them the system they deserve. Not just exposure trips but stability -- in coaching and in method. India, for instance, has 48 able-bodied athletes in the TOPS group. One might argue that is far too many. At the 2016 Rio Olympics, India won 2 medals. At Tokyo, the medal count went up to 7, including Neeraj Chopra's gold. And in Paris 2024, the count was 6 medals. So, getting into TOPS must be far more stringent. The same rule must apply to designating a sport as a priority.

Listen to Marijne, Nieva

Get them to speak to every coach of every discipline and make them listen. They know what to say and how to get results, (even in the Indian system). Build a coaching team that cares about results; about the athletes and not earning another Dronacharya award. Before Sjoerd Marijne (women's hockey) and Santiago Nieva (women's boxing) returned for their second stints, their respective sports were a mess. But they knew that the problem isn't talent.



Artistes perform during the closing ceremony of Asian Games. (Pic right) Qatar's equestrian rider Jassim Al Kuwari carries the OCA flag.



PTI/REUTERS

Rather, petty inter-personal rivalry was dragging down the teams. Cut that out and focus on the goal, which is medals. Make Marijne and Nieva mentor other coaches too.

A professional system

The period before any big event has somehow managed to coincide with an administrative mess. Olympic gold medalist Abhinav Bindra chaired a high-level government task force in 2025 that submitted a comprehensive 170-page report to the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports to completely overhaul and professionalise India's sports bureaucracy. But things have, frankly, gone the other way since then.

The report stated: "Neither SAI nor state departments have a dedicated sports administration service. Instead, positions are often filled by generalist civil servants or contractual staff lacking sector-specific expertise, resulting in ad hoc decision-making, weak institutional continuity and absence of long-term professionalisation."

Clean up the doping mess

It is like age fraud. It robs deserving athletes and it robs the nation of athletes who have an actual chance of winning. India really hasn't done anything about this for too long. In December 2025, India topped the global doping list for the third consecutive year. Some athletes chase the jobs and awards that top performances bring but they end up undermining the entire system. A brutal crackdown is the need of the hour.

Officials must step up

There is a post doing the rounds on X that shows Abhay Chautala, former Indian Olympic Association president in the warm-up area along with Wrestling Federation of India president Sanjay Singh, getting a photo clicked with Aman Sehrawat, who had just won gold in the 57kg. There are two problems with the act. First, administrators are not allowed in that area. Second, for the photo, they allegedly pulled in Anam Panghal, who was 10 minutes away from her gold medal match. These are

not isolated incidents. Indian sports administrators, as shown by such acts, often seem to feel that they own the sport and the athlete. It's about time this stops. At their core, administrators are facilitators and they need to get that too.

The right spend

India spends good money on elite athletes now. But most major cities still lack sporting infrastructure and good coaches. Unfortunately, this means that once the elite athlete retires, the search for the next one must begin all over again. The cumulative budget allocated to the sports ministry since 2014 exceeds ₹30,000 crore, rising from ₹1,643 crore in FY 2014-15 to a record ₹3,794 crore for FY 2025-26. Perhaps directing that spend better might yield even better results than the 85 medals won in Japan.

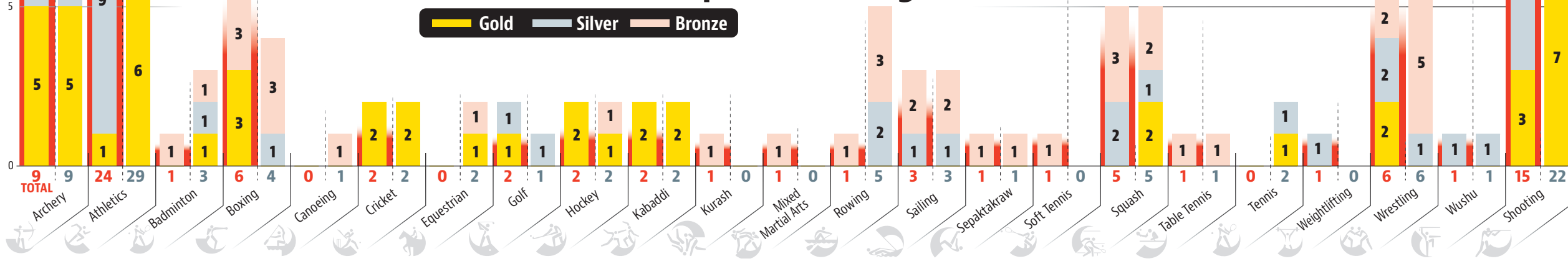
LA is less than two years away. The athletes who will stand on the podium there are deep into their preparation. So celebrate what went well, be honest about what did not and get back to work with urgency and purpose

ABHINAV BINDRA,
Olympic champion

• India did not win any medals in the two Asian Games in the following: cycling, esports, fencing, judo, karate, rugby 7s, sport climbing, surfing, swimming and volleyball. Teqball was introduced this time

• In Hangzhou, India won two silvers in chess, 1 silver in bridge and 2 bronze medals in roller sport. All three events were scrapped this time

How India's 2026 Asiad show compares with Hangzhou



Verstappen claims first win of year

SEPANG: Max Verstappen secured his and Red Bull's first win this year in chaotic conditions in a storm-delayed Bahrain GP in Malaysia. He came home 2.307 seconds ahead of championship leader Kimi Antonelli of Mercedes and Lewis Hamilton.

Djokovic stuns top seed Zverev

BEIJING: Novak Djokovic ousted Alexander Zverev from the China Open beating the top seed 4-6, 6-4, 6-4. The 39-year-old Serbian called it one of his best matches of the year, alongside his epic five-set win over Italy's Jannik Sinner to reach the Australian Open final.

Mukesh, Deep shine as Rol victory

SRINAGAR: Pacers Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep shared nine wickets as Rest of India beat reigning Ranji champions J&K by 167 runs to clinch the Irani Cup. Chasing 279, J&K needed to just hang in for a draw to lift the trophy by virtue of their 41-run first innings lead. But Mukesh (6/33) and Deep (3/25) ripped J&K's batting unit in a sensational spell to bowl the hosts out for 111.

India's historic hockey double holds a big hope for Olympics

Sandip Sikdar
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NEW DELHI: A year largely shaping up to be below par for the Indian men's hockey team. And the women were nursing the wounds of a major slump and disunity in the ranks. Yet, once they landed at the Asian Games, both squads swept away their blues. And for the first time, the Indian men's and women's teams won gold in the same Games.

The men for the first time also defended the title, while the women ended a 44-year wait—their only title had come in the 1982 New Delhi Asiad where women's hockey made its debut. This they did by toppling favourites and holders China. Having booked their tickets to the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, the teams can look forward to starting a promising era.

If the men's gold was expected, yet it was a story of redemption, and the victory was hard fought. In the Pro League — typically a testing ground — India languished in eighth place among nine teams, avoiding relegation.

Those struggles were carried to the grand stage in August when the Harmanpreet Singh-led outfit finished a dismal eighth in the World Cup. Despite being the only team to medal at the last two Olympics, the Craig Fulton-coached squad looked bereft of answers. But in Japan, the recalibration clicked. India stormed to



The Indian women hockey players upon their arrival at the Kempegowda International Airport in Bengaluru.

PTI

gold unbeaten. The turnaround wasn't just about mentality, but clinical execution. "The big area was in attack and finishing a lot of what we started collectively, not just individually," chief coach Fulton told HT on Sunday, reflecting on the team's revival after the World Cup. "We wanted to improve our PC attack and keep as many clean sheets as we possibly could. Our PC attack and defence were excellent. But (at the World Cup) we weren't scoring enough and we were conceding. That ended up being the difference."

Fulton dispelled the notion that Asian dominance is a given for India. "People are getting so used to us winning in Asia now. But when I first joined (2023), we had won one gold in the previous 24 years," said the South African. "You can see how difficult it is to

compete and win gold in this tournament. We wanted to make our own piece of Indian hockey history. The cherry on the cake was that the girls won their final."

The women's triumph was some resurrection. They landed in Japan as next best to world No.4 China. There were signs of revival when they drew against the Paris Olympics silver medalists at the World Cup. The women's team had endured a low period. After missing qualification for the 2024 Olympics, they endured a volatile period marked by the exit of their Dutch coach Janneke Schopmann and her successor Harend Singh. They were also relegated from the Pro League.

The catalyst for turnaround was the return of Sjoerd Marijne in January. The Dutchman was the architect of India's brilliant fourth

place at the 2021 Tokyo Olympics. With renewed focus on fitness and backed by sports scientists, Marijne orchestrated a rapid revival.

India secured a lifeline by qualifying for the World Cup, then won the Nations Cup to return to the Pro League. At the World Cup, India's revival was already underway. They drew against China, Australia and England, thrashed South Africa and beat Germany to finish fifth. That momentum led to an unblemished run at the Games. India dismantled every opponent before edging out China.

Former India chief coach Neil Hawgood, who guided the women to the 2016 Olympic qualification, after 36 years, praised Marijne. "Sjoerd got them to peak at the Games, which was a priority while preparing for at the World Cup," the Aussie told HT from Perth. "This time (two years) is a unique opportunity Sjoerd has created for his push to the Olympics."

Hawgood said the next steps must help sustain the momentum. "Expose the talent from below and widen the squad so that you can compare what a player may look like with 24 months of growth, compared to maybe some that have reached the ceiling," he said. Fulton said: "We're looking to bring in a few younger players. We will see who needs a break or rest."

For decades, the women had seen ups and downs. Now, alongside the men, they have time to target the biggest accolade: Olympic success.

Young Indian archers hit the mark, make a point

Rutvik Mehta
rutvik.mehta@htlive.com

MUMBAI: Across the previous three Asian Games of 2023, 2018 and 2014, India's most bankable sports to fill the most chunky pie and the most valuable golden cherry in the medals cake were the usual suspects: athletics and shooting.

In 2026? Archery.

Five gold, two silver and two bronze medals at Aichi-Nagoya might be the same quantity as 2023 Hangzhou. But the difference in quality stands out for a couple of reasons, not least the two quotas for India in compound (the only one on offer) and recurve for the 2028 LA Olympics.

First, even as shooting (3 gold in 2026, down from 7 in 2023) and athletics (1, down from 6) dropped in gold standard, archery kept up. Their five-star podium finishes were the best across sports, with shooting and boxing (also 3) next.

Second, while archery's 2023 gold and medal haul had a large compound tune to it (all 5 gold and 7 medals from 9), 2026's returns had a bigger recurve roar. With individual and team champions in women, mixed and men's team silver medalists and an individual men's bronze medalist, the discipline with five Olympic events made a big step up.

To the extent that Neeraj Chauhan's medal from the all-India bronze medal contest almost felt like a bit of an underachievement. It wasn't (he is only the second individual man to do so), yet such were the lofty rides by the women's team, its champion Kumkum Mohod, and the men's and mixed teams.

Compound had a slight downturn, failing to defend two of its five golds (both individual). It showed other Asian countries will no longer let India run away in the new Olympic event, much like India's recurve archers caught up with and even overtook the Koreans in the traditional Olympic event.

That Indian archers hit the mark with a 12-member squad in



Indian women's recurve team celebrates after winning gold at the Asian Games at the Okazaki Central Park.

REUTERS

which nine were Asian Games debuts makes it all the more creditable. Four of the six women were 21 or under, and three of them were teens, including 17-year-old Kumkum. Five of the six in the men's group were 25 or under.

"Yes, experience works, but young talent can also be much better," said Jiwanjot Singh Teja, India's Dronacharya award-winning national coach. "They are sharper, bolder, and intelligent. If we get more young people in the team, we will get better results."

Getting younger people on the team isn't always guaranteed as domestic trials dictate that. The Asian Games validated the selection process that kept out both the Hangzhou individual compound champions and more seasoned archers in recurve.

Much work also went on behind the scenes to get these archers to deliver as a team after the trials in May. With only two World Cup stages to compete together, a lot of emphasis was placed on the two pre-Games national camps. Udhay Singh, put in charge of the recurve women's team because his trainee Kirti Sharma topped the trials, made Kumkum, Kirti, 19,

and Ankita Bhakat, 28, do everything together—practice, eat, talk—in the camps.

"The World Cups made us realise that we needed to work on our team building, and that was my focus in the camp," said Udhay. All the coaches involved, personal and national, as well as other stakeholders were in sync.

"I would also give credit to the national coach with the team, all the other coaches there, the Archery Association of India, TOPS and SAI," said Prafull Dange, Kumkum's coach who watched his trainee create history in Japan from Amravati. "Everyone played their part in this result."

This result, though, is done. Two quotas are booked for LA 2028, and three gold medals won in Olympic events. Success at the Asian Games, even amid a rich field, is one thing, and replicating it at the Olympics is another. Indian archery has yet to medal at the Olympic stage, and that is the ultimate aim. Not least for the history-making gold medalists at the Asian Games.

"Our archers are doing really well now," said Teja. "We just need to continue with the same environment."

No financial burden on AIFF, Chaubey tells members

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KOLKATA: The All India Football Federation (AIFF) will not have to bear any immediate financial burden of the three home friendlies played in this international window. Federation members were informed of this by AIFF president Kalyan Chaubey at the special general body meeting here on Sunday.

For the first time, India are hosting friendlies with top-50

teams, all of whom were part of the last World Cup. According to AIFF officials, the three matches could cost between ₹80 crore to ₹85 crore.

Representatives of three state units who attended the meeting confirmed this to HT speaking separately. No money from AIFF has been used so far, one of the three mentioned above quoted Chaubey as saying. Not authorised to speak with the media, the officials did not want to be named. When asked, Chaubey

said he did not wish to comment.

These matches, Chaubey said, underscored AIFF's decision in December 2022 to opt out of hosting the 2027 Asian Cup. "We would have needed at least five stadiums with each requiring a lot of investment to bring them up to standards demanded by AFC (Asian Football Confederation). It was not possible then."

"It needed 16-hour work days for over one month to get the Salt Lake stadium ready to the standards demanded by CBF (the

Brazilian federation). It needed a lot of help from the state government," said Chaubey. Along with sports minister Dr Indranil Khan, West Bengal chief minister Suvenud Adhikari attended Saturday's match.

The special general body decided that AIFF elections will be held on December 20, likely in New Delhi. Former state election commissioner of Haryana, Rajeev Sharma, has been appointed as electoral officer, AIFF said in a media release.

"In four years, we could invite Kuwait and Lebanon to the 2023 SAFF Championship which was a first. We got India an invitation to play in the 2025 CAFA Nations Cup, also a first, resumed our ties with the Merdeka Cup and got Brazil to come to India," said Chaubey. "As a former player, I know how important it is for our national team to play against quality opponents. In our time, we would sometimes play a coaches selection to prepare for international assignments."